

THE NINE LIVES OF ASHCAT

A Mystery of Hollowmere

SparkyGames

Adapted from the video game *The Nine Lives of Ashcat*.

This book, like the game it grew from, was made with substantial help from artificial intelligence. We think honesty about that is worth more than mystique.

All persons, cats, guilds, geese, and bureaucracies of death depicted herein are fictional. The Mere, in particular, does not exist, and would prefer you kept believing that.

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A LEDGER OF YEARS

Accounts referred to in this file, oldest first. Entries are reckoned from the year of the telling.

- 40 years ago* The working at the Mere. The seam is sewn.
- 40 years ago* The Tatterstage loses its lead player.
- 37 years ago* Widow Sarn of Hemlock Row, stitcher, drowned.
- 30 years ago* A parcel is posted, and does not arrive.
- 15 years ago* A kitten is taken in at Needle Lane.
- This spring* Elspeth Vane orders new thread.
- This autumn* The night this file begins.

The reader is invited to check the arithmetic. Everyone else in this city does.

Prologue: The Night of the Kettle

Dusk over Hollowmere, and the lamps going up one by one, like the city buttoning its coat.

From the ridge of the Fish-Giver's roof I can see most of what matters: the chimney forests of the Shambles, the canals, the fog beginning its evening climb up from the Mere the way it always does. Somewhere below, a door slams. Somewhere else, a man says something unkind about a horse. The city, in other words, in working order.

She puts the kettle on when the lamps go up. I am punctual. She is predictable. The arrangement works, and has worked for fifteen years, which is a long time in a cat.

Her name, for the record — because tonight of all nights the record matters — is Elspeth Vane. The city calls her the Needle of Hollowmere, mostly behind her back, always with respect. Four streets from here she is at her table under the lamp, mending something the city has brought her that the city could not mend itself.

And I am Ash. Her cat. Other titles have been proposed over the years: familiar, companion, mouser-in-residence, *that animal*. I answer to none of them and come to all of them, provided there is a fire on.

Tonight calls for a gift. A vole, ideally. Voles say what flowers cannot.

* * *

There. Under the chimney pot. Fat, smug, unaware.

I go low. The tiles are still day-warm under my belly, and the wind is doing me the courtesy of blowing the wrong way for the vole and the right way for me. There is a red feeling that lives at the bottom of a cat, older than cities, and it comes up through me now, the world narrowing to one point with fur on it. It is the one part of me that has not aged.

The rest of me has. I wait longer than I once needed to, because waiting is cheap and the other thing is not. I let it come two tiles nearer than a young cat would have troubled to.

Then the vole makes its argument, which is brief, and mostly consists of running. I make mine. Mine is better, by about a whisker. There is a scuffle among the chimney pots which I will describe, in the interest of dignity, as *professional*, and then it is over, and the vole has been acquired. Thoughtfully dead. Arranged neatly, carried gently.

I sat afterward longer than the work deserved, and did not mention it to anybody.

She will say “not on the table,” and mean *thank you*. She has said it every time. I have put it on the table every time.

I take the rooftop road toward home with the vole warm in my mouth and the evening going purple at its edges. There is a gap over the alley at Cooper’s that I used to cross without consulting anybody, including myself. I stood at the edge of it and looked, and counted the four seconds she taught me, and went round by the wall instead.

I spent that hour thinking about a sunbeam I remember from March. I want that noted. Whatever else the record says of me, let it say I was happy.

* * *

Below me now: the Shambles, shut for the night, stalls sleeping under canvas. Eight bells sound from the tower, the whole count, one to eight, dropped into the fog like coins into a well.

There used to be a ninth bell. There is no ninth any more. Nobody remembers when that changed, and nobody finds it strange, and I have never met anyone but me who noticed there was a gap where a sound should be.

And between two chimneys, strung across the dark like a hair caught in a comb: a thread of silver light. Humming.

Everything alive trails a thread, if you have the eyes for it. They run through this city out of windows, along gutters, wound around wrists and doorposts and gateposts. She calls the whole crossing underlay of it the Weft. She stitches with it; I have only ever been able to look. Hers I know by heart: silver, with a particular twist to it, like handwriting.

This one is silver too. And it is nobody's I know.

I did not chase the silver thread. A cat of my age, carrying a gift, does not go haring off across the roofline after every unexplained glimmer. I looked at it. I considered it. I made a note in the ledger of things that are wrong tonight and went on my way, and the lie I told myself about not *wanting* to chase it weighed nothing at all.

Almost nothing.

* * *

Street level, Needle Lane, and the fog rolls up from the Mere to meet me, and the shadows deepen, deep enough to wear, if you know how. I have been a rumor most of my life.

Something small and hungry climbs out of the gutter: a swallowed lantern of a thing, all glow and appetite.

It does not come at my throat. It comes at the lie, the one about not wanting to chase the thread, and it brightens on the way in, the way they do when they have found a fed one.

I would like to tell you I handled it with grace. What happened is that I went low and let it overshoot, and the fog was on my side, and I took it where a thing made mostly of light does not expect to be taken. It went back down the drain dimmer than it came up.

I sat longer than I meant to afterward, putting my coat back in order, and that was when I noticed the quiet.

No pigeons.

Understand: pigeons are never quiet. The roosts over Needle Lane keep up a continuous session of complaint and scandal from dusk until dawn, and I have slept under that noise my whole life. It was not there. The roofline sat against the sky, empty as a shelf.

* * *

The lamps on Needle Lane are lit in the wrong order.

You would have to live here to see it. The Lamplighters walk a sequence, every night: third lamp, then first, then the one by the pump. The order is the point. I have heard one of them say so, on a doorstep, to an apprentice: *we light them in an order, lad, and the order is the stitch*. Tonight the lane is lit dark-bright-dark-dark-bright, a signature forged by someone who has only ever seen it written.

The Lamplighters never miss. The dog at Number Twelve is awake, I can smell him being awake, and he does not bark, which he has never once in his loud and tedious life failed to do.

And halfway down the lane, the fog stops being fog.

It has sleeves. It has a collar. It has the shape of a person who is not in it. And that is when I see what has been done to the lane: window-threads, door-threads, the little tethers of household luck, all of them *cut*, and sliding through the dark toward this one standing shape like water finding a drain, and the shape gathering them in.

Not a dead person. An absent one. Rag-wraiths, the roofs call them, and the roofs are careful about that difference even when the day-side is not.

It turns what it has instead of a face toward me. Whatever unpicked these lamps is still at its work, and I am standing in its light.

I fought it. I will say this once, plainly: I went in with everything I had left in me, and then with the thing of hers I carry, the pale cold weight under my ribs that is not mine and never was. I felt it go out of me and do nothing. That is a feeling I had no name for then.

It was above my weight and it knew it. Ten years ago it would still have been above my weight. In the end I did the intelligent thing, which the stories never put in: I slipped away. Three streets before I stopped, and I stopped because my legs decided it, not me, and I stood in a doorway with my sides going like a bellows and waited to be a cat again.

Nothing followed. Nothing was missing.

And yet. It was not hunting me. All that gathered-up stolen thread, and it spent none of it on a cat. It was *working*, and I did

not know yet at what.

* * *

Her window is ahead now.

The shutters are closed.

I stood in the road and could not make that mean anything. They are old green shutters and they fold back against the brick, and they have been folded back every evening of my life: in rain, in frost, in the week the chimney caught. She did not close them for weather. She did not close them for company. She did not close them.

Something in me tried to file it and could not find the drawer. So I did what anybody does with a fact that will not sit down. I told myself she was out.

Two ways home from here. The long way passes the Lamplighters' hall, and whatever silenced the lamps went wrong there first. The fast way is over the fences.

I took the long way. Eleven minutes, perhaps twelve. Because the route had a wrongness at the head of it, and because her voice said *look before you leap, Ash, it is the entire difference between brave and stupid*, and because the fences are a young cat's road and I had already had my breath taken off me once that night. All three are true. I have had a long time to decide which one I was obeying, and I have not decided.

The hall stood open. Door wide, ladders racked, coats on their pegs. The kettle on their little stove was cold, and a guild hall's kettle is never cold. Forty men and women walk out of this room every evening and light a city. Nobody was in it.

Caught on a lamp-hook by the door, glinting where it had snagged: a thread of silver.

Her stitching. I would know it under floodwater. She was here — tonight, in this room, my witch, who has not walked out on an evening in years. Why was she *here*?

I ran then. Out of the hall and eleven streets home, and I do not remember eight of them. The fog thinning near the Mere. Ordinary houses, ordinary gates, a cat crossing an ordinary city at a speed that was going to cost him. Her street. Her gate. Her drainpipe, the one I

have used nine hundred times, and up — slower than nine hundred times, my back legs arguing the whole way — and in through the workroom window —

and the house is doing the wrong thing with sound.

A kettle, screaming. And nobody going to it.

* * *

The workroom first, and the workroom is wrong. The threads on the walls, forty years of her work hung like a garden, cut. Every one of them snipped at the same height, cleanly, as if by someone *tidying*.

The parlor door stands open, and I do not go through it. Not yet. I stop at the threshold, low, and I look.

Something is standing in the parlor doorway on the far side, wearing the room.

It is person-shaped the way a coat on a hook is person-shaped, and it is made of *her* threads: it has been pulling forty years of her work out of the walls and putting it *on*. Where the light of the hearth should catch a face there is a weave, still moving, still settling, thread finding thread with a sound like the smallest rain.

That is the part I will keep, of everything that night: it looked at me, whatever it looks with, and it *decided I was not an interruption*, and it went back to its work.

Every hair I have is standing up. Good. Let them.

I went for it. Of course I went for it. She was somewhere past that doorway and the thing between us was wearing her wards. I remember the first spring off the floorboards, and that it was a poor one, and that I made it anyway. I remember the weave turning, unhurried, and a sleeve coming around like a laden clothesline let go in a gale. I remember the cold weight under my ribs going out of me a second time that night, all of it at once, everything of hers I had left to spend, and it was not enough, and the room went sideways, and then the cold came up through the floor in a way that floors do not do.

I want to tell you dying hurts. It would make better telling. What it does is *leave*: the cold goes first, then the noise, then the part of you that was worried about the noise. What is left over found itself

standing in a corridor that was all filing and no building, in a light the color of four in the morning.

Nothing hurt. I found this deeply suspicious.

A desk. A lamp. A queue of one, and the one was me.

The being behind the desk was thin the way a ruled line is thin, translucent at the cuffs, with spectacles that had given up asking to be needed. He did not look up. Around him, shelves went away in every direction that shelves can go, and some that they cannot, all of them full, every folder tied with grey ribbon.

"Name?"

"Ashcat," I said. "Of Needle Lane." It seemed a night for the full formal.

"Needle Lane." Something moved behind the spectacles that was almost interest. "Yes. We have had a busy evening from Needle Lane."

He wrote. The pen made the sound of winter. Then he reached the column that mattered, and stopped.

"Nine allotted." He said it to the paper, not to me. He turned the sheet over, as though the back of it might explain; the back of it did not. "I have not filed a nine since I was at a much smaller desk. Vane's familiar." A pause you could have hung a coat on. "One spent."

He did not say whose the busy evening was. I did not ask. Every whisker I own said this was a room where questions were expensive.

"The arrangement, since it is your first," said the Clerk, to the paper. "Deaths are appointments. Tonight you had one." He said it without cruelty, the way a man reads weather. "The first is complimentary. Do consider it a courtesy rather than a habit."

The stamp came down. It was, I noticed, a paw print. Neither of us remarked on this.

The stairs up were longer than the fall down.

* * *

Hearing came back first. Floorboards under one cheek. The smell of cold hearth. Four paws — count them — four. Whatever had been standing in the doorway was not standing in the doorway.

Get up, Ash.

The parlor.

Elspeth in her chair. The light gone out of her hands.

...

The kettle was still screaming. It had been screaming this whole time, and I did not hear it until now. She hates it when it does that.

I took it off the fire. One paw, on the handle, the way I had watched her do it ten thousand times from the hearthrug. It took three tries. Nobody will ever know.

And then the house was quiet, and there was nothing else to take off any fire.

I got up on the arm of her chair, which I am not allowed to do, and nobody told me to get down. Her hands were folded in her lap, and her face was not frightened, and not surprised, and not anything. Between a kettle boiling and a kettle screaming is no time at all. Whoever did this to her did it in that, in her own parlor, in her own light: faster than any needle honestly goes.

Fifteen years. Every evening. She always came to the window.

I do not know how to be a cat that nobody is expecting.

I stayed on the arm of the chair a long time, and I will not tell you how long, because I do not know. The shutters stayed shut. At some point I found myself looking at the sewing table. Her red kerchief lay on it, folded, washed that morning, waiting to go back around her neck, where it had lived so long it was less a garment than a fact of her.

I put my head through it. Nobody tied it. It stays.

The thread at my chest, the tether every familiar wears, hers, cut like everything else in this house.

Not quite.

One strand left. Thin as spite. Running out from under the window, over the sill where her geraniums used to argue with the slugs, down into the fog, into the city.

I looked at it a long time. Outside, eight bells rang somewhere, and no ninth.

Then that is where we are going.

Part I

Wax and Wick

Chapter 1

The Carrying and the Wake

Three witches came at first light.

Nobody sent for them. I asked, later, how they knew.

“Nine seats,” Cardew said. “One rope between the nine of us. A seat goes out, the weight comes onto the rest, and you feel it in your wrists whether you’re minding or not.” She had felt it at dusk, in her own kitchen, with a pan in her hand.

I asked why she had waited until morning.

“You don’t walk Needle Lane in the dark. Not while something is still —”

They did not knock. Witches do not knock at a house where a witch has died; a knock asks a question, and the house has already answered it. The door opened to Mother Cardew’s hand, and behind her came two young ones I did not know, one carrying folded linen, undyed, and one carrying nothing but her own held breath.

I was on the arm of the chair. I had been on the arm of the chair all night. I did not get down.

A dead stitcher is watched until the tide, because work with nobody answering for it can be unpicked a second time. Nobody had told me that. I had been sitting the office since the kettle.

Cardew is the eldest of the Circuit, and it was eight seats now, though nobody had said so aloud yet in that room. She is small and grey and folded, like something kept a long time in a drawer, and her eyes went around the parlor once, at working speed, and

I watched her see everything. The cut threads. The cold kettle off the fire, which nobody could account for and nobody asked about. Elspeth.

They lifted her the way you lift someone who might wake. That is the thing I will allow them, all three, forever. And the young one who had been carrying her own breath let it go, once, in the doorway, in a small ragged sound she will be embarrassed about for years. It was the correct sound.

At the doorway, with the linen and its burden through it, Cardew stopped. She looked back at the walls, at forty years of workings hanging cut and dead at one tidy height, and she said:

“Who did this to the room.”

It was not a question. Burglars take things, and nothing here was taken: not the silver thimbles, not the bolt of moon-colored cloth worth a bargeman’s year, not the rings on the hand of the woman in the chair. Somebody had come into the Needle’s own parlor and *unpicked* it, and left everything of value except the value.

And then Cardew was looking at me.

Everyone else was looking at the floor. That is what people do around a dead witch’s cat. Cardew looked straight at me, colleague to colleague, and waited.

I had one chance to be taken seriously, and I knew it. A cat who yowls is comforted. A cat who performs is petted. I sat up on the chair arm and told it, all of it, in order, as she taught me anything worth saying should go: the lamps, the pigeons, the emptied hall, her thread on the lamp-hook, the fog with sleeves. The shape in the parlor doorway that decided I was not an interruption.

Cats can speak to those who trouble to listen, and most people do not trouble. Cardew listened the whole way through without moving, and when I finished she was quiet a long moment.

Then she said, quieter, to nobody: “Again.”

She put the word down like something she had not meant to be holding. I filed it. *Again* means *before*, and a thing that has done this before has habits, and habits can be found.

At the door, with her girls and their burden already in the lane, she turned once more.

“Mind the room, cat,” she said. “Rooms hold a while. After that —”

She did not finish it. I think the end of that sentence had worn off her a long time ago and she had stopped missing it.

Then they were gone into the fog with her, and the house was mine, and it was nobody's.

* * *

The day-side came at nine. Two constables, not unkind. The younger one wiped his boots on the mat, which I record in his favour.

They tried the window catch. They looked at the hearth. The older one asked whether she had any family. All around them hung forty years of workings cut through at one tidy height, and they stood in the middle of it and saw an old woman dead in her chair behind a door locked from the inside.

"Heart, most like," the older one said. "At her age."

The younger one wrote that down, stepped twice over a thing under the window I had not yet found, and they were gone in ten minutes.

Nor is there anybody on the night-side whose office this is. I went through them one at a time, on the hearthrug, and then went through them again, because I did not care for the answer.

* * *

I minded the room.

I went over it the way she went over a hem: slowly, twice, against the nap. It took most of the morning, and I had not slept, and I am not young. A cat's advantages in an investigation are that we are low, we are patient, and we are invisible to people who believe importance has a minimum height.

The parlor smelled of cold hearth and geranium and her, I will not write about that part, and under everything, faint, of something that did not belong: pond-bottom. Old rope. Patient water. The Mere has a smell, and the Mere does not come up to Thimblefield, and it had been in this room.

And under the window, where the curtain hem brushes the boards, I found the candle stub.

Beeswax. Burned an inch down and pinched out, and stamped near the base with the mark of the bee: the Chandlers' Guild, who hold the monopoly on every honest light in this city.

That stub had no business existing in that room. Elspeth burned tallow her whole life, good witch-made tallow, smoky and stubborn like her, and she called beeswax *the rich man's smell* and would not have it in the house. Somebody else's light had been in this parlor.

And out of that inch of wax I built the man who left it. What follows is a thing I built, not a thing I found, and I am setting it down the way I had it.

An inch of beeswax is about an hour. So: somebody was in this parlor an hour before she died, with a light of his own, brought in his own pocket, because he did not mean to sit in the dark and did not mean to use hers. He was comfortable enough to wait. Then he pinched the wick out with his fingers and did not trouble to take the stub away.

An hour of lit window on Needle Lane, with forty neighbours who have nothing better to do than notice. It should have been seen.

Then I remembered the shutters, closed for the first time in fifteen years, and thought: of course. He closed them. He shut the lane out, lit his own candle, and settled down to wait for her.

I was pleased with that.

I sat with the stub between my paws while the light came up grey, and began the way she began a working, with a naming of parts.

Item: a silver thread on a lamp-hook in an emptied hall. She was there the night she died, and I did not know why, and hall-kettles do not go cold on their own.

Item: a street of cut threads, and a thing wearing them, that worked and did not hunt.

Item: quiet pigeons. Bought quiet or frightened quiet, and I did not know which.

Item: an hour of beeswax, pinched out, stamped with the bee.

Item: the word *again*.

Item: one strand of her, uncut, running out under the window into the city. Mine now. My inheritance, along with this house, and the arrangement of my entire life, cancelled.

Item: the cold weight under my ribs, spent twice on the night she died and still less than it was. What a cat has of his own comes back with meat and sleep. That does not. She put it into me out of her own evenings, and when I spend it I feel it leave, and nothing I can do makes any more.

On the chimney breast there is a cork board where she pinned the city's wants: *Mistress Vane, the churn's gone sour-hearted; Needle, the gate wards, before Lady's Day if you can.* A city that had no idea what it had. I got up and looked at that board a long time.

Then I knocked her pincushion off the shelf, took the longest pin in my teeth, and pinned the candle stub to the board, dead center.

My whole job used to be: be somewhere warm at the correct time. All right, then. New job.

* * *

They gave her to the tide at the turn of the evening. That is the custom.

The quay at the Shambles' edge was fuller than I had expected and emptier than she deserved. The Lamplighters sent four, everyone the hall has left, I would understand later. They stood in a row with their ladders shouldered and their lamps lit at half-wick, which is their mourning.

The Magpie Exchange sent a bird I did not yet know, watchful on a bollard, with one respectful button laid on the stones before her. There were cats on the roofline, a dozen at least, sitting the way we sit at funerals, which is exactly the way we sit anywhere else.

And the Chandlers' Guild sent one man, early, in very good black, standing precisely where he could be seen being sorry.

I noted him. The board on the chimney breast noted him.

The rite is the seam. Mother Cardew took the bone needle and the grey thread, and began the shroud's last seam in Elspeth's own pattern — and four stitches in, she stopped.

She stood there on the quay with the linen raised in her unsteady hands, an old woman in front of a city, and I watched her courage fail in a way I would not wish on an enemy. "I don't know her hand," she said. Quietly. To the linen. "Sixty years, and I don't know her hand."

Nobody moved. The tide turned underneath us — you can feel it through stone, through the pads of your feet, the moment the sea changes its mind — and the seam stood open four stitches, and the Needle of Hollowmere lay waiting on her bier for somebody who knew her stitch.

I have watched those hands from a windowsill every evening of my life. Through fog, through frost-flowers, through my own reflection: the needle down, the thread drawn, the little tug at the end of each stitch like a word ending. I know the hand better than I know my own name — which she also gave me, so it comes to the same thing.

I got up onto the bier.

Somebody started forward to stop me — some notion of decency, a cat on a shroud — and Cardew said, “Let him,” in a voice that ended the subject for a generation.

I will not pretend my part was neat. A cat is not built for needle-work: I pushed the bone needle with a paw, drew the thread in my teeth, and the first stitch took me three tries, like the kettle, and nobody will ever know that either, except that I am writing it here, so now everyone will, and I find I do not mind. The pattern was in me the way routes are in me. Her hand, remembered by my whole body at once. Down, through, draw, tug — *a word ending* — and again, along the linen, while the tide stood slack and the lamps burned at half-wick and a row of cats on a warehouse roof watched a colleague work.

The seam closed. The tide took her without discussion, the way she would have wanted — no speeches, no splash, the grey linen going down through the grey water until it was a paleness, and then a memory, and then the sea seeing to its accounts.

One lamplighter forgot not to salute.

Then Mother Cardew did the thing for which I will forgive her everything else, always. In front of the guild delegates and the roofline and the man in very good black, she bent down, it cost her; I heard her knees pay it, and she tied a small grey knot into the thread at my chest, where the whole Weft could see it.

“A debt,” she said. “Mine. You’ll know.”

And then, walking me back up the quay while the crowd made itself busy elsewhere, low, for my ears alone:

“It has happened twice before. Both times a stitcher. The Tat-

terstage's lead player, forty years gone — one of ours, though the playbills never knew it. And Widow Sarn of Hemlock Row, three winters after. She sewed sails. She taught half the quay to mend nets. Her terrier sat out two winters on her step, waiting to be let in."

We went a few steps.

"Nobody looked, either time. The Circuit closed the files. I signed the closing." She did not finish that thought out loud. "I'm too old to open them again. Too watched, as well."

I asked who would look now.

"Seven of us," she said, "holding what she held. Ten years of her work, and there's a thing under this town that wants a hand on it every hour of the night." She turned her own hand over and looked at it. "There's no spare hand in this city to go asking who. So nobody will look. I'd rather you heard me say it than worked it out slow, the way I —"

She let the water have the end of that one.

She stopped at the sea-wall and looked at the water a while.

"You are neither." A pause. "You were her ninth, you know. She'd never say what she meant by the count." Another. "Find who did this, cat. I'll hold what doors I have left."

Ninth. I filed the word next to *again*, in the drawer of things said to me that were heavier than the sayer knew.

* * *

Home, then, to a house with nobody in it.

Night had come down while the city walked back from the water. The lamps went up along her street. Most of them: two dark. I came in through the workroom window and sat among the cut threads and let the house be quiet at me.

The kettle sat where I had left it, off the fire, on the cold hearth-stone, and of everything in that room it was the wrongest thing, because a kettle off the fire is a kettle *finished*, and nothing here is finished. Nothing here has even begun.

I went up to the board, where the candle stub hung from its pin, and beside it set the things the day had brought, each on its own pin: a thread of grey shroud-linen, for two women nobody looked

for. A gull feather, for the man in very good black. And through the loop of it, where I could reach it with my eyes from the hearthrug, the end of the one uncut strand.

Somewhere out there was a shape wearing my witch's work. Somewhere nearer was whoever lit its way with an hour of fine wax and pinched the flame out afterward, the way you put away a tool you mean to use again.

Again.

I slept on the hearthrug, because the chair was not mine to fill, and dreamed of her table years ago: a chart of the harbor wall half-sewn under lamplight, a much smaller cat asleep in the middle of it, deployed as a paperweight, and her voice above me somewhere, amused, saying something I could not hear yet.

I woke with my paws working at the rug, stitching nothing, in her hand.

In the morning I went to find the Magpie.

Chapter 2

The Thread Itself

I said I went to find the Magpie in the morning. That was true, but it was the second true thing. The first was the thread.

It had not gone anywhere in the night. Thread waits. The one strand nobody cut still ran out from under the window, silver going grey where it crossed the sill's shadow, and out into a city that walked through it all day without feeling so much as a cobweb. I sat under the window and recalled her teaching: *magic is needlework, Ash. The Weft is every thread of everything, crossing. To follow a thread you do not pull it — pulling tells the far end. You lay a paw on it, lightly, and you let it tell you which way it is cold. And learn the difference between fraying and cutting, because the world will not teach it to you. Anything frays a thread. Weather frays, and wear frays, and teeth fray, and time frays everything it is left alone with. But cutting one clean is not a skill. It is a right. The Weft knows who held the right, and it keeps the entry either way.*

I put a paw on the line. It was cold toward the city. I went the way it was cold.

The strand ran the rooftops, and it ran them the clean way: chimney to chimney, along ridgelines, over the one plank bridge between the tannery and the ropewalk. Whoever owned the far end of this thread knew Hollowmere the way I know it: not the streets, which anyone can learn, but the *overstreets*, the roof-roads. I made a note in the ledger, and the note read: *it travels like a cat*, and I did not like the note, so I turned the page.

Halfway across the Shambles' roofline I found the thread being

robbed.

A gutter-wisp — fat, this one, prosperous — had wound itself around the strand where it sagged between two chimneys, and it was *drinking*: sipping the faint hum off the silver. Not trespass. Grave-robbing. That hum was the last of her moving in the world, and I am not able to write down what I did to that wisp. It went back down its drain unlit. The hum came back to the thread, faint, like a tune through a wall.

The thread dropped to street level at the roofline's end, ran along Needle Lane's gutter — past the wrong lamps, past Number Twelve, where the dog watched me pass in a silence we had both agreed never to discuss — and then it turned, and ran straight for the Mere.

And the fog stood up to meet it.

The Mere fog is not the river fog. River fog is weather; it has somewhere else to be. The Mere fog comes up the streets at its own pace and does not disperse so much as *decline to leave*. The lane it held that morning it held wall to wall. Every window in it dark. Every thread in it slack. The strand ran into that fog low and taut.

There was no fighting through it, because there was nothing to fight, only the line to lose. So I crossed it the way she taught me a city must sometimes be crossed, which is slowly. I waited out each curb while the fog breathed. I went unseen along the stretches where being seen felt like a bad idea, and going unseen is not a trick; it is holding still in the cold with your shoulders down until the wanting to move goes quiet. I was two hours in that lane. I am fifteen years old, and it cost me a week of mornings.

And twice, at crossings where the cold came up through my feet with that pond-bottom patience I had smelled in her parlor, something of hers went out of me and the cold drew back, the way a tide decides you are not yet due. I did not spend it. I felt it go, both times, and there was less of her in me afterward than there had been.

I came out the far side of the fog with wet whiskers, an intact line, and a shake in both forelegs I could not talk out of them.

The thread ran three more streets, down the terraces, and out onto the sea-wall at the Mereside edge.

And stopped.

Mid-air. Over the water. A cat's height above the black glass of

the Mere, the strand ran out past the wall, thinned to a hair, and ended, not frayed, not worn, not melted in the manner of workings that fail. *Cut*. One clean bite, on a slant, the way scissors leave silk. I stood on the sea-wall with my paw on the last of her and looked at that ending a long time.

Almost nothing can see a thread. Of the things that can, almost none can touch one, and of those, almost none can cut one clean; her own wards took her forty years and a bone needle to tie and untie. Whoever went out over that water had seen the strand following them, had known it for what it was, and had turned and cut it *one clean stroke*. And they had done it out over open water, where nothing walks.

And the right to cut her work was hers, and she is in the sea. Whoever bit through this strand had no standing to.

And I understood what the strand had been all along. Not her tether to me, that was cut in the parlor, and hangs at my chest still. This was a thread of the *work*: one strand of the forty years the shape had pulled off her walls and wound around itself, snagged on the sill as it left, paying out behind it like a hem coming undone as it walked.

I had not been following her. There is no her to follow. I had been following what *wore* her, and it had felt the line come taut at last, and turned, and bitten through my last road to it.

That is why the strand ran toward the Mere.

The Mere lay flat as a ledger to the horizon-fog. Black water; the drowned thing under it that day-side children are told is a story and night-side children are told to stop asking about, sewn shut below the surface forty years ago by somebody's needle. The fog on the far shore held its shapes, and one of them, for a moment, was the size of a man, and then was not, and I wrote it down anyway.

So the thread was not a road. Very well. It was still an answer, and it was this: the killer reads the Weft, travels the overstreets, cuts clean, and did not want to be followed across the water. A trail closed on purpose is a trail worth money, and things worth money have a fence, and the Shambles keeps the best fence in the city.

Which brings me, second, to the Magpie.

The trouble with visiting the Magpie Exchange is that you must bring something, and the trouble with bringing something, if you are a cat, is that you own nothing. What I carry I carry in my shadow, where she sewed pockets I have never been able to count, and what is in them is not for trade. So I did the thing I had been circling since dawn and not doing: I went to her workbox, and I took her second-best thimble.

The second-best. The best is silver, and it stays where her fingers left it. The second-best is brass, worn through at the crown from four decades of the needle's little kiss, worth nothing to anyone who did not watch it work. I carried it to the Shambles in my own mouth, and the whole way there it clicked gently against my teeth like a small tame ghost.

The Shambles after hours is my favorite kind of city: canvas and rope-creak and the day's fish-smell settling like sediment, lanes just wide enough for a barrow and exactly wide enough for me. The Exchange keeps no sign. It keeps a bird.

Brindle was on her perch above the stall shutters, doing the thing magpies do that looks like idleness and is inventory. Black and white with that oil-slick green in the wing. I had seen her at the wake, on the bollard, with her respectful button. She watched me come the length of the lane with the thimble in my teeth and said, before I had set it down:

"You are the witch's cat."

"Was," I said.

She did not say sorry. She turned her head the other way round to look at me again, which in a bird is consideration, and she said, "Hm," in the tone of an appraiser finding the hallmark genuine, and I liked her enormously and permanently.

Business, then. I set the thimble on her counting-board and told her what I wanted to buy: last night but one, Needle Lane, who or what went along it, and anything the lane's gutters had yielded since. Brindle looked at the thimble a long time. She did not touch it.

"Payment comes in kinds," she said. "That one is the wrong kind. That one is grief, pet, and I do not fence grief; it only ever comes back on the fencer." She hopped once along the rail. "But work, now. Work I will take. My back alley has grown three nights of wisps — something has them fat and bold this season, and my stock glimmers,

and wisps drink glimmer when the lies run short. Clear my alley and we will talk like professionals.”

So I worked. It took the fat end of the night. Her alley had five of them, coiled in the shutter-slats and the drain-mouths like lit worms in an apple, and the work was low and quiet and mostly patience: a guard here, a cuff there, a cat plainly willing to spend the whole night being unprofitable to drink near. That is the half of the trade that does not want a young body, and it is the half I still have. The last and fattest came out of the downspout at the greyest hour and made its argument, which had lights in it, and I declined the argument twice before it stayed declined, and the alley was quiet.

Brindle watched the whole thing from her rail, upside down part of the time, which I chose not to notice.

“You’re not useless,” she said, at dawn. “That’s the whole interview.”

Then she told me what I had bought. A cart on Needle Lane, the night of it: late, unlit, wheels wrapped, and *wax on the wind of it*, she said, wax and something under the wax, pond-water and old rope. Twice along the lane, her pickers had it: up from the city riding light, and down toward the Mere riding heavy, the wrapped wheels telling the stones what the driver would not. I could make nothing of it, and filed it anyway. No pigeons to raise the roosts about it, of course. Of course.

And the lane’s gutters had yielded to her pickers, two mornings since, exactly one thing worth a shelf: a scrap of paper, cart-docket shaped, that a gull had beaten her to and a boy had beaten the gull to, and the boy sold to the Exchange for a licorice knot. *Consigned, Needle Lane, night of*, and the consignee line scratched out. Scratched, mind. Not blank. Somebody drove a cart down an unlit street and then did not want to have been the sort of person who had.

She took the thimble at last. “For holding, pet, not for keeping. Redeem it any dawn.” She held it a moment longer than trade requires, and turned her head away.

I went home along the roofline with a docket-scrap folded into my shadow and the following entry in the ledger: *the night had a cart, the cart had wax, the wax has a guild, and somebody is ashamed of the delivery*. On the chimney-breast board, the candle stub gained a neighbor.

* * *

I lost. In her parlor, on the night, against the thing that wore the room, I lost. It came into her house and it did not even *hurry*. And every plan I had made since — the thread, the fence, the docket — ran on ahead of me to the same place: sooner or later I would stand in front of that shape again, and on the current arithmetic it would take everything I am, a second time, at its leisure, while it worked.

So I decided to get better. I know how that reads from a cat of fifteen whose whole working day, until that spring, had been the question of which sill had the sun in it.

I went to the goose.

The Watch goose lives behind the tannery and guards six gardens' worth of back-run, and it wins. Her rule, from the windowsill years, was that you look first and count while you do it. So I looked. Looking I can still do.

I watched what the goose *did*, not the hissing, which is theater, but the feet, the weight, the neck's coiled bookkeeping. Then I went in low, and the going in was where it came apart. I knew where the neck would be and arrived after it, every time, by about the width of my own head, which is the distance between a cat of eleven and a cat of fifteen.

Nine arguments over five nights. I lost the first seven. It was an old animal being knocked over in a wet garden by a bird, getting up slower each time, and going back in because the alternative was to have decided not to. On the eighth I read it correctly and was too slow to use what I had read, and that is a grief of its own and it was new to me. On the ninth I left the garden walking.

Something went in my left shoulder on the sixth night and has not come back. I set it down once.

Then the dog at Number Twelve: eleven feet of chain and a standing offer to discuss territory, declined daily for years. I accepted, and told him plainly what I had come for, and he was decent about it in the manner of a working professional asked to spar with a retired one.

A dog teaches reading, not speed, which was the lesson I could still take. Watch what it will do before deciding what to do about it. Four sessions. By the fourth I could tell him where he was going

before he went, and I still could not get there first, and we both understood that the second half of that sentence was permanent.

At the end of the fourth he sat down, which for that dog is a treaty, and I sat down too, out of range, as the treaty specified.

And then the last thing, which was not fighting, and which was the reason for all the fighting.

Her ward is still on the parlor door frame. It hangs there with a hole in it the size of what walked through, the stitches lifted, not torn, a wound with straight edges. I had watched her patch that ward four hundred times: after storms, after solstices, once after an argument with the chimney. Watching is not doing.

I got up on the frame with a mouthful of her thread from the workbox, and I mended it.

I will not pretend it was her work. My stitches sat in the old ward like a boy's writing on a master's page — fat, anxious, twice-knotted where hers would have held with a breath. It took most of a night, and one stitch I placed and unpicked eleven times because it *pulled the wrong way*; my paws wanted to run the line mirror-wise, right to left, and the ward wanted otherwise, and I remember being irritated at my own hands and thinking nothing of it.

But when it was finished the ward held. The door frame hummed again, low, the sound of a house with someone minding it, and the hole was gone.

Her work always took its payment at the pull. I had watched that for fifteen years without giving it a name: she set a stitch, and something went out of her with the thread. A warmth. A face she used to be able to call up. An hour of luck she had been keeping. A year off the far end.

Nobody had told me what a cat pays with. I found out at about the fourth stitch. A familiar has one coin, and the coin is sleep. I paid a night of it into that frame, and the frame was not done with me, so I paid the next night as well: two of them on the cold hearthstone with my eyes open on nothing while the dark went about its business without me.

I sat on the hearthstone and looked at my crooked stitches in her doorway and understood that I was going to do all of it, the whole case, every thread of it, and that no one was going to stop me, including the thing that had stood in that doorway and gone back

to its work.

* * *

Two nights owing and no prospect of collecting them, and I walked the rounds nobody was paying for anyway: the lamps still short-handed, past the drains and the dark doorways, down Needle Lane to its cold end and back. Two wisps put up their small arguments and lost them. The dog at Number Twelve stood, once, and did not bark — looked where I looked, at the fog standing at the lane's end where fog does not stand — and we held that watch together for a while, chain and cat.

Wisps used to be rare on this street. Used to be. The dark had noticed the missing lamps, the way water notices a low place. Somebody had to walk the line while the Lamplighters grieved.

The city I can work in is a particular kind of city. I intended to keep it.

Chapter 3

Creditors

I took the docket-scrap back to Brindle at the next dawn, because paper is her native language and mine only by adoption.

She read it head cocked, one eye at a time: the watermark, the fold-grease, the ink that had been wet in fog. “Counting-house paper,” she said. “Chandlers’ counting-house. This is the flimsy, the copy that rides with the cart. The originals live under the ledgers, second yard off Wick Row.”

Then she flicked the scrap flat with one black claw to take the corner, and stopped.

Half a second. No longer than that. There was a cart-slot seal stamped into the corner of the flimsy, and Brindle’s working eye sat on the seal and did not travel, and her cocked head came level while it sat there. Then she went on as though the seal were weather. If I had been less new to all this I would have asked her what she had just decided not to say. I was new. I filed it instead.

“Second yard off Wick Row,” she said again. “Mind the night shift, pet.”

* * *

Wickrow after dark is the best-lit district in the city.

Every doorway wears a little flame: a lamp over the door, a burning stub in the small window above it, candle-boxes along the sills. Every flame is a warded bee, which is the Chandlers’ mark, burning in its

own wax and billed to the tenants by the quarter. Other streets buy locks. Wickrow buys light. That is *stock control*.

I went in over the roofs, dropped to the yards where the roofs ran out, and met the night shift.

The night shift was a hound.

Not the honest kind, that discusses territory from the end of a chain. A counting-house hound, off its chain, walked yard to yard by a man with a lantern and turned loose in each one while he counted his keys. Big-shouldered, low-voiced, paid in meat. He found my scent in the second yard's woodstack and came in after it with no preamble at all.

The yard was a box and the box was his. Wall on three sides, tarred smooth to the top, nothing in it a claw could use. A rain-butt in the near corner, too far off to be a plan. And the gate stood open at his back, which is the entire art of a yard dog: he does not have to catch you, he only has to go on standing between you and the one hole. So I went up the woodstack, because up was what I had, and up is a thing I weigh now before I take it. It was stacked green, and green wood rolls, and I came off the top of it into the open with a log going the wrong way underneath me.

He did not lunge at where I was. He stepped, twice, wide and unhurried, and took the corner I was going to need before I had finished needing it, and then he shut it. I was reading his mouth the entire time, and I set that down as evidence and not as defense.

What got me out was not speed. I had none to bring to a yard dog, and had none at eleven either. It was that a hound built like that cannot change his mind inside his own length. I made him commit, and went under his head on the side he had to swing his whole body to answer, and I did not run for the gate, because he would have had the gate. I went back up the green logs, which held for exactly the length of one climb, and over the wall.

He put his forepaws up after me and told the whole district about it. I left a strip of my flank on the wall-top and took nothing at all off him, and I record it that way because that is how it went.

But it cost me the quiet. Somewhere across the yards the keys stopped counting, and the lantern came around, and boots — more than one pair — and I came off the wall low and fast into the alley-mouth with the light swinging after me, and the alley-mouth was

blind.

A paw hooked my scruff and hauled me sideways through a gap I had not seen, into a doorway's dead shadow, and held me there while the watch went past close enough to smell the lamp-oil and the supper on them.

When the boots were two yards gone the paw let go. I turned around with every dignity I had left and found a grey tom considering me from the dark: old, big-boned under a coat that had seen weather, one eye, half of one ear, and the stillness of a creature that has spent a long time being exactly as visible as it chooses.

"You fight like a housecat," he said.

"I was one."

"Were," he agreed, and did not say sorry.

He was the first creature since the parlor who had put a paw on me, and the paw had been *sure*, and something in me that had been walking on three legs since the kettle went quiet put its fourth foot down.

He looked me over once, professionally, the way Cardew had looked over the room.

"Watch the paws, not the claws," he said. "Claws are a rumor. Paws are an appointment. The dog told you where it would be four moves before it got there, and you were reading the teeth." He tipped his head at the yard I had come out of. "Wax door, far side, under the loading beam. The counting room is behind it, and Wick's paper is worth the reading."

"You know what I am looking for," I said. It was not a question, and he did not treat it as one.

"I knew your witch to look at," he said. "Everyone did."

Then he gave me one more thing I had not asked for. He said it flat, and worn smooth with saying.

"You will be under other people's roofs all season, so have this one. Nobody collects off a lit candle. You take a house's light, you take its salt, you take its fire: take any of the three and you take nothing else under that roof that night. Not a debt. Not a favor. Not a mouse." The one eye came around at me. "It is not manners. Manners you can decline. It is older than the Hollow Court and older than the desk they keep in it, and it was old before anybody thought of writing things down. The desk came after. Everything came after."

He was already moving then, grey into grey, and at the gap in the fence he paused with the one eye half back toward me. "Bodkin," he said, his name, given as the old ones give it, once, take it or leave it, and was gone over the fence with no more noise than a thought.

The name meant nothing to me then.

I took the wax door.

* * *

The counting room was warm, and lit by its own stock, and guarded. The Chandlers do not set dogs on their paper. They set the paper's own keeper: a poured thing, man-high, tallow-shouldered, with a gentle unfinished face, that stood up out of the corner shadows when I crossed the threshold and placed itself between me and the ledger-shelves with the unhurried certainty of a door swinging shut.

I had learned, by then, to spend four seconds looking. I spent six. The thing was slow and its patience was perfect, and strength was not going to answer it. But it *was* a working, and a working is stitches, and stitches can be read.

The threads of it ran down into the floor, into a lattice woven under the boards: an ugly, effective, journeyman weave, nothing like her hand. And a lattice is only a gate lying down. She unpicked gates in front of me a hundred times, and I had never once done it myself until the night I mended her door.

So while the keeper leaned its warm bulk after me, always a beat behind, I went at the lattice, paw and tooth, loop by loop, and the wrong loops fought me, and the right ones came away like a lie confessed, and on the last of them the keeper stopped mid-lean, considered its own hands with that gentle face, and poured itself politely back into the corner, off duty for the first time in years.

Under the ledgers, exactly where the flimsy's watermark said they would be, the originals.

And in the originals, her name.

Vane, in a strong small impatient hand. Instruction after instruction, dated inside one single week of this spring: buy Vane's paper. All of it. The tallow debt to the renderers' yard. The two winters' rent she owed on the workroom before the good years. The chandlery

account, seven years old, forgiven-in-name and never in law. *Buy it quiet, pay the premium for quiet, and call it due Lady's Day.*

Every debt my witch owed in the world, bought up in seven days, by one buyer.

I sat on the counting-house desk in the light of the enemy's own candles and made myself read it twice, because the first reading had a red wash over it and red is not a reading light. Then I folded the page, teeth and paw, and slid it into my shadow, into one of the pockets she sewed there, where it weighed what secrets weigh, which is nothing, and rode like a stone anyway.

I had gone one whole roof toward home before I made myself admit what the ledger meant. A man who buys every debt you owe and calls them due on one date is not planning your murder. He is planning your *eviction*. You do not go to the expense of killing a woman you have spent a premium to lawfully destroy.

And this next thought arrived later, on the drainpipe, and stopped me half way up it. You *particularly* do not kill her if her needlework is holding shut something you profit by. A dead seamstress mends nothing.

Lady's Day was most of a season out. I set the date at the head of the ledger.

I needed to know what her needle had been holding for Ellery Wick. And for that I needed people who watch the Chandlers for a living and hate them fluently.

Fortunately, the city keeps a guild of exactly those.

* * *

The Lamplighters' hall burns lamps at its own door.

That costs a guild that cannot spare the oil: their own light, spent outward at the dark, all night, every night, as a point of order. I came to it over the yards and stopped on the wall opposite and read the front of that building like a notice: *we are not gone. We light what we have. Come home.*

Inside, the hall was one cold room. Most of the coats on the pegs hung over boots nobody had come back for: pairs of boots, toes out, waiting, under coats that kept their shapes the way the wraith on Needle Lane had kept a shape.

Forty lamplighters used to walk Hollowmere. What was left of the guild fit in that one room, around one lamp, with room to spare.

They knew me the moment I came in — *the witch's cat* went around the room in the way words go around a room full of people not saying them — and the room braced. A grieving hall, and a cat in it, wanting something.

The one to convince was obvious. Torn ear; chalk on her paws — hands; I keep the ledger in my own tongue — a shift-boss's way of standing, facing the door, near the lamp, where the next bad news would have to go through her first. Merrow.

I did not lay Wick's page down. Paper first is an auditor's manners. Instead I did the thing I had been carrying since the doorway, which had the advantage of being true: I looked at the coats over the boots, and I asked after their missing.

The room stopped bracing.

"Not dead," Merrow said. Flat, fast, a door long since slammed on that word. "The Court said not dead. Our filings came back *marked*: no appointments under those names. Eleven names. I file them again every week and they come back marked. So they are *somewhere*, and this hall lights lamps until they walk back in."

"The day-side says contract work up the coast," she said, in the same voice. "Good money, no notice given. That is what is said in the Chandlers' yards and at the fish-stalls, and there is no paper in the world that says where a man is not." She looked at the pegs. "Their rounds are still walked. I walk two of them myself."

She looked at me a long moment, chalk-handed, torn-eared. I was the first party to come into that hall and ask after the missing instead of the murder, and it settled something.

"Walk my round with me, cat," she said. "Rounds first. Paper after." So she had seen the page's corner in my shadow after all.

* * *

Her round was forty-one lamps, and something was walking it ahead of us.

We both saw it by the fifth: lamps she had lit at the round's head, dark again behind us. Not blown, not failed. *Drunk*, wicks wet and

whole, the little warded bees drained to grease. And the order of the darkening was the sequence her guild has walked so long it has worn a groove in the evening. At the fifteenth lamp we doubled back quiet and caught them at it: a pair of wisps, fat as lamp-oil themselves, working her lamps *in sequence*, one keeping watch while the other drank.

Wisps do not do that. A wisp is appetite in a bottle. Appetite does not read route-maps, and it does not skip a bright lamp to keep a *schedule*.

These two had been taught. Something had walked this round beside them, night after night, until appetite learned a route. And of all the rounds in the city, it had chosen the one that stitches Wickrow's dark shut.

Merrow took the left one and I took the right, and a shift-boss of the Lamplighters swings a ladder very well. Mine opened the flank the hound had left me, which bled quietly for the rest of the night, and I said nothing about it and finished the round, and the lane was brighter for it. She relit her lamps in order — *her* order — to the round's end, and at the hall door she chalked a fresh tally on the wood, one stroke among hundreds, and I understood that the strokes were rounds completed since the night of the missing.

"You came about the night," she said. "Ask, then. I answer what is asked. No more."

That is a doorway exactly the width of your own wits. I sat, and thought, and asked, not *who killed her*, nor *what happened to your missing*, but this: "What work did Elspeth Vane do in Wickrow that nobody paid for?"

Merrow looked at me the way you look at a colleague who has just found the fault you had walked past. Then she took down the shift-book from behind the meeting-board, and opened it to a page her thumb knew, and laid the page where I could read it.

"That is Wick's hand," she said, tapping the requisition pasted at the head. "And that is the night nobody signed."

The tally ran down two facing pages, and it said this: for two years, at the turn of every season and after every hard blow off the Mere, ward-shifts at the *Wickhouse* on the Mere-edge, logged, walked, witnessed, and paid to *nobody*. The escort-lamplighter's fee stood in the book every time. The stitcher's fee stood blank every

time.

She sewed a rich man's warehouse shut, season upon season, for free. Nobody sews free. She least of anyone: I have watched her price a churn-blessing to the ha'penny and then chase the ha'penny.

Unless the sewing was not for the rich man at all. Unless what her needle held shut in that warehouse was something she would have paid to keep held, and the rich man merely owned the building it lived behind, and knew what he had, and let a witch ruin her evenings and her ledgers on it for two years, gratis, while he bought up her debts with the money her work was saving him.

I did not say any of this at the hall. It was not yet mine to say. But Merrow watched me read it, and when I looked up her face had the grim satisfaction of a woman whose grievance has finally been believed by somebody.

Behind the meeting-board their own ward hung torn: the hall's hem, the guild's own guard-stitching, ripped the night of the missing and left that way, because the one who always mended it was one of the coats. They had been living inside a torn ward every night since, sooner than let anyone else touch her seam.

Merrow saw me looking. The whole room saw Merrow seeing.

Cats inspect seams. Getting up on the meeting-board took me two tries with that flank, and the whole room watched me take them. Then I mended their ward in front of everybody, better than I had done the parlor door, because the parlor door had taught me how. When it was done the hall hummed faintly, low, under the talk, and one of the four remaining lamplighters put his face in his hands, and everyone else looked at the lamp.

Merrow walked me to the door. At the threshold, in front of her whole guild, she tied a lamplighter's knot into the thread at my chest — rough work, honest, tight — where the entire Weft could read it.

"The hall owes the cat," she said, for the room.

And then, bending close, for me alone, in the voice she keeps for the end of bad shifts:

"Wisps do not learn a route. Somebody taught them the taste. Find the teacher."

Chapter 4

The City Talks

Find the teacher, Merrow said. But a teacher is found through pupils, and the night's pupils were scattered across three guilds and two species, so I went and asked the parts of the city that keep records and do not know they are keeping them.

The Ratsmeet convenes under the fish market in the hour the ice melts. Not poetry: scheduling. When the fishmongers' ice runs down through the gratings, the under-market turns briefly uninhabitable to anything that minds wet feet, and rats do not, and one sufficiently motivated cat did not. Nothing moves through the Shambles at night that a rat does not book.

I came in over the gratings while the market was still shutting, and got the day's last piece of quay wisdom free of charge. A boy had put a hand-bell off the end of the Shambles stair into six feet of black water and was being comforted about it by half the fishwives on the row. *Never mind, love. Go down at slack and look. The water keeps everything but a bell.* Nobody explained it. Nobody there needed it explained.

There is a protocol for a cat attending, and I had it from Mirri the ratcatcher's daughter: do not eat anybody; do not say "trap"; do not say "terrier"; do not be a cat about it; and do not argue with the doorman, who is a goose. This one considered my references at the culvert-mouth, hissed once on principle, and let me through.

The Grey Boss holds court on a throne of corks.

He is old the way paper is old: grey to the point of transparency. "I remember the ninth bell," he said, before I had finished sitting.

"You will hear it said no one does. I am no one, then." The court laughed. He watched me not laugh.

"And I remember what was paid to keep it ringing," he said. "The first of everything. First catch of the season, first light of a new hearth, first child of a bad year. Down to the water it went, and the water took it, and nobody in this city called that monstrous. Everybody's grandmother had paid it. Everybody's grandmother ate that winter."

The corks creaked under him. All round the Meet the old rats touched their whiskers once and put their paws down again, and the laughing stopped. I was the only creature in that room who had needed to be told.

I put my question with the manners Mirri had drilled, to the Meet, not the Boss, and asked about the murder night on Needle Lane.

"The witch's cat," said the Grey Boss. "We had a lively night. Everyone had a lively night."

A rat's silence is a price list. *A lively night*, on a lane his own bookings would show empty. Unless the liveliness was the emptiness itself: a whole nation under the floor, booking nothing, all night, and being paid, or frightened, or *favor*ed into finding that unremarkable.

"You cannot clear out of an empty street," I said, slowly, watching him. "But you can be cleared out of one that is about to stop being empty."

The old rat's ears made a small movement his court could not see. "The cat can count," he said. Then he gave me my change: "A cart," he said. "No chandler on it. We know the chandlers' boys, every one, and this driver we did not know and have not seen since. And behind the cart, in no hurry, a gentleman. Going nowhere in particular, the whole way down the lane."

"What sort of gentleman?"

"The sort you don't book," said the Grey Boss, and the whole Ratsmeet went quiet, and the audience was over, and the goose saw me out with one satisfied hiss.

By morning, I knew, the Chandlers would hear a cat had been asking. Good. Nervous men check their locks, and checking your locks tells the whole street which doors matter to you.

The pigeons took longer, because the pigeons were having an election.

Whoever leads the Pigeon Post decides what the city overhears. They elect a Postmaster by hat. The whole electorate perches at once on its candidate's chosen hat, and the hat that bows lowest wins. It had not occurred to the founders that somebody might simply feed the electorate.

A slick young cock-pigeon called Toby was winning on unlimited seed.

It was my problem because of one fact: the night my witch died, every pigeon in the city went quiet at once. Not frightened quiet, which is loud the moment the fright passes. *Bought* quiet. And here was an election swimming in mystery seed. I do not believe in prosperous coincidences.

So I audited it. Three nights on the roofline, upwind and unhurried, walking the supply line back hop by hop, and it ended above Needle Lane at a grain-chute swept a little too neatly. Then the arithmetic announced itself. Good seed, bought in bulk, and hauled *up*. Nobody hauls seed up. This seed had been carried to the roofs and scattered from above by somebody with *hands*.

The second night of that audit ended badly. There is a gutter on the granary side that I have used four hundred times. I gave it the four seconds she taught me, ledge and drop and sill, and the four seconds said what they have always said, and I went.

The reading was right. It had been taken about a younger cat. I was short by the width of my own shoulders and I knew it before I was halfway down, which is the part of it I would strike from the record if the record were mine to strike.

Three storeys is not far. It is far enough.

The corridor again. The light the color of four in the morning. The queue of one. The Clerk looked at me over the spectacles for a long, costly moment, and consulted the book, and did not pick up the stamp.

"You have no appointment," he said.

"I fell," I said.

"I am aware. Falling is not an appointment. Falling is an accident that has got above itself." He turned the book around so that I could see the page, which was blank, and turned it back. "REFUSED. The

desk does not entertain walk-ins. Mind the door on your way out; it sticks.”

It does stick. I woke in the granary yard with rain in my whiskers and a gutter across my tail, and less of her in me than I had gone up with. He had taken his fee. He did not itemise it.

So I lay there a while, humiliated in a place beyond anatomy, and then got up the way I get up now, in two parts.

I took it to the Perch, full assembly, hats and all, and put it before the old Postmaster. I laid it out in the order she taught me: the seed, the chute, the hauling-up, and the night the whole Post had spent with its beaks full. Then I watched an old bird’s pride fight an old bird’s honesty, and honesty win by a neck.

“We voted with our beaks full,” he said, at last, to the assembly, “and we called the quiet weather.”

From a Postmaster, before the whole Perch, that is a confession. The roosts went up in the kind of noise they had failed to make on the night that mattered. Toby attempted a point of order and was sat on by his own electors.

But mark what the confession actually said. The seed came *before* the night. Days before, laid in like stores against a winter. The murder was not an act of passion that happened to find the city conveniently deaf. The murder had a *quartermaster*: somebody who provisioned the silence in advance, in bulk, by hand.

I went home over the roofs slowly, carrying the word. Under her old window a lamplighter was relighting Needle Lane, and the first pigeon in a month settled onto the ledge above the dark glass and said something rude about me to the whole street.

I sat in the road and let it finish.

* * *

Then the city, having resumed talking, talked about me, and I was summoned to court.

Not the Hollow Court. The other one. The Court of Whiskers convenes on the ropewalk roof at the wrong hour on purpose, and I arrived on the summons of three yowls and a dead moth left on my sill, which is how our bar serves papers. The docket that night was a kitten.

Tansy: small, orange, absurd, with the build of a mitten. Her case, as the seniors laid it out from their chimney-stacks, was this: to save her three brothers when the spring flood took their crate down the canal, she had sold her purr to the Quiet Gentleman for the favor that fished them out.

The contract was legal. That was the scandal of it. No theft, no trick: consideration given — three lives; consideration received — one purr, surrendered in escrow. But a kitten without a purr cannot be comforted and cannot comfort, which is the entire profession of a kitten, and the Court of Whiskers wanted the precedent *killed* — every tail on that roof went still while the name was said — before the Gentleman opened a *market* in such things.

The kitten slept in the lee of a chimney through her own hearing. Midway through the arguments she woke, located me — I do not know how; we had never met — marched across the assembled jurisprudence of the rooftops, sat down against my flank, and told the Court: “This is my counsel. He is the best one.”

I had issued no such appointment. The Court minuted it anyway, and I am given to understand the minute stands to this day.

What could I do? I did the job. The old ones gave me the one piece of law that matters — *he never signs anything that can be settled; read it before you touch it* — and I went down to the Shambles strongroom where his paper lodges. No guards; his paper guards itself. On a shelf in that dry dark, her purr: a small knot of thread in escrow, purring faintly to itself, with nobody in the room it was for.

And the knot had grown a loop nobody tied.

I read it three times in the Weft-light, as the Court had charged me. The contract was flawless — his contracts always are — but a purr is not inert goods. A purr *accrues*. Warmth begets warmth even on a shelf, and a season’s interest had knotted itself a loop that appeared in no schedule. His paper is exact, and exactness cuts both ways: what is not conveyed is not conveyed. The interest was nobody’s, and an unclaimed loop may be unpicked by any finder, and a knot grown into another knot comes undone *with* it, if the unpicking is clean. Three nights, the last until nearly dawn, loop by loop, her small stubborn purr humming against my paws like a trapped bee getting hopeful — and it came loose all at once, like a cork, and went home at volume.

I saw that Tansy, three streets away on the hearthrug where she had installed herself without leave two days earlier, woke mid-purr, purred so hard she fell off the rug, and went back to sleep still running.

On the empty shelf where the escrow had sat: a calling card. Blank, both faces, smelling faintly of fog. It had not been there when I started.

I carried it home in a shadow-pocket and pinned it to the board beside the candle stub and the docket and the shroud thread, and sat on the mantel a long time looking at the only blank exhibit in my case, which said, more clearly than print: *noted.* — *G.*

Tansy stayed. I explained to her that I live alone. “Yes,” she said. “We live alone.” She moved the remainder of her personal effects — one chewed bootlace — behind the coal scuttle. She sleeps on my paws, which obstructs the paws, and purrs like a small wrong engine. Somewhere in the Gentleman’s strongroom a page of his ledger is one line lighter. The Court of Whiskers advised me to price that. I have priced it, and I find I would pay it again.

* * *

One more thing belongs here.

The Fish-Giver missed two dawns.

Pell, the paper on his door calls him. No cat uses it. For eleven years that man has set out scraps behind his stall at first light for half the strays of Thimblefield, rain or frost, and stood in his doorway saying good morning to animals who officially are not there. He has never learned my name. Every cat is “puss,” with the same democratic courtesy he shows the magistrates who buy his herring.

Two dawns, no scraps. I went down.

The trouble was on his door, in paper: rent behind, lease called, seven days, through a bank that banks for the Chandlers. Nobody was going to knife the Fish-Giver in his parlor. They were going to *file* him out of it, and the paper smelled of a counting room in Wickrow. He had three assets, and did not know he had any.

The first was down his own drainpipe: his grandmother’s brooch, lost nine years ago and mourned to every customer since. No hand

fits that pipe. A paw does. One wet shoulder and a bent whisker later the brooch lay on his step at midnight, and at dawn he sat down on his own threshold with it and cried.

The second was the pigeon-net, newly talkative and feeling it owed me. The roosts reported within the hour: the landlord's man takes his evenings loudly at the Bent Anchor, and has a sister, and the sister is a magistrate.

The third was that the magistrate keeps a cat, who owed me a favor of long standing, and the favor was called and paid off the page, cat fashion: silently, completely, neither government consulted. Certain paperwork was reviewed; a lease's calling was found procedurally defective; and a bank which banks for the Chandlers chose, on reflection, not to have the defect examined in open court.

That was the first fight I ever won without a fight. Paper has teeth. I filed the lesson where I file weapons.

Dawn, three days later. The shutter went up. The scraps went down. The Fish-Giver stood in the middle of it wearing his grandmother on his coat.

He never learned any of it.

* * *

One last entry from that week.

The morning the Fish-Giver's shutter went up, the Mere fog was still standing in the Shambles' low lanes at full market bell. Not thick. Just *present*, an hour past its going-home time, the way a creditor is present in a doorway. The fishwives worked around it and called it weather.

I sat on Pell's roof-ridge and watched it decline to leave until nearly noon. That night I opened a fresh page in the ledger and headed it as she headed a fraying hem she could not yet re-sew: *WATCH THIS*.

The fog had never kept market hours before. Somebody had cut the Needle out of this city, and the city's oldest resident had noticed the same week I did.

Chapter 5

The Ward That Failed

The Wickhouse squats on the Mere-edge, fat as a tick, and every stone of it is warded in her stitch.

I had known the building my whole life and never once had business with it. Now I stood on the sea-wall at dusk with Merrow's shift-book tally in my memory and Wick's ledger-page in my shadow.

Her seam ran the whole water wall. Foundation to chimneys, stitch upon stitch upon stitch, the biggest single working I had ever seen.

Two years of unpaid ward-shifts, the tally said, and the tally was complete. The Lamplighters' book opens two years back and she began the wall the season it opened. Two years. That is what undid me, standing under it: not that the work was old, but that it was not. She built all of that in two years of nights, at her age, after her own day's work, and came home in the small hours smelling of pond-water, and would not say why, and sat closer to the fire than the fire required.

Bodkin was on the sea-wall.

I had not seen him arrive, which by then I understood to be the only way he arrived. He sat looking at the water — not the warehouse; the water — with his one eye half shut, an old grey stone among the granite ones.

"Keep your feet dry and your business short," he said, without preamble, as I came up. "And go in by the wax door, not the water door."

"You know the building."

"Everyone on this side of the wall knows the building." He looked

at it then, briefly, the way you glance at a debt. “Nothing good ever came off that water. You are going in anyway.”

“I am.”

“Then that is the geometry of it,” he said, and settled deeper into his coat, and stayed exactly where he was, on the stone. “I don’t go in there.”

In the order I lived it, that was an old cat’s sensible fear of a bad building, and it made me trust him more, not less.

I put him down in the ledger as honest. Every word he said to me on that wall was true.

* * *

Getting to the wax door is the Mereside’s own toll.

The fog on those terraces has residents. I went across it slowly, waiting at the curbs, keeping to the long shadow, and at the last crossing I called on the part of me that is hers and felt it answer and felt it go. Even so, I did not arrive unmet.

One entry for the *WATCH THIS* page: the Mereside steps wear a white stain where the fog’s breath has reached, every night, for longer than the stone remembers. The wet that night stood a full step above the stain. The line had moved. Nobody had rung a bell about it.

Between me and the door handle, dry-footed on a street glazed with wet, stood one of the Drowned.

I had heard of them all my life and seen them never: the Mere’s patient people. It did not lunge and it did not stalk. It *arrived*.

It regarded me with the mild interest of deep water. It stood where it stood because something under the lake preferred that door unopened, and I understood for the first time that my case had two sides. One side was a murder. The other side was *old*, and wet, and had been waiting on this city before there was a city to wait on.

What she taught me. You do not outwait the tide; you use its schedule. The Drowned arrive; therefore they are never quite *here*. Everything red at the bottom of me came up at once and I let it. Not at the thing: past it, one committed burst through the gap its arriving had not yet closed. And I was through the wax door with the fog’s fingers still turning where my tail had been.

Inside: wax to the rafters.

White hills of it, aisle upon aisle in the gloom, a hundred winters of light not yet sold. The merchant smell lay over everything, honey and render and coin. And under the merchant smell, the other smell. Pond-bottom. Old rope. Patience.

The wax was not stock. The wax was *feed*.

I walked those aisles the better part of an hour and the sums assembled themselves around me. The deep reserve of the trade, stacked against a wall the Mere touches. Along that wall, her seam. On the far side of her seam, something that fed, and took its feed, and stayed where her stitching held it.

The guild's ledgers call that spoilage: so many hundredweight written off each quarter, damp-lost, rat-lost. The rats, who book everything, would laugh at that line.

So Ellery Wick's entire empire stood on a seam he got for free from a witch who could not afford to let it fail.

Halfway down the water wall I found the place where the seam was wrong. And in the middle of that cold warehouse, with my nose an inch from her stitching, I fell into a Remembered Day, and it was the first one, and I did not choose it.

I had not slept in three days. I stood at the wall with her thread-scent in my head, and between one breath and the next it was years ago, and warm, and her table was under me instead of stone.

The same chart. That is what undid me: the chart of this same water wall, half-sewn, spread across her table in lamplight — and a much smaller cat deployed on top of it as a paperweight, asleep, entirely certain of the world. Her voice above me, amused, talking to her needle the way she did when the work was long:

“That winter I tried eight strays. Every one declined the interview. Wise animals. The ninth fell asleep on my work—” the needle going down, through, drawn, the little tug, a word ending, “—and I took it for a signature.”

I came back to the cold with my paws on the actual wall, doing the sum I had been refusing all season. Eight strays declined. The ninth signed. She kept count of strays, and of nothing else in that cheerful shambles of a house, and Cardew's voice on the quay: *you were her ninth, you know. She'd never say what she meant by the count.*

Nine of us. There were nine of something else, too, and the Clerk had not filed one since he sat at a much smaller desk. I wrote the two nines side by side and drew no line between them. I did not want to draw it, and I noted that I did not want to.

* * *

Now the seam.

At the near end, man-height and below, her work was *wrong*.

Not torn. Tearing leaves violence in the thread, and there was none. Not burned, not rotted, not the Mere's slow patient chewing, which I could see further down, held off by every stitch.

Undone. Each stitch lifted out clean and whole, the way she herself lifted stitches when a hem displeased her: her exact movement, her exact order, the little releasing twist at the top of each. But run *backward*, in the precise reverse of the sewing.

I did the only thing that would let me be sure. I re-sewed a hand's length of it, her pattern, my own paws. And to re-sew what was unsewn I had to follow the unsewing, stitch into the ghost of each lifted stitch, and my paws, following, *ran the line mirror-wise*. Right to left. The way my paws had wanted to run her door-ward, when I stood on the frame irritated at my own hands and thinking nothing of it.

Whoever unpicked this wall did it in her own stitch, mirrored, and did it at a speed I could read in the spacing. Perfect technique. And Elspeth Vane taught exactly nobody: the Circuit begged her for apprentices for forty years and she turned away every one.

The lifted thread told me the second finding of the wall. It lay where the unpicking had dropped it, loose coils along the foot of the stone, and when I took it up to work with it there was nothing in it. Dead slack.

A stitch of hers, standing, holds what she paid into it. There is an evening of her life in every hand's length of that wall. These coils were spent thread, nothing of what was paid in coming back out at the lifted end. Whoever ran her seam backward had unlocked the wall and recovered not one evening of all those years. Undone is not refunded.

I took the hand's length of her thread away with me, evidence, hers and then mine, and I went out by the wax door with the warehouse dark at my back. Bodkin was gone from the sea-wall.

A case wants stating. She talked to her needle when the work was long, and I had taken it for company; it was method. So I stated mine aloud, to the empty wall, there being nobody on the stone to hear it: "The slack comes off dead. What was paid into the stitching does not come back out at the unpicking."

And the fog over the stone held the shape of a sitting cat for one second longer than fog holds anything. I wrote down that it was fog.

I sat where he had sat and put it in order. The wax feeds a thing the guild will not name. She held it off for two years, unpaid, and told nobody. And the man who profits by all of it *bought her debts and called them due*.

It was time to meet Ellery Wick.

* * *

The invitation, when it came, was a candle.

That is how the Chandlers grant audience: a beeswax taper arrives, trimmed by the guild's own chandler to burn exactly one hour, stamped with the bee at the base. You light it and start walking, and if it dies before you reach the Guildhall, so does the appointment.

They had sized the taper for a man's stride. I carried it lit through the evening streets in my teeth.

A black cat crossing three districts at speed with a live flame held out in front of his own face, fog curling off the wick-heat, wax dripping onto the whiskers, which took a week to feel right again. Children pointed. A watchman blessed himself.

I arrived with a quarter-inch to spare.

The Guildhall of the Chandlers is a chapel to the bee. Ten thousand lit votives line its hall, tier upon tier, and the heat stands in the room like a body. Above, the great combs of the guild's own hives mutter behind bronze grilles.

And between me and the stair, the keeper of the hall unfolded from beside the votive-tiers: a tower of poured wax with a gentle face, cousin to my counting-room acquaintance and four times the size of him.

“The Guildmaster will see you presently,” it said, in a voice with a guttering in it, and *presently*, in the grammar of such keepers, meant: *when you have shown the hall what you are*.

I had spent fifteen years on hearthrugs watching wax behave. It sags before it runs and it goes at the thin places first, and this one was thinnest where a shoulder wants to be.

So I led its gentle bulk on a tour of its own votive-tiers, close and fast, and kept it turning in the heat of its own hall, and the wind of that turning did what I could never do. It bowed a hundred flames toward its own body, and softened it at the shoulders, and at the knees, until it stopped, mid-reach, considered the puddling of its own wrists with that unfinished face, and withdrew with immense courtesy to its alcove, conceding the stair.

She would have laughed until she needed the chair. I climbed the stair and was seen presently.

* * *

Ellery Wick is a small man behind a desk built to make everything else in the room smaller, and he was already talking when the door finished opening.

“The ward-cat! The seam-mender — the hall talks, the whole row talks, sit — no, not there, the good chair. The good chair, I insist.” Warm, voluble, quick-eyed, in guild black with beeswax-colored facings; warm the way his hall is warm, which is to say: *by the burning of something*. I took the good chair. It is a mistake to refuse a frightened man’s hospitality; it tells him you have already decided.

And he was frightened. Under the patter, under the desk and the facings, Ellery Wick was a man who had been doing sums at night, and I had come to check his working.

I laid the whole case on his desk, item by item, in the order a cat lays out prey. The ledger page in his own hand: buy Vane’s paper, all of it, due Lady’s Day. Merrow’s tally: two years of ward-shifts at his warehouse, paid to nobody. The hand’s length of her thread from his own water wall, unpicked in her mirrored stitch. The docket-scrap from the gutter of Needle Lane, consignee scratched out.

And I watched him meet each exhibit, and here is my testimony, for what a cat's reading of a man is worth. At the ledger he flinched like a man touched on a bruise he knew he had. At the thread he went *blank*: the blank of a man shown a wound in a language he cannot read.

Then he did the thing I had not priced. He got up, opened his own strong-cabinet, and laid his books on the desk beside my exhibits. All of them.

True books. I know true books now; the rats and the magpies between them taught me the difference. And the true books said what the stolen page had said, and worse, and he narrated his own disgrace item by item in a voice that got steadier as it got more damning, because Ellery Wick is a coward about everything except arithmetic.

"I wanted her ruined," he said. "Not gone, cat. *Obliged*. Her lease, her debts, her standing: I bought the lot inside one week, and I paid over the odds for every scrap of it, and I timed the calling for Lady's Day because the Circuit meets at Lady's Day and the shame would be public and there would be nothing left of her that was not mine."

He turned his pen around on the blotter, once, and set it straight again.

"She sewed that wall for nothing. You have seen the column. Do you know what *nothing* means, on a book? It means she could stop. Any evening she liked. Two years I have sat at this desk knowing the whole house stands on a favour, and a favour is a thing a woman withdraws on a Tuesday because you were short with her at market. A debt is not withdrawn. A debt is *held*." The voice had gone quite level. It was the only steady thing in him. "I did not want her out of my district. I wanted her out of any position a woman can say no from. Ruined, she is not my creditor, she is my tenant, and a tenant sews the wall for the roof I let her keep, and I never pay her a penny, because you do not pay a tenant. You charge one."

There it was, then: the whole sum, said aloud in a warm room by a small man who had never once in his life been able to look at a thing he was doing until he had first written it down. He had not wanted her dead. He had wanted her *owned*, in perpetuity, at a discount.

"And now follow the rest of it," he said, "because I can read a

cat's face better than my clerks think, and you have already decided what I am. You do not kill the one needle holding your roof shut. You do not kill the needle. Alive and ruined, she re-rewards my wall from whatever gutter I chase her to. She was proud like that. She'd have done it to spite me. Dead—" and his voice went, at last, where his sums had already gone, "—dead, my wall is a larder with the pantry door coming open, and I am the man who has fed the thing behind it, and my father fed it before me, and for two years one woman was the whole of what stood between it and my aisles."

He put both hands flat on the desk.

"So ask me your question. I have been asking it myself since the bells rang eight that night, sitting here *hoping* it was me she'd ruined herself over. Who else knew the ward was hers?"

I looked at him a long time. Then I put my last question in front of him, flat as a docket: *a cart went down Needle Lane that night. Your cart-slot. Who signed it out?*

And Ellery Wick, guildmaster and terror of leaseholds, went and fetched the counterfoil himself, and laid it down, and it was worse than anything in his books.

The cart-slot had been signed out against *favor-paper*. Not coin, not credit: a favor the Chandlers' Guild itself owed. Owed for years, incurred by his own father's generation, the sort of debt that sits in a strongroom and is never, ever called.

Called in that week. Blind, no name given, no name *asked*, the guild's own seal pressed beside a signature line that held no signature at all. Just a small, neat knot, drawn in ink. A knot of thread, on paper.

"Everything in this city comes through the usual quiet channels," Wick said, very quietly, for a man built of noise. "You do not ask. The not-asking is what the quiet *costs*. I have paid it my whole life. I never once asked what I was buying." He pushed the counterfoil across the desk to me with one finger. "Take it. Ruin me with it if you like. I find I would rather be ruined than be next."

* * *

I could have squeezed him. The choice existed: a guildmaster's knot tied into my thread where the whole Weft could see it would

have opened every warded door in Wickrow to me for a year. He watched me decide what to do with him, and did not say one word to help himself.

I exposed him.

By eight bells the next evening the Lamplighters had his books.

I was on the hall steps when Merrow read them. She came out with the shift-book under her arm and her ladder left inside, which for a lamplighter is shirtsleeves, and she read the requisition page to the street in her end-of-shift voice, flat as a level.

Ward-shifts, Wickhouse, two years. Escort's fee: entered, paid. Stitcher's fee: and here she turned the book outward, so the street could see the column, and read the emptiness aloud. *Blank.* Page after page, season after season, *blank, blank, blank,* until a man at the back who had bought his light from the bee all his life said something thick and went home with his coat buttoned wrong.

She read the whole tally once. Then she read it again, slower. The second reading was the one that did the work.

By nine bells the criers had it. The terror margin, the fat quarter of every candle's price that was fear and not wax, died on the counting-room floor within the week.

Wick kept his desk. Barely. The guild's own arithmetic saved him: he was the only man in the building who understood the water wall's true accounts, and now every soul in Wickrow knew there *were* true accounts, and that the cat had them. He needs me now, the cat who ruined him.

And so ended, formally, the first file of the case. Ellery Wick: guilty of debts bought quiet, of a witch's years taken free, of feeding a nameless thing on the Mere-side of his wall and pricing the city's fear of it. And innocent, provably, structurally innocent, of the murder of Elspeth Vane.

Item: he wanted her ruined. Item: he wanted her dependent. Item: he wanted her owned. Not one of the three is worth a penny to him unless she is alive to be it. A dead seamstress mends nothing, and you do not bury the tenant you have just finished buying.

I crossed him off, and I confess the crossing-off cost me. He was the last suspect I could dislike.

Home, then. The board on the chimney breast received the last pin of the season: the counterfoil, with its inked knot in the signature

line.

From it I ran a length of grey wool with my own paws. Past the candle stub. Past the docket. Past the blank calling card that smelled of fog, and off the board's edge entirely, toward the window, toward the south of the city, where the favor-paper of every guild drains when it is called.

Gravamen. The undertakers' district; the Court-adjacent shadow-market where debts go to be owned.

The quiet channels had an address now.

Tansy slept on my paws while I sat up over the board. The strand that kept its house end stirred in the draft: the last length of her still running out from under that window, cut only at the far end, out over open water. And for the first time since the kettle I felt the case *move*, the whole weight of it, slow, like a barge coming off the mud.

Somebody in Gravamen had spent a knot of thread to put a cart on Needle Lane. In the morning, I went to meet the sort of gentleman you don't book.

Part II

The Quiet Roosts

Chapter 6

The Quiet Gentleman

Gravamen is where the city keeps everything it would rather not look at, which is why it is the best-looking district in Hollowmere.

The undertakers have money, and taste, and no neighbors who complain. Black brick, white trim, brass fittings with no fingerprints on them. The Horological Society keeps its tower there, running four minutes slow. And below it all, Gravamen is Court-adjacent: the Hollow Court's day-side face, the place where the paperwork of endings is drafted before it is filed in the building under everything. Debts drain to Gravamen the way water drains to the Mere.

I did not arrive well.

The rag-wraiths took me at the boundary of the district, where the fog off the canals meets the crematory warmth. Three of them. I had never heard of two together, and here were three working as a *set*, a wardrobe of the missing: a drover's coat, a housemaid's apron still tied at the waist of nobody, and a lamplighter's jacket with the hall's brass at the throat.

The seam of the city was loosening. Cardew had said it, Merrow's lamps said it, and here it was said again in worsted and calico: more missing, more empty clothes walking, the Hush fraying from the middle outward. The *WATCH THIS* page took the entry that night in three words: *three, hunting together*.

The apron came first, and I met it with the red already up in me. A rag-wraith is a garment, and a garment is held together by somebody's stitching, and stitching can be asked. I went up its tied waist while it was still deciding to be a shape, found the gather-knot

at the small of the back, and took the right loop the way I had learned on a wax keeper's lattice. The apron came apart into laundry. Laundry cannot fight.

The drover's coat was not going to be unpicked. Drover's stitching is tar-thread and rivet-seam, and a coat like that swings from the shoulders. So I stood still while a thing with no lungs came on, which is the whole of the goose's arithmetic and cost me more nerve than teeth ever have. It overswung twice. The third swing was written in the first two, and I was not there for it, and I went around it the way night goes around a lamp. Ten years ago I would have gone over it.

Which left the lamplighter's jacket, and the lamplighter's jacket I knew. The brass at the throat was hall brass. There was chalk on the cuff, laid on in a short bar by a thumb, the way Merrow marks a sleeve when she sends a man out on a doubtful round.

A rag-wraith is not evidence of a death. It is evidence of a coat with nobody in it. I held the distinction and the distinction did not help me, because I stood in front of one of Merrow's people and did nothing at all with my teeth, and while I was doing nothing the drover's coat finished remembering where its shoulders were and came down on me like weather off a hill.

Three is not one. I was fifteen years old and I would not put my teeth in the hall's brass, and that is the entire account of it.

It went the way it had gone in the parlor, in the same order, and I had time to notice that I knew the order.

The corridor. The filing. The desk. The Clerk was already shaking his head.

"You are not on the docket." He held the sheet up, translucent fingers, that winter-sounding pen laid down beside it. "No appointment, no death. We do not process walk-ins."

There was one chair in front of the desk. I sat in it. There had been three of them, I said. The child's jacket alone—

"A defeat off the docket spends no life," said the Clerk. "You will be sent back up, minus a filing fee and whatever your satchel held. A *true* death is announced. You will know the appointments when you keep them."

He took the fee. Then he drew my thread out across the desk for the filing. Partway along it he stopped. There was a knot in the thread, small and grey, close-worked. He was still a moment too long.

“Whoever ties these does not care to be noticed,” he said, to the file. Then he took up the pen, wrote two words in the margin of it, and laid it down again. I read the words upside down: CLERICAL ERROR.

He brought the stamp down. In all that quiet it was very loud.

The stamp said REFUSED. It was still a paw print.

“The gutter two streets east of where you fell drains poorly,” he said, as I left, without looking up. “If you are quick, the satchel will still be there. Your file is becoming irregular.”

I took the stairs up slowly. Somewhere on them my shoulder finished deciding what it thought of the drover’s coat, and by the time I came out into the fog it had told the rest of me.

* * *

I retrieved the satchel. The Clerk’s drainage intelligence was, like everything at that desk, exact.

I have not told Merrow which garment it was.

Then I went back and read the ground, because the entry I had made — *three, hunting together* — was the wrong entry. It was the entry a frightened animal makes. Here is the right one.

Rag-wraiths drift. That is the whole of their nature: they go where the weather goes. Two of them in one street is what two leaves in one gutter is, which is nothing. Drift leaves a track. Wet fog lies down behind a drifting thing in a long smeared wake.

There were no wakes. There were three dry patches.

Three, on the wet: three shapes’ worth of stone that the night’s damp had not reached, because something had been standing on that stone long enough to keep it dry. Dust had banked against the hems. They had not blown into that corner. They had been *waiting* in it, in position, since before the fog came up, and they had been waiting in a corner no man crosses, the gutter-and-ledge line a cat takes into Gravamen when he does not want to use the bridge.

I sat down in the middle of the three dry patches and made myself finish the sum.

Somebody had known which crossing I would use. Not which district — the district was on a counterfoil — but the *crossing*, the

cat's crossing, chosen by a party who understood that I would come in low and unbridged and alone at the wrong end of the night.

And under the drover's coat's collar, where a coat is gathered, there was a knot. Small. Grey. Tied with a little finishing twist at the top of it that I had last seen going backward down a warehouse wall on the Mere-edge, an evening and a district ago.

I did not know whose hand. I knew it was a hand. Rag-wraiths do not tie themselves to a corner and hold their positions for a cat. Something had gathered them, and posted them, and paid whatever posting costs, and the thing it had bought with that money was the specific street I was going to walk.

Here is the one I wanted least: from that corner onward the case was no longer a thing I was investigating. It was a thing that was also investigating me, and it had gone first.

I climbed to a Gravamen roof in the last of the night to put my coat and my nerve back in order. It took three stages where two would have done, and I sat down harder than I meant to, and that is when I saw the third thread.

Over Gravamen, strung high between the Horologists' slow tower and the fog, ran a familiar-thread: the deep silver line that runs between a witch and her bound creature, rare as a comet, the kind I wore for fifteen years and wear cut. It should hum with the two lives it joins. This one hummed a chord of one.

Not mine. Mine hangs at my own chest, and I know its weight without looking. Not hers. Hers ended, cut clean, over the black glass of the Mere, and I had stood with my paw on the end of it. A third: old silver gone the grey of long weather, taut, tended, *alive*, and with no witch on the end of it. I sat very still on that roof and followed it with my eyes as far as eyes would go: south and west, out over the terraces, toward the water. A bound creature whose witch does not answer, and whose thread has not been cut.

The ledger in my chest opened to the page with the two nines on it, and keeping that page as it was had begun to feel like holding a door shut with my back.

There was a knot in the thread's far slack, I thought. Too far to be sure: the size of nothing. And while I stared at it, dawn came up over Gravamen, and somewhere below me a door I had not noticed opened, and stayed open, in the manner of a door that is *for* you.

I had come to find the Quiet Gentleman. Finding him was not a thing I did.

* * *

His office is not hidden: no cellar, no password, no crooked stair. A tall black-brick house on Gravamen's best square, brass plate polished blank, blank like the card, door ajar at the exact angle of expectation. Inside, a hall smelling of fog and beeswax. *Beeswax*; item. And beyond it a long room of shelves that I mistook, for one honest heartbeat, for the Hollow Court's, because they were filled floor to ceiling with folders tied in ribbon.

Not grey ribbon. Every color. Every color a promise is made in.

He was at the window, looking out at the square, and I cannot describe him. Neither can anyone else; I have since asked rats, magpies, gargoyles, and a ghost. He is a gentleman, and he is quiet. There is a coat, of good cloth; there are gloves. Above the collar the eye slides, politely, the way it slides off other people's grief.

Nobody believes that is his name. The old ones on the ropewalk roof gave me the rule with the rest of their lore, flatly, in the tone they keep for things that are not up for discussion: you do not say an account-holder's true name, because saying it is how an account with him is opened. So the city has called him something else for so long that something else is now the only thing there is to call him.

No one remembers meeting him for the first time. And I cannot tell you whether that morning was my first.

The room was strange to me and my paws knew the floor.

"The witch's cat." His voice is the sound a signature would make. "Correction. The Needle's *heir*. The estate is open, the heir is in the room; the description is amended to the later instrument."

He turned from the window. "Damaged in transit," he said, in the way a form says it, and did not ask, and did not offer, and went on to the next item.

"Acquisitions to date. A magpie's regard. A lamplighter's knot. An old mother's debt. A guildmaster, ruined, converted to gratitude. One purr, recovered against paper of this house." Nothing in his tone accused. "The collection is competent, little rival. That is a

professional finding. It is not a kindness. Kindness is a term, and no terms are agreed between us.”

“I have questions.”

“You have *payment*.” It was not a correction so much as a page turned to the correct one. “Questions are held by nobody. Payment is held by you. The whole of this house stands in that distinction.” He gestured. On a reading-table by the window lay a single folder, untied, and beside it, in a dish, exactly the space where a favor-knot would sit.

I looked first. The folder was the counterfoil’s twin, his own file of the transaction. The price in the dish’s emptiness was one knot, unspecified, *his choosing later*: not the knot you give him, but the not-knowing which.

So I paid him nothing, and I asked my questions anyway, and *he answered them*. Freely. Precisely. I have come to believe the folder on the table was never the offer; the offer was the conversation, and the conversation was bait of another kind.

What he told me, with the fog pressing its face to his good windows:

That yes: the night’s arrangements had come through his house. Three favors, called blind, brokered without asking. “The not-asking is the price of the quiet. The Guildmaster states it correctly, and it is never stated in writing.” Item: a cart-slot from the Chandlers. Item: a scattering of seed by a human hand. “The hand was human. The debt was not.” I sat with that sentence while the clock in his hall ticked four minutes behind the world, and it opened like a lattice: some day-sider, indebted to a night-side creditor, worked off the debt with an evening’s honest labor, hauling seed to a roofline. The debtor human; the debt’s *owner* something else.

“And the third favor?” I asked.

“The third favor,” said the Gentleman, “emptied a hall.”

The room was very quiet. Even his clock seemed to owe its ticks somewhere.

“I do not know where the Lamplighters went,” he said, and I believed him. “The instrument is a debt of the hall’s. Old oil, older gratitude. The form of payment is: *be elsewhere, all of you, from seven bells*. Where elsewhere is, is not a term of the paper. The purposes of clients are not recited in the paper. I am a channel, cat.

Water does not ask.”

I did not answer that, and he did not require an answer. The place where his face is *considered* me. “You will want to know about my client.”

I had not asked. Asking would have been payment. He told me regardless, and every sentence had the weight of a thing given for a reason I could not see:

“This house meets everyone. This house met you before you were worth meeting. This client is unmet.” Not *I have never met. Unmet*: a condition of the file, with no tense in it anywhere. “Instructions received in the manner instructions are sometimes received in this trade. A knot, tied overnight, in the binding-thread of my own ledger, inside my own house, the commission written in the tying. Close work. Old-fashioned. No hand of that description has been on my paper since this was a much smaller concern.”

The Clerk’s voice came up in me from five hours earlier, said to a file and not to me: *whoever ties these does not care to be noticed*. Two desks, both in the debt trade, one knot-hand neither could file.

“And the payment?” I asked. “What does a client with no face pay a house like this?”

The Gentleman crossed to his shelves, drew out a shallow drawer that had no business fitting between two others, and set its contents on the reading-table beside the untouched folder: a spool. Small, plain, wound with thread of a grey I knew and my whole body did not want to know: the grey of the shroud-seam, the grey of tide-taken things. Wound *tight*. Years and years of it.

“Time,” he said. “Stored. Spent-down life, wound and banked. It is not a currency I deal in twice; it does not settle, it only *ends*, and ending is against the interests of my house. But a channel takes the toll the water carries.”

He looked at the spool the way Wick had looked at the thread on his blotter. “The number of beings in Hollowmere competent to wind such a spool is four. Inquiries have been made. Three of the four are dead. One of the three is your witch. The winding is not her hand.” A pause with no apology in it anywhere. “It is her hand’s *mirror*.”

He set the spool a half-inch further from the folder, as if the two accounts should not touch. “Price the stock, little rival. Nothing

living winds its own life and survives the winding. What is on that spool is not saved. It is taken, and taken small. A gargoy's blink. A street's held breath. The quiet between a bell and its echo. Half-seconds nobody enters as missing, gathered over decades, wound tight, banked. That is the stock.

"Under the stock, an advance. Something in this city holds lives in escrow. It has been lending against its holdings. Whether it is entitled to lend is not a question this house is instructed to reach. My client did not ask."

* * *

I walked home the long way, over the roofs of three districts, because there was too much in the satchel of my chest and walking is how a cat files.

Entered into the case, that morning, in order:

That the murder night was purchased entire: silence, transport, and an emptied hall, all of it bought through the city's one channel that never asks, by a client even the channel has not seen.

That the client pays in wound-down life: years off a spool, the coin of the Toll itself, taken small from things that never entered the loss.

That the client's knot-work is close, old-fashioned, mirror-handed. At the Gentleman's ledger. At my own thread under the Clerk's lamp. At a warehouse wall on the Mere-edge. And at the collar of a drover's coat, on a corner of my own route, holding three empty garments in position against the hour I would come. One hand, everywhere, and every place it touched, a professional shrugging: *not one of ours*.

That the last of those is a different kind of entry from the others. The first four are a hand at work on the city. The fifth is a hand at work on *me*. I have been running this file as though the far end of it were sitting still and waiting to be arrived at. The far end knows my crossings.

And that the Quiet Gentleman was now, formally, a suspect: the second strong name on a board that had just lost Wick. He knew it. He found it fitting. He had all but pinned himself to my board with his own gloved hands.

I put the corner to him too, walking home, and could not make it sit. A house that brokers does not stand three coats on a kerb; it sells the standing to somebody who will. So the posting went through some channel, and the channel is a business, and a business keeps paper. Somewhere in this city there is a receipt for my death, made out four hours before I walked into it, and I did not have the price of asking him for it.

Guilty of brokering, unasking, of profiting on the night my witch died: certainly. Guilty of the needle-work itself? I did not know what he was capable of, because I did not know what he was, and he papers rooms I have slept in. He stays. He stays at the top of the board until the method itself rules him out, and nothing less will do it.

Tansy was awake when I came in, upside down against the coal scuttle, supervising me pin the morning to the board. "What is *escrow*," she said. Not a question mark in it; she bills her questions flat, like a tradeswoman.

Escrow, I told her, is when somebody else holds a thing of yours, so that neither of you can touch it until the argument about it is over.

She thought about this with her whole body, the way she does. "Like when the big kittens hold your tail."

Exactly like that, I said, and she went to sleep mid-purr, and I sat up over the board a long time with her one word ringing in me like a struck bowl. *Holds*. Something in this city holds lives in escrow. Held is an argument that is not over. Held is not spent.

The method. Everything now ran through the method: who in this city can spend life like money and stitch like her mirror. I needed to date the technique — how long had that hand been working? — and for dating old crimes, Hollowmere keeps exactly two archives that never lie. One is under everything, and charges a toll.

The other has been standing on a corner of Wickrow for three hundred years, and it had, I had heard from the pigeons, recently done something unprecedented.

It had blinked.

Chapter 7

The Gargoyle and the Ghost

Sootbeard has watched one street for three hundred years, and last month, he blinked.

The day-side walks under him daily and sees a rainspout. Sootbeard is the gargoyle on the corner of Wickrow's oldest counting-row: granite shoulders, a beard the soot of thirty thousand chimney-seasons, and the fixed downward glare of a sentry whose watch has never once been relieved. He was installed by masons, with ceremony, under an ordinance, as one of a regiment of civic monuments raised to watch the streets of Hollowmere in the years when the city still remembered what it was watching for. The regiment was decommissioned in 1731. Nobody told him. Or rather, somebody *did* tell him, and he declined the order as improperly countersigned, and stayed on watch.

And one night last month, between one lamplighter's lamp and the next, Sootbeard blinked, and in the half-second of that blink, something crossed his street unobserved.

He wants it understood that he noticed the blink itself. A lesser monument, he says, would not have.

I heard of it through the pigeon-net: the gargoyle on Old Counting Row was attempting to file a report, and had been attempting for a month, and there was no one left in the city authorized to receive it.

I went and received it.

I sat on his ledge through a whole turning of the fog while he

delivered it, in the voice gargoyles keep — gravel settling in a well — and in the form he had held ready for a month, which was the form of his commissioning, sworn and structured: item, the night; item, the wind; item, the state of the lamps, lit wrong for weeks now, each error logged; item, the fog, which in three hundred years of his watch had never stood in the street past dawn-bell, logged standing so seventeen times this season, the intervals shortening — *the counts are rising; a sentry reports trend as well as incident*; item, at four minutes past seven bells by the Horologists' tower, an interference; a blink; duration estimated at one half-second; contents of street upon reopening of watch: unchanged; contents of street during closure: *unknown*, and the word came out of him like a stone breaking, because in three hundred years there had never been an unknown in his log.

"Something made me blink," he said. "Nothing makes granite blink. Nothing on the schedule of this world. It was not weariness. I do not tire; I erode, and I have three centuries of margin. Something reached into my watching and *spent* it."

He let that stand while the fog went by, and then made it worse.

"Understand the account it was drawn on. A monument's watch *is* its account. Three hundred years paid in, and nothing ever drawn out: no sleep, no holiday, no relief, no lapse. I am the richest unguarded purse in this city, and no man in three centuries has put a lock on me, because no man in three centuries has thought of me as money." The granite eyes came down. "Somebody has now. I wish to report a theft."

A theft of attention. The night of it, I confirmed against my ledger, was the murder night. Old Counting Row lies on the clean route between Gravamen's quiet channels and Needle Lane. Whoever went to my witch's parlor went through Sootbeard's watch, and paid the crossing with a coin that buys *inattention*, and the coin, I now knew from a gentleman's shelf-drawer, was wound-down life. You do not dodge a gargoyle. You purchase his blink.

"Your report is received," I said, and I meant it as a courtesy, and it landed on him like relief of watch. He asked to whom he should henceforth report. I gave him the truth: to me, for the present, in the matter of the murder of Elspeth Vane. He asked my rank. I considered the file, and the collar, and the strand, and I said: *the*

Needle's heir, investigating. Sootbeard saluted: granite grinding on granite, a fist to a brow, dust of three centuries sifting down. He has saluted me at every meeting since, and I have stopped trying to prevent it, because you cannot argue with an ordinance.

* * *

But a blink has no witness, by construction. That is what it is *for*. So we reconstructed it, Sootbeard and I, from the three witnesses on Old Counting Row that do not have eyelids.

His idea, not mine.

The first witness was the rain barrel at Number Nine. Standing water remembers ripples the way wax remembers heat — poorly, but honestly — and the Weft-side of a barrel's surface holds the pattern of its last true disturbances in a lattice a patient reader can lift. I read it by moonlight, paws on the rim, while Sootbeard recited the month's weather from memory to rule out the innocent rings, storm by storm, cart by cart, drunk by drunk. Under all of it, dated to his blink by the interference-fringe of a lamplighter's footfall he could vouch for: one set of ripples with no source. Rings spreading from a center that held *nothing* — something had passed the barrel closely, at speed, its wake writing on the water while its weight declined to exist. Small, the wake said. Low. Four-footed.

I wrote it in the ledger. The ledger and I did not discuss it.

The second witness was the dog. There is always a dog — Number Fourteen, a wall-eyed old mastiff who sleeps in the areaway and has barked at the night complete and without editorial judgment for eleven years. He did not bark at the crossing, of course. But a sleeping dog dreams its street, and dreams keep drafts of what the waking mind was robbed of. I sat with him, downwind of the dream, and in the draft of that night his street ran quiet and complete, and through it went a shape his dream had tried to bark at and could not, because every time the dream-bark rose the shape spent something and the bark *was already over*. What the dream had kept of it was an interruption with a silhouette. The silhouette had a tail.

The third witness was the frost.

It was the window of the old assay office, disused, north-facing, the kind of glass that grows the same fern-garden of frost every cold

night of its life — and frost-ferns, Sootbeard testified, grow by the breath of the street: every warm exhalation that passes bends the crystals' habit by a hair. On the murder night it had frozen hard. The pane held the record of every breath that had gone down Old Counting Row: the lamplighter's, the mastiff's slow tide, a late clerk's gin-warm mutter. And one passage of *no breath at all* — a corridor through the frost-garden where the ferns grew bent around a warmth that had come and gone between two of their branchings, faster than breathing, low to the ground, unbreathed because its bearer had, I understood this in my own chest with a jolt like a misjudged jump, *held its breath*. As you do. As I do, crossing a watched street.

Small. Low. Four-footed. Tailed. Breath held for the crossing.

Sootbeard ground through the same arithmetic beside me, three centuries of watch-craft arriving at the same address, and being Sootbeard, he filed it as a sentry files:

"Parameters, small colleague: small; low; four-footed; tailed; breath held for the crossing. There the report ends. My watch was closed for the duration of the interference. A sentry files what he saw, and I saw nothing. I do not log conclusions my eyes were shut for."

And he stopped, correct to the last grain of him, leaving a silence on the street where the conclusion belonged.

"A thing that has learned to travel as one," I said, first, into that silence. The ledger of my chest recorded that I had reached for that sentence the way a falling man reaches for a gutter, before anyone had said the word I was falling from.

* * *

The residue settled the method; the method still wanted a date. Sootbeard had one more service to render.

There is one other recorded blink in the city's history, reported forty years ago by the gargoyle over the Tatterstage door, on the opening night that closed the Tatterstage for good. The night-side has told that story to itself ever since in the same two sentences. The leading lady died in her dressing room an hour before the curtain, of the fog. Her understudy went on in her place and died on the stage in the middle of a line. That gargoyle was sold for hardcore when

the house closed, and his log survives only in Sootbeard's memory. To compare fringes, Sootbeard had to *attend the site*, and Sootbeard cannot fly. He was installed.

Which is how Wickrow was treated, at two of the morning, to a civic monument walking to the theater district roof-line by roof-line where the timbers would bear him, carrying in his two cupped fists, held at parade height before him like the regimental colors:

me.

Being carried is an indignity I have tolerated from one person in my life, and she is dead, and I sat in a gargoyle's fists above the sleeping city with the fog going by underneath, and I found that the indignity had somewhere in fifteen years become a thing I missed the way you miss a language.

The Tatterstage stands, barely, off the old theater square: boarded, bird-limed, the gilt gone. Its door-gargoyle's empty plinth remains over the architrave like a healed socket. Sootbeard set me down on it, took post on the parapet opposite, read the sight-lines of his lost colleague for a long silent time, and pronounced: same fringe. Same theft. Same coin, same hand, same *crossing-craft*, forty years apart.

"Your suspect," he said, "has been stealing half-seconds in this city since before you were littered, small colleague. Report continues below." A pause; granite eyes on the boarded door. "The house is not empty. It auditions."

* * *

Every night at the wrong hour, the Tatterstage holds auditions for a play that closed forty years ago. Nobody gets the part.

I went in through the fly-gallery, which meant the outside ironwork, and the outside ironwork meant three rests where a younger cat takes none. I have stopped pretending the rests are for looking around.

The great chandelier hung cocooned in its hoist-bag. On the stage, lit by nothing and visible the way the drowned are dry, a lady in a costume of a fashion two reigns gone was running a scene against the empty house.

The Understudy. That is the name the night-side gives her: she was the understudy who got her chance, and she died on that stage

mid-line, at her own opening, and she cannot leave until the scene *ends correctly*. The Hollow Court could tie her off, but she has declined the service, on the professional grounds that the scene is not over.

And she cannot finish it, because she remembers her death wrong, and rehearses the error.

Nightly she runs the scene toward her exit; nightly, at the fatal line, she directs her scene-partner into the wrong blocking; nightly the scene breaks, and the house sighs, and she begins again. She has directed forty years of auditioners into her own error.

She quotes only from plays; it is all the speech she has left. When I first came down the fly-rope she looked at me across the dark house and said, from some old comedy: "*Enter the cat, which is more than the management deserves,*" and I was hers from that line onward, and I do not care who knows it.

The true blocking still existed, in three places. The printed programme of the fatal production, with the scene-plot, survived in the collection of a retired prompter, ninety-one years old, sharp as vinegar, resident in a nursing-house that enforces a no-cats ordinance. Ordinances have gaps. The prompter talked to me for two hours the way the lonely talk to cats, reciting the blocking of a forty-year-old tragedy from memory while I purred, and the matron found nothing amiss but a faint warmth on an old man's knees.

The chalk ghost-marks were still under the boards of the Tatter-stage itself, preserved under forty years of dust like the frost-ferns in the assay glass. And the third witness was the Understudy's own body: a performer's feet remember what her grief has rewritten, if you can get her past the place where the memory flinches.

So we performed it. She and I. Cue by cue.

I cannot act, but her scene-partner's part, in the fatal scene, is silent: it enters, it crosses under the practical lamp, it stands where the light falls, and it *receives her line*. Forty years of auditioners had been directed by her, at the crux, to cross behind the lamp: her error, her enshrined mistake. A line delivered into darkness lands on nothing.

I took my blocking from the chalk and the prompter, not from her.

She swept toward the crux; her whole habit turned to direct

me into the error, in somebody else's words, as always, carried out of some other tragedy for the purpose: "*Away, sir; stand you in the shadow of it.*" I stood where the chalk said. Under the lamp. Downstage. In the light.

And her line found me there, and landed, and I saw forty years of rehearsal come apart in her face like the wisp-lattice. With the blocking true, she was standing where *she* had stood, saying what she had said, seeing what she had seen, and what she had seen was not what she remembered. The scene ended. Correctly. For the first time.

She stood a long moment in the practical lamp's light, unpicked at last from her own error, and before the Court's gentle machinery could arrive to tie her off she looked down at me and gave me her exit line. Her own. Not borrowed. The only unquoted sentence, I believe, that she had spoken in forty years:

"Two women died in this house that night, little one, and the notice counted one. Take them in order."

She said it the way a prompter reads a cue-sheet, and I understood that she had been holding the order of it for forty years with nowhere to set it down.

"My lady went first. An hour before the curtain, in her dressing room, with the fog standing in under her door and her throat closing on it quietly enough that nobody came. They wrote it down as the weather. The fog was *bought*. And write into your file what the bills never carried: my lady was a stitcher. She kept a seam under the greasepaint, silver, at the hairline, and I painted it over for her every night and asked no questions, because an understudy sees everything and says nothing."

"Then I went on in her place, with her lamp and her blocking and my name chalked over hers an hour before the house came in. And the same fog came up over the footlights at my crux and took my breath in the middle of a line."

She looked past me, out into the empty house, and gave me the thing I had come for without either of us having known it was the thing.

"And that is when I saw it, and I have had nowhere to put it until you. I know what a bought half-second is. It is made so that nobody can have seen it — nobody living, on the schedule of the

world, standing where a person stands. I was not standing where a person stands. I was mid-line and already going, half out of the schedule, and *the purchase did not cover the dying*. So I saw it come into the house, low, and cross under my own lamp, and take the prompt-breath out of the night. My line went out into a silence that had been *purchased*, and the house heard my heart refuse. It cost me my death to see it, little one. And I have spent forty years blaming my own feet.”

She straightened. Curtsied to the empty house, to the cocooned chandelier, to me.

“Tell them the notice was wrong,” she said. “The performance did not fail. It was *robbed*. And so were you.”

She took her bow. The house lights of some better theater came up for her, somewhere I could not follow, and the Tatterstage was, at last, only a building.

* * *

I sat on the empty stage a long time with the practical lamp cooling beside me. Some of that was the sum. Some of it was that standing a whole scene under a lamp had used what the ironwork had left me, and getting up was going to be a separate piece of work, and I was in no hurry to begin it.

The sum would not come out any way but one.

The technique was forty years old. Take the two deaths in her order. The lady first: a stitcher, silver at the hairline, one of Cardew’s *twice before*, killed by a fog that was bought. Then the understudy, who simply happened to be standing in the light when the purchase went through: the change the transaction gave back. Nobody counted the change, and the change is the only witness the case has.

The hand that murdered my witch had been working in this city for forty years, patient, close, mirror-handed, spending life like small coin. Forty years. The Circuit’s rival witches, the guild’s men, the whole day-side gallery of plausible suspects: I ran them through the new arithmetic that night and watched them fall out of it one by one, too young, too new, too *mortal*. What in Hollowmere is forty years at a craft and still working? Witches, a few. Gargoyles. Ghosts. The Gentleman, whose house is older than the question.

And cats, said the ledger, are allotted nine lives, and I have stood in the Clerk's corridor three times this season, once on the docket, twice REFUSED, and am writing this book.

So I wrote the name.

I want that on the record exactly as it happened. I was alone on the stage of a theater that had just finished being haunted, with the practical lamp going cold beside me. I opened the chest-ledger at the working page. And in the small hand, the hand I keep for entries against myself, I wrote a name that had been given to me once in an alley, flat, take it or leave it, by a creature who had held me still by the scruff while the watch went past.

Small. Low. Four-footed. Tailed. Breath held for the crossing. Forty years at a craft and still working, and working on the roofs, where the crossings are. It fitted the parameters without argument and without ceremony. It took no time at all. It had taken no time at all in Gravamen either, on a roof, in the dark, which is when I first did this sum and stopped doing it.

I looked at what I had written for about as long as it takes a cooling lamp to stop ticking.

Then I struck it out.

One stroke, left to right, the honest way, not a scribble; I could not even be dishonest about it properly. And the small hand, which does not take instruction from me and never has, wrote underneath what I had just done, because recording what I do is its entire office:

Struck out is not unwritten. A struck entry is still an entry. It is an entry with a line through it, the line is in my own hand, and the line is dated.

You cannot un-know a thing by drawing on it. All you can do is put on the record, in your own stroke, at your own hour, that you knew and declined to proceed. Any clerk in the Hollow Court would have told me so for nothing. I did not ask a clerk.

Then I bought myself a stranger.

There is a grey at the Court of Whiskers: the senior of the deputation that serves our papers, oldest of the old ones on the ropewalk roof, a tom of the right vintage, grown and working forty years ago. I entered him on the page above the struck line, in the big hand, where anybody might read it, and I set out three lines of sound reasoning to keep him company. The reasoning *was* sound. That is what makes

it the worst paragraph I have ever written. A suspect you do not love costs nothing to suspect. It is comfort with a docket number on it.

I hated every stroke of it, and I made every stroke.

Something crossed a sentry's street shaped as a cat. Something took the prompt-breath out of a theater, low, under the lamp. Something taught wisps a route, and travels the overstreets as if born to them, and cuts a familiar-thread with one clean bite, and ties close old-fashioned knots that neither death's clerks nor debt's gentleman can file. And over Gravamen, humming toward the water, hangs a familiar-thread with one voice in the chord, and I had not followed it, and I was running out of ways to tell myself why.

Forty years ago, something happened in this city worth a lifetime of half-seconds.

I needed the Remembered Days. All of them. And the only way to them was to sleep in the places where it is least safe for me to sleep, which is a sentence my witch would have underlined twice and forbidden once, and she is dead, and the forbidding has lapsed, and the underlining stands.

Chapter 8

The Remembered Days

The Witches' Circuit convened at the quarter-moon, in the long room above the Assay Court that they have used since before the Assay Court existed. Mother Cardew brought me in: she opened the door, looked at me sitting in the corridor, said "the cat is with me," and did not wait to see whether the room agreed.

Nine seats. One empty in the way that seats are empty when someone has died. And one empty in the way that seats are empty when someone is *late*, which in that room is its own scandal.

The Circuit maintains the Hush, the old binding that keeps Hollowmere's two sides politely separate, and it takes nine of them to do it. Seven of them frightened me when I came in, and by the end of the first hour I had stopped being frightened, because I had worked out what I was looking at.

At dusk on the night she died, the load she carried came onto the hands of everyone still holding. Seven pairs. It has not come off since. I watched a woman fall asleep sitting upright between two items of business and nobody remark on it. I watched another take up a stitch in her own lap under the table, out of habit, while the minutes were read, and lose the count, and start again. The Needle's seams wanted a new Needle, and the seven of them together, Cardew said later, without bitterness: *could not sew one year of her decade*.

So they were not going to look into anything. I want that recorded fairly, because I spent a month resenting it. It was not indifference and it was not a closing of ranks. There was no hand spare in that room to send after a murderer; every hand in it was holding

something up. Whatever was going to be done about Elspeth Vane was going to be done by whoever was not holding anything, and that was a cat.

One item of the session's business I did not understand until much later: the thread-merchants' notice of an undelivered order. Elspeth Vane, in the spring, had ordered forty spools of the deep silver, a decade's worth of warding thread, half paid in advance. With the order, read aloud to the table in her own impatient hand, a letter asking the Circuit for the loan of every steady needle it could spare, "for a work of renewal, before winter, that I have put off too long and will not put off past this year." The seven of them had assumed the water wall. I assumed the water wall. Nobody in that room knew what the Needle had decided to make permanent, or what the deciding would cost her, and the spools sit undelivered at the merchants' to this day.

The late seat arrived. Mistress Shear.

I will describe her fairly, because I came, in the end, almost to pity her. Sharp-boned, quick, dressed a half-degree finer than the room; a candidate's hunger worn thin over real skill. She is not a fraud; I watched her hands the whole session and the hands are good, journeyman-good, lattice-good. She had petitioned for the ninth seat twice while Elspeth lived and been declined twice, because the ninth seat is the Needle's seat and she does not have the hand. Everyone at the table knew it, and she knew they knew, and she came anyway, twice.

She spoke correctly of the dead. She moved correctly through the agenda. And when the session closed she stayed behind the others to examine, with correct and scholarly interest, the sampler of Elspeth's stitching that the Circuit keeps under glass.

I watched her want it. Her hands came up over the case and stopped, a half-inch off the glass, spread, held, the way a paw hangs over water with a fish in it. She stood like that longer than she knew, her face doing the correctness and her hands doing the truth, and in the glass under her fingers, reflected, the draped ninth chair. Then the hands came down to the frame's edge, and she examined the sampler *mirror-wise*, tracing the lines right to left, and my whole pelt stood up, quietly, under the draped chair where I had failed to leave with Cardew.

I took that to Brindle, because appetite for technique leaves receipts, and the Exchange reads receipts.

It took the Magpie three dawns and cost me the redeeming of the thimble. What Brindle's paper-net brought up was this: some weeks before the murder, a circular had moved through the quiet channels, fog-smelling paper, no signature but a small inked knot, offering for sale, to a discreet and qualified buyer, "the Needle's hand, demonstrated and taught." Stolen technique. The stitch of Elspeth Vane, on the market, while Elspeth Vane was alive.

And Mistress Shear had answered it. Paid earnest-money, heavily; there were promissory notes in the Exchange's tributary streams with her careful signature on them. And received, by way of demonstration, a sample: a hand's length of warding, unpicked in the Vane stitch, mirror-handed, delivered to her workroom inside a locked box she swears was never unlocked.

Then: nothing. No teaching, no second contact, her notes uncollected, her earnest-money never drawn. The seller had dangled the one thing her hunger could not refuse, proved it real, taken her name, and vanished, leaving her holding a sample of the exact technique that would shortly unpick a murder scene.

Suspect the third: a witch with the motive of an empty seat, the ambition of two declined petitions, and *physical possession of the murder method*. What she had done was buy. Nothing in the trail showed her doing anything else, and the buying was enough.

I carried the paper to Cardew: the circular, the earnest-notes, the locked box. The Circuit moved faster on that than on anything else it did all season, which I understood later — it was the one action available to a room with no hands free. Shear's workroom warrant was suspended by sunset, her needle sealed in the Circuit's own escrow, and the inquiry joined to the estate's docket at the Hollow Court, *for Lady's Day*. The date Wick had loaded like a trap for Elspeth was now the date on which everything Elspeth left behind would be weighed: her creditors and her imitators and her heir together in one room. Whatever I still owed this case, I owed it by Lady's Day.

Shear did not take the suspension quietly. She stood in the Circuit's corridor and said, to Cardew, in a voice I was not meant to hear, "You know my hands. Sixty years in this city, you know every

hand in it — you *know* mine cannot do what was done.” And Cardew, who does know every hand in it, said nothing at all, and the nothing followed me home. It was true, and I knew it was true, and I kept her pin on the board anyway, because the file was not yet ready to trade a possession for a protestation. The file keeps what I did, not what I ought.

* * *

The other entry has no case number, no client and no fee, and I have started it in four different chapters and moved it every time.

I went to my teacher with the parameters hot.

I want to be exact about my reasons, because the file deserves better than the ones I gave myself at the time. I told myself I was consulting the best roof-professional in Hollowmere on a question of crossing-craft, which was true. I told myself that a struck-out entry is a hypothesis a careful investigator eliminates rather than nurses, which was also true, and is the kind of true that a cat says out loud on a staircase to keep from hearing the other thing.

He was on the ridge of the tannery, at the end where the wind comes off the Shambles, sitting the way he sits: not waiting, exactly. Available.

“You have been walking about with your ears up for a week,” he said. “Ask it.”

So I asked it. I laid out Sootbeard’s report the way a sentry would want it laid out — the blink, the fringe, the barrel, the dog, the frost — and then I gave him the parameters, one at a time, and I watched him take each one the way a joiner takes a measurement. Small. Low. Four-footed. Tailed. Breath held for the crossing.

“What kind of creature,” I said, “crosses a sentry’s watched street and is not seen?”

He did not pause. I have gone back over that for a year now, looking for the pause, and there is no pause in it anywhere. He answered the way he answers everything, flat and worn smooth, an old professional handing over the plain terms of his trade to somebody who has finally asked the right question.

“An old one,” he said. “It stays low, because a watch reads the height of a man and the height of a dog and it does not read the

gutter. It is quiet at the pads, which is nine years of practice and cannot be bought. And it knows the street's schedule better than the street does: when the lamps go, when the boots come, where the sentry's eye rests when it is resting."

"And the half-second."

"The half-second is for the one step that none of that will cover." The one eye stayed on the Shambles. "There is always one. Every crossing in this city has one place where craft runs out and you are simply visible, and either you pay for that step or you do not make it. A professional knows which step it is on his own route. That is most of what a professional is."

"Who has that?"

"Anyone who has crossed the same streets for long enough to have counted them," he said. "It is not a gift, kit. It is arithmetic and forty years of legwork. It is the least mysterious thing in your file."

There it was, laid on the ridge tiles between us in the flattest voice on the night-side. A small, low, four-footed, tailed professional, with the schedules of this city in his head and the roofs under his pads, who knows exactly which step on any given crossing has to be paid for.

I have been asked since whether he was confessing. He was not. He was answering. That is the thing I cannot make anybody understand who did not sit on that ridge: there was no confession in it, because there was no concealment in it. He was telling me the truth about his trade, entire, in order, correctly, because I had asked and because he does not do the other thing. If I had said the next sentence — and the next sentence was four words long, and I had it whole, and it was sitting in my mouth like a stone — he would have answered that correctly too.

I did not say it.

I said, "That is useful," and he said, "It is not," and neither of us said anything else about it, and the wind came up off the Shambles, and after a while he told me the pigeons were roosting wrong at the Mereside end and that I should look at it, and he was right, and I did, and everything that is left in this file came out of it.

But there is a thing that happened in between, and it is the only reason this entry is in the file at all. There was a quarter of a minute on that ridge, after the answer and before "that is useful," when

neither of us spoke. I have never been able to decide what was in it. I know what was in it on my side. I have no evidence at all about his, except that he did not fill it, and he is not a cat who is troubled by a silence, and he let that one run its whole length before he looked away at the Shambles and left it to me to close.

I walked home the long way, over roofs I did not need, and let myself in, and Tansy was asleep in the coal scuttle with one paw over her face. And I did not open the chest-ledger. I straightened the pins on the case board instead, all of them, every pin, one by one, squaring the papers under them until the whole board was tidier than it had been since the spring. Then I washed, thoroughly, twice, and went to sleep on a case that had gained nothing that day, and slept, for once that season, extremely well.

* * *

Now the entry I have been walking past since I began this chapter. It stays. She would make it stay.

By that week I was sewing for half the night-side. Word of the Lamplighters' mended hem had gone around the roofs, and the requests came the way they used to come to her cork board: the roost-boards wanted their weather-hems seen to, a midwife wanted her door-ward deepened, and the fish market at Thimblefield wanted its cold-stores stitched against the season, Pell's market, the row of stalls where half the strays I know are fed on the mornings' misweighings. I took all of it.

Every stitch is paid at the pull. Hers came out of memory and warmth and luck and years, and I watched her pay for fifteen years and never once asked what *I* was paying, because the work came easy and easy work feels free. It is not free. She named my coin for me at the parlor door when I was nine months old and could not see why a mend of four seconds should cost anything at all, and the coin is sleep, and I had been spending it all season without keeping the book.

Add it up, which I did not. Six roost-boards. Two weather-hems and a chimney-hitch. A midwife's door-ward, deepened twice. A season of the night-side's small repairs, done for nothing, and no night in eleven weeks that I had slept the whole of.

I was fifteen years old. I had been stiff in the mornings for two winters before any of this began, and I had a working arrangement with that: get up late, get up slowly, and be warm at the correct times. There was no late and no slowly left in that week. I got up on the hour I was wanted and I went out on it, and by the eleventh week my hind legs had begun arriving at the roofline a beat after the rest of me, and I had stopped noticing, which is the part I would take back.

I sewed the cold-store ward at the end of a night that had already spent me. My paws were slow at the tuck and I could feel them being slow. There is a looking you do before an anchor-loop, nose on the timber, and it is the cheapest thing in the trade and I did not have it in me. I set the loop against a beam that was salt-rotted an inch under the surface. I would have known. I did not go and find out.

Two nights later the fog came up the market lanes and leaned on my stitching the way a customer leans on a scale, and the loop pulled through the rot, and the seam opened at the corner where the widow Hake keeps her smoking-stall, and her banked coals went over into the netting.

I was on the roof-ridge when it went, asleep sitting up, which is a thing I had started doing that season. I went down into the smoke because her winter stock was in that stall and her lock was warded — my warding; nothing was getting in past my warding, including her — and I got the ward unpicked and the door open and the water-chain working. It took me three goes to get up onto the chain-post. That is the whole of it: a jump I had made a hundred times, and I made it on the third attempt, in smoke, with a woman's winter burning behind me.

The stall burned anyway. All of it. A winter of smoked fish, a widow's whole margin, gone to a smell that sat on Thimblefield for three days. The last thing I did in the smoke was carry out the stall-cat's kitten, and I did it at a walk, because a walk was what I had, and the beam I had trusted came down on me, and I was dead before I finished being useful.

The corridor. The desk. And this time, in front of the desk, where there has only ever been the one human-sized chair: a second chair. Cat-sized. Placed, not left, squared to the desk's edge, the way he squares everything.

Neither of us mentioned it. I got up on it. My file was already open on the desk.

“An accident,” said the Clerk, and the pen wrote REFUSED before he had finished the word. “The desk does not process falling timber. You will be returned, minus the fee.” He took the fee. Then he did not close the file, and in that room, a thing not done is a thing said. “A word on your account, since you insist on running one. You have spent one life truly, on the docket, in the parlor. The next true death you keep — and you will keep more; I have seen your season’s calendar — carries the Toll. The Toll is not a fee, familiar. Fees come out of what you carry. The Toll comes out of what you *are* — one Remembered Day, of the Court’s choosing, surrendered entire. The Court is not cruel in its choosing. It is worse; it is indifferent.” He closed the file then, and took up the pen, and said, to the paper, in the voice he keeps for the things that are not in the ledger: “Sew less tired.”

Sew less tired. I took it as kindness at the time, and it took me a season to hear what it was: not *you were careless*, not *you were proud*, but an auditor reading a balance aloud to the account-holder. The desk could see where the fault came from. The desk could see it from down there.

I climbed the stairs with a burnt winter on my back.

The widow Hake never knew a cat was in the fire. The night-side made it good as the night-side does: fish arrived on her step at dawns, unexplained, all season; Pell fed her out of his own margin and called it a loan so she would take it, and I have seen her feeding his strays since with the fierceness of a woman paying interest nobody billed her for.

But her winter burned because my stitch failed, and my stitch failed because I had been sewing on no sleep for eleven weeks and had never once counted them. I opened a page that morning and headed it in the big hand, where the small hand could not get at it and soften it: *the fog leans on weak work now. Yours included. Sew less tired.* Under the heading I began, for the first time in my life, to keep the tally of what my own stitching costs, night by night, in hours not slept.

And then I went hunting the past deliberately, and the way you hunt the past is: you sleep where it is not safe to sleep.

I had the shape of the thing by then, from four of them, kept and compared. A Remembered Day does not come where it is safe. It comes where the body has lain down inside old danger and knows it. Sleep on the hearthrug and you dream of dinner. Sleep on the Wickhouse rafters over the water wall, over the fed thing turning below, and—

Warm. Lamplight. The table. The chart of the water wall, half-sewn, and me small and certain on the middle of it, and her voice above, amused, talking to the needle: "That winter I tried eight strays. . ."

I have given the reader that one already. But dreams, revisited, keep drafts: this time it ran longer. This time her needle stopped, in the dream, and her hand came down and rested on the small sleeping certainty of me, and she said, to the cat on the chart, to the room, "Nine is the correct number. Nine is the number I owe." And the needle went back to the wall-chart, and the word *owe* went into me like a splinter.

And there is a limit on days like that one, which I had never had cause to test. What comes up in them is *hers*. Every Remembered Day I have ever been given is a day Elspeth Vane stood up in, and I have it because she left something of herself in me and it has not all gone yet. It cannot show me a market morning three generations before she was born.

And I had been shown one.

So the market morning came from somewhere else, and it took a night of lying awake to work out where I had been lying *down*. The Wickhouse rafters run over the water wall. The water wall is the near end of the seam. And a seam remembers what it was made to refuse. That is the first plain fact of the trade: ask any stitcher what her oldest ward smells of and she will tell you, without thinking about it, that it smells of the thing it was set against. Wards are arguments, and an argument carries its opponent inside it, or it is not an argument.

So there are two sources and I had been reading them as one. Sleep with what she left in me and I dream her days. Lie my whole small length along the top of a forty-year refusal, and I dream what

the refusal is refusing: the city's older business, which was nobody's memory to keep, and has been down there the whole time with nothing to do but remain the case.

I slept on the sea-wall at the Mereside edge, in the fog's own doorway, with Sootbeard standing over me all night. He had insisted. The operational posture of the watch, he said, extends to colleagues sleeping irregularly. And I dreamed the forty-year night.

The city before. The dream opened on Hollowmere as no map has ever shown it me, and I understood, slowly, that I was being shown *why there was a working at all*. The city was built on the Mere because the Mere was the wealth: the black water ran deeper than any coast for a hundred miles, and ships came up the fog like gifts, and the first quays were rich before they were safe. And the water collected. Not storms; the Mere has never needed weather. The dream showed me a street of the old Mereside with its lamps going out one at a time from the water upward, unhurried. And a market morning with the Drowned standing among the stalls, arriving, always arriving, while the sellers worked around them with their eyes down.

The city kept a tithe then. The dream did not show me what the tithe was; it did not have to. An old rat on a throne of corks had told me in the spring, in front of his whole court, and I had written it down and not understood that I was writing down the foundation of everything. *The first of everything*. First catch, first light of a new hearth, first child of a bad year. Down to the water, and the water took it, and nobody called it monstrous, because everybody's grandmother had paid it and everybody's grandmother ate that winter. That is the bill. That is what she stood on the black glass to refuse. I had been calling it a monster all season, and it was not one; it was a party that had been paid for four hundred years and then was not. The dream showed me the bells: nine of them, and the ninth rung slow on the mornings after the water had collected, one stroke for each thing taken, and the city counting along in doorways, and I woke the first time there, with my own mouth making the count.

The lake did not hate. Hate would have been *safer*. The thing under the water kept accounts, the way the sea keeps tides, and the city had run up a very old bill and then produced, at last, in one generation, a witch who proposed to close the account another way.

That is all the seam is. A refusal, sewn shut, of a debt older than the city's name. And under the refusal, for forty years, the creditor, reading the stitching, with the patience of a thing that has never once been paid late by anything except Hollowmere.

Nine bells. That is the first piece and it rang through all the others: the tower giving its full old count, one to nine, and the ninth bell's voice was deep and certain and it is the only time I have ever heard it, awake or asleep. The city used to have one more hour of night, and the hour had a bell, and the bell was rung that evening on purpose, because the working needed the whole nine.

The barge. Black water lying dead calm and lightless, and out on it, a barge without a bargeman, and the Circuit of forty years ago on the quays with every lamp in the city turned toward the Mere. And the lamps' order mattering; the Lamplighters walking their sequence like a loom's shuttle, lighting a pattern across the whole town; I woke with my paws working and slept back down into it.

Her. Young, younger than I ever knew her, hair dark, hands already hers, going out onto the black glass *alone*, on foot, on the water, because the working wanted the Needle and no other weight. And the fog on the far shore stood up in shapes that were not the fog, and under the water something *hoped*: something old and patient and vast, risen the whole way to the underside of the surface, pressed against the world like a face against glass. The Mere, before the seam. What all the lamps were for.

The grey shape. At the edge of every piece of the dream, close to her skirts, on the black water where nothing else could walk except her and it: a smallness. Grey. Four-footed. The dream kept it at the corner, always at the corner — dreams are tactful; hers especially; even remembered, she was minding what a cat should see. But I know how a familiar stands to a witch at work. I have stood so for fifteen years. The grey shape stood so.

The seam. And then the working itself, which I cannot render and will not try beyond this: she sewed the lake shut. Standing on it. Stitch by stitch across a closing that ran from the Wickhouse shore to the far fog, her needle taking the light of the ordered lamps as thread takes wax, the ninth bell tolling the measure. And each great stitch had to be *paid at the pull*, and I watched the payments go: memory, a whole quarter of the sky of the dream went dark and

stayed dark; warmth, the winter that followed was in her hands for the rest of her life; luck; years.

And then the working reached the last stitches, the anchor of the whole seam. The price of an anchor is not memory, or warmth, or luck, or years.

And here the dream went tactful again, and it went tactful in the one direction I did not want it to.

It turned to the corner. It gave me her hand going careful, in a way I had seen that hand go careful perhaps four times in fifteen years. It gave me the needle slowing, and stopping, and starting, and stopping, a thing being counted out rather than paid over. And it gave me nothing else. I have gone back into that corner twice since, deliberately, the way you press a tooth, and the corner is where the dream ends and I wake with my mouth open.

What I have is this. The anchor was set. It cost what anchors cost, which is not memory or warmth or luck or years. And at the corner, close to her skirts, on water that was still holding and would have carried it anywhere it liked, the grey shape stayed.

That is the detail I woke on, both times I have dreamed it since. *It did not run.* It stood to her the way a familiar stands at the work, and whatever the work was doing at that corner, it did not run.

She came back off the water alone.

The dream would not show me the shape's face. I have written that last sentence four times now, trying to get some of the weight off it, and it will not come off: *she came back off the water alone.*

And fifteen years afterward, on a chart-table, to a sleeping stray, the same voice said: *nine is the correct number. Nine is the number I owe.*

I do not know what she owed. I do not know to whom, or on what account, or what the anchor took to the last item of it. But she was still saying it fifteen years later, in an empty room, to a needle, with nobody in the house awake but a kitten.

* * *

I woke on the sea-wall in the grey before dawn with the fog going out on the ebb. The ebb was *late*. A cat who has lived fifteen years

by a tidal city's clock does not mistake this: the water hung on the stone a quarter-hour past its own appointment before it consented to turn, and Sootbeard confirmed it against the Horologists' tower with the satisfaction of a sentry whose trend-line is filling in. The *WATCH THIS* page took it in four words, *the tide argues now*, and I lay still a long time.

Forty years ago my witch sewed the Mere shut, and paid for every stitch of it at the pull, and at the anchor of it there was a grey familiar standing at her skirts on black water, and the dream will not tell me one thing more than that.

That familiar is in no record I have ever heard recited. Not the Court's rolls, not the Circuit's minutes, not the old ones' recitations on the ropewalk roof, where they can name every cat of consequence back four generations and enjoy doing it. Grey, at the greatest working this city has ever seen, and then nothing. Missing. Not dead.

Missing-not-dead is the category this whole case has been orbiting since the spring: the coats on their pegs, the wraiths that have not frayed, the Court's returned filings, a warehouse of wax with no bodies in the accounting. I filed the distinction that morning in the words a kitten had given me over a saucer, because she had got there in one sentence and it had taken me a season.

And the technique that killed my witch is forty years old and works in her mirrored hand.

The thing under the water, which hoped, has been *finding* things ever since the seam began to loosen. Finding wax. Finding the missing. And finding someone: someone with her exact stitch, learned from in front, mirror-wise, across a decade of lamplit evenings on the near side of the work.

I stood up on the sea-wall and looked out at the flat black glass, and then up, at the one-voiced familiar-thread humming its long grey line over the city, toward the water.

The pigeons of the Mereside roosts, I noticed, were silent. Still. Again. Down here the silence had never really lifted at all.

Whatever I believed and was refusing to believe, the next thing was the same either way. Follow the thread. All the way. To whatever is on the end of it.

I went home first, and slept the honest kind of sleep, and ate the breakfast Tansy had saved me half of, and I sharpened every claw I

own on the doorpost of a dead woman's house, and then I went to spend some lives.

Chapter 9

The Quiet Roosts

The board had one outstanding bill older than the thread, and I paid it first. I interviewed the grey.

I found him on the ropewalk roof, alone, at the harbor end, where the wind comes up the walk with the whole Mereside in its mouth. He is older than Bodkin to look at, blunt-clawed, heavy in the hips the way the very old toms go, and he watched me come the length of the ridgeline without moving anything but the good ear.

I had entered him in the log for being the right vintage and kept him there for being seen on the Mereside at hours no court business explains. And I climbed to that roof *wanting* him. I put my questions the way you set a snare, and I read every answer twice looking for the wrong in it.

He talks the way the old ones talk when they have stopped performing for anybody: half of every sentence left where he had worn it smooth years ago, the listener expected to fetch it. I asked what took him Mereside by night. "The rails," he said, and looked at the harbor. I asked what was at the rails. "Fewer," he said, "every year."

It took the better part of an hour and all my manners to assemble it. A kitten-hood fed by the roost-keepers of the Mereside dovecotes, sixty years gone: scraps on the ledges for a starveling grey, in the years when nobody else left him anything. And an old tom's vigil kept ever since, on rails that have been emptying for a decade, bird by bird, going-down by going-down, and no one told. "Because who does a cat tell," he said, "that the birds are going into the water.

You. Apparently.”

His paws settled it, if the vigil had not. I read them while he talked: no splice-callus, no thread-groove, claws gone round as riverstones. Those paws had not worked a stitch in this century. I had known it, truly, by the third sentence. I stayed the hour anyway, asking snare-questions of a grieving old sentry, because the alternative to suspecting him was a name I had written once already and drawn a line through, and he knew that too, I think. When I left he said the only whole sentence he gave me all night: “Whatever you came up here to find, young one, I hope for your sake it is not where you have been not-looking.”

I entered his testimony and struck his name off the board with my own paw. I left the ropewalk with the board one name lighter and the not-looked-at place one name heavier.

* * *

The thread ran south-southwest, high and taut and tended, and I followed it.

Tended is the word that mattered. Threads slacken. A familiar-thread whose witch-end has gone silent should hang slack, and mine does. This one was taut half across the city, and where the roofline winds had frayed it, it was *mended*: neat grey splices set at intervals of years, each of them tied by somebody with no hurry in his hands. Somebody had been maintaining a dead line for four decades.

It crossed the Shambles high over Brindle’s stall. It crossed Wick-row within sight of Sootbeard’s corner, and I wondered, passing, how many of its menders’ crossings his log had never held. And then it began to descend, wide and slow, down the terraces of the Mereside, and it dipped, before the water, at the roosts.

On the fourth terrace I passed a wraith. There are enough of them down there that I had stopped logging them. This one wore no clothes. It wore a *silhouette*: the whole outline of a man, hat and coat and the particular set of one shoulder, held up and kept. I sat a respectful distance off and asked it where its own man had gone. It did not speak; wraiths do not. It *pointed*. One long silhouette-arm, unhurried, certain, out past the sea-wall at the black glass of the

water, and it held the point until I had finished looking, and then put the arm down and went back to standing.

I understood the rest of it a hundred yards further down. A wraith whose owner is spent frays inside a season, coming apart at the cuffs of itself. That one was crisp as new laundry. Its man was held somewhere, whole, and it knew, and it was keeping his outline pressed against a homecoming it had no date for. *Held is not spent.*

The quiet roosts. I had been hearing the phrase all season: the Mereside dovecotes, the oldest pigeon-fastness in the city, from which the Post's silence had never really lifted. Toby's seed, the bought election, the murder-night hush: all of it had washed out of the upper city with the seed audit. Down here it had not. Down here, I discovered that night, there was nothing left to wash.

The roosts were empty.

Not roosting-elsewhere empty. Empty the way the Lamplighters' hall was empty: coats over boots. Dovecote after dovecote, terrace after terrace, standing open to the fog. Droppings gone chalky with weeks. Seed rotting in the throats of the feeders.

And over it all the deep wrong Mereside silence, which I now understood was not the absence of pigeon-noise but the *presence* of something else: the hush you hear inside a bell after it has been stopped with a hand.

One bird remained.

He was old past flying, blind in both eyes, deaf — I judged — to everything but vibration, and he sat his empty rail in the greatest dovecote like a postmaster at a closed counter, and he was, I realized as I came up the ladder-holes making my footfalls heavy so as not to lie to him, the only creature in that whole city of the missing who had never once been asked for his testimony, because who would climb to ask it? A cat climbed. The last witness of the quiet roosts gave his deposition to a cat, feeling the questions through the wood of the rail.

What he gave me, in the pidgin of taps and stillnesses we built between us over an hour: the quiet had not come with the murder. The quiet had come up the chimneys *years* ago, slow as damp — first the dreams going out of the squabs, then the gossip going out of the elders, then, roost by roost, the going. Not flight. Going. *Down.* They went to the water to be paid, he tapped. They went to the

water to be paid, and the payment was the quiet.

The seed on the upper roofs bought a single night of silence from the living. Down here the silence had been bought outright, whole roosts of the Post's oldest stock drawn toward the black glass over years, fed forward the way the wax was fed, to the account of a patient thing whose seam was loosening.

I left the old bird my second-to-last strip of dried herring, wedged where his rail meets the post. He stood on one foot upon it, which among the Post is the taking of salt, and he tapped one thing more, unasked, as I went down the ladder-holes: *the mender comes at the neap*. The mender. Comes at the neap tide, when the water is furthest withdrawn and the flats lie bare. He had felt the mender's footfalls on the roost-boards for forty years, four small drumbeats, lighter than a gull's. And the visits and the goings-down, he wanted me to know, had *kept different calendars*. The mender tended the thread. Something else emptied the roosts. Two hands on the Mereside, and he had outlasted them both, and could tell them apart blind, and nobody had asked.

He had been sitting on that rail for ten years with all of it, and nobody had climbed.

* * *

There was one more door on the Mereside I had business with, and I went to it out of bookkeeping.

In the nights after the fire I had gone back over every ward I sewed that tired week and sewed it again rested, because the ledger said to. The last of them was a midwife's, on the third terrace, a narrow house with a blue sill. Rennet. She had asked me for a deeper door-ward in the first place because a midwife answers her door at hours when nobody good is knocking, and I had given her the best hem in me: doubled at the hinge, anchored into sound wood, every timber of the frame read before I put a stitch in it. I had been proud of that door. Record the pride. It is part of the price.

The door stood open.

Not forced. Open the way a door is open when somebody has walked out through it and not troubled to pull it to. Inside, the house

was in order. The fire banked. The pot scoured and turned over. Her trade chalked up on the inner face of the doorpost, four births that month and a fifth pending, with the fifth one's week marked. Her bag on its hook beside the door, packed — a midwife's bag is always packed — which meant she had not been called out. Nothing was taken. I went through that narrow house twice, low and high, the way you go through a room after a smell, and the only thing missing from it was the woman.

Then I read the frame, and stopped being a detective for a while.

The ward had not failed. Enter that plainly, because I had spent the whole week expecting my own bad work to come and find me, and this was not my bad work. My hem was whole. It had been *lifted*: taken up out of the wood stitch by stitch, in reverse, mirror-wise, from the last stitch back to the first, the way you take up a hem you mean to give back. No snags. No pulled grain. No hurry anywhere in it.

And then coiled. The thread of my own working lay on the sill in a small neat coil with the loose end tucked under, the way she taught me to leave any thread I had finished with.

I sat on that sill a long time with my work under my paw.

The tabby who keeps the coal-chute two doors along had been out all night on her own business and had heard nothing at all, and said so with the flatness of a witness who works out, halfway through her own sentence, what her testimony means. Nobody screams through a lifted hem. There is nothing to scream at. The door simply stops being a door.

Here is the arithmetic of that house, entered in the small hand. She asked me for a stronger ward. I gave her one, and it held, and the holding is exactly what made her worth the trouble: a hand that can lift my stitch off a frame gets a house with nobody awake in it, no hole in the wall, and no explaining to do at dawn. I did not fail Rennet. I *marked* her. Every door I have sewn on the night-side this season is a door with my hand on it, and my hand, it turns out, is legible clear across the city to exactly one reader.

Nothing was taken out of that house because she was what the house had.

I went home over the roofs, and got the chest-ledger down off the mantel, and opened it at a clean page, and wrote the name at the

head of it in the small hand.

I did not strike it out.

* * *

It was the neap.

The tide-tables are posted at the fish market. I read them at dawn from the top of Pell's shutter, with the burnt-stall smell still hanging over the row and the widow Hake's pitch swept bare beside him, and Pell looked up from his scrap-bucket and said, "Mind the water, puss." He had no way of knowing what he was saying. He says it to all of us, every dawn, all season, and he had been saying it since before the roosts began to empty.

I told myself I went down to the flats because the thread's last descent crossed them and the knot in its lowest slack could be read nowhere else. That was true. I went down at the neap because the mender came at the neap, and some part of me wanted to *see*.

The Mere at neap-ebb: black flats shining like a spilled mirror, the fog withdrawn to a waiting distance. The thread came down out of the dark in one long curve and ran its final length a paw's height over the flats, out past the last stone, toward the deep pool that never ebbs.

And in its lowest slack, just past the last stone, there was a knot. I could see it from the wall. Close work. Old-fashioned.

I saw the rest coming, and went anyway. The fog stood off the flats in a horseshoe, waiting with the manners of an usher. The pools between the stones lay too still. I counted five of the Drowned, spaced across the flats, dry-footed on the wet mirror, standing in the open where I could not fail to count them. Nothing down there was hiding from me. I was expected, and I had the whole width of the flats to change my mind in. The appointment was announced, as the Clerk had promised.

I paid it.

I went out over the flats.

I had died twice that season and been sewing on no sleep since the spring, and the body I took out onto that mirror was fifteen years old and knew it. The first stretch I took soundless, which is

the cheap part, and the cheap part was already loud in my chest. There were two gaps where I had to run, and I ran the first one and had to stop at the far side of it and stand with my mouth open like a dog. At the cold places, where the mirror came up through my pads, I felt something of hers go out of me to meet it, the way it does, and I felt how little of her was left to go. She had put fifteen years of evenings into me. I spent some of them on a hundred yards of wet flat because there was no other way across, and I have never got them back.

I ran the second gap slower than the first. Then I reached the last stone, and I read the knot with my nose an inch from forty years of close grey splicing, and I learned the two things I had come to learn.

First: the knot was kin to the knots on my own thread. Not similar. *Kin*: the same hand's habit, the same tuck and doubling, the mend of a mender who learned mending in one particular lamplit parlor. I had carried its brothers at my own chest through every refusal at the Clerk's desk and never once been able to look at them squarely.

Second, and it has never left me: a familiar-thread hums with its two lives, a chord. This one, an inch from my ear, hummed its single sustaining note, and the note was in *her key*. The twin of the thread I wear. Whatever hung at the far end of this line, out past the last stone, under the black glass or over it, my witch had bound it to herself once, the way she later bound me, and its half of the chord was the half mine will make when I am gone.

There was a third thing. I had not come for it, and it did not wait to be asked.

A lamp came down the terraces behind me, swinging on a round that does not exist. I knew the walk before I knew the man — a lamplighter's pace, steady as chalk-strokes — and then I knew the man: Fenn, whose round Merrow rated the steadiest of her remaining four, the same lamplighter who had put his face in his hands the night I mended the hall's ward. He came down the sea-stair and out onto the mirror with his lamp lit and his eyes open and nothing behind them. I ran at him. I put myself under his boots and made every noise I own, and he stepped around me the way you step around furniture in a house you have lived in all your life, and set his lamp down on the mud, and walked into the horseshoe of fog, and the fog leaned in from three sides and folded him away standing. It

was quick, and it was gentle, and it is the worst thing I have watched in this city. His lamp went on burning where he left it.

Then the fog spoke to me.

It has no voice of its own. It has never needed one. It holds the voices of everyone it has taken — held, in escrow, unspent — and it spent some now, one sentence at a time, each sentence in a different mouth.

“Stand aside,” it said, in an old lamplighter’s voice, the voice of a man whose route has walked him longer than he walked it.

“Let the seam open,” it said, in a woman’s voice with the roost-keeper’s burr in it.

“And we walk home tomorrow,” it said, in a child’s voice. “On the morning ebb. All of us.”

The offer was plain and I will report it plainly. Not power. Not my lives back. Not the case. Every name on this file walking up the terraces in one grey morning, against one cat standing aside from one seam.

I did not think about the coats or the roosts. I thought about a hall door with hundreds of chalk strokes on it, and the woman who put them there standing where she always stands, facing the way bad news has to come in. Merrow has lit lamps for the missing every night since the night they went, and she has never once said the word she is not permitted to say about them, and if I stood aside she could stop. That is what was being offered. The chalk washed off with one bucket, and her people coming up the terraces into their own coats while she watched from the door.

It had priced me correctly. It did not offer me one thing for myself.

I listened to every voice it spent, and the last voice was Fenn’s — five minutes held, and lent back already — and Fenn’s voice said, “It is warm down here, cat.” That was the only sentence in the whole transaction I believe was a lie.

And under the listening I did the one thing I am for. I audited. Voice after voice, mouth after mouth, the whole inventory of the city’s held — and one voice was not in it, and could not be in it, and was never going to be in it. The Mere returns what it holds; it holds the missing, whole, at the bottom of the world. She is not at the bottom of the world. She is nowhere a lake can reach. Dead is not held; spent is spent; it is her own iron law, and the lake, of all

creditors, keeps it. If it could have said one sentence in her voice, I think it would have owned me. It could not, and it knew it could not, and so it stood there in its ring, holding out a city.

“No,” I said.

Fenn’s lamp burned on the mud between us, and I made myself look at it while I said the rest, because a refusal is cheap until you price it in other people’s coats.

“I am her estate. The estate declines. The seam stays sewn. I will find another way to bring them up — and if there is none, charge that to me. Not to her seam.”

The fog took the horseshoe apart without hurry. The voices went back into escrow. There was no anger in any of it. I had said no to something that had been waiting four hundred years to be paid and expected, on the evidence, to be paid that night, and it put its offer away the way a creditor puts away a paper the debtor will not sign: without heat, and without going anywhere.

The lamp on the mud went out. Not blown. Drunk.

The tide does not run at the neap. The Mere is not the tide.

The water came up the flats in one silent folding, unhurried, total, like a page being turned by something reading in bed, and the five who had stood aside all evening to let me get out here closed in and took me. I had spent what I had crossing out, and the last thing I did with the last of my breath was the thing my whole training had been for: I looked. Down through the black turning glass toward the pool that never ebbs, where something vast lay against the underside of the world with the patience of owed money, looking back up at me with what a lake has instead of a face, and *hoping*. And past it, at the edge, at the tactful corner of my own drowning, four small drumbeats on the mirror-flats, lighter than a gull’s, going away.

The cold went. Then the noise. Then the part of me that was worried about the noise. The offer stayed.

* * *

“Back so soon,” said the Clerk. “The form remembers you, which saves us both time.”

The desk. The lamp. The queue of one. This was no refusal and both of us knew it: the appointment had been posted on the flats in

five standing figures and I had kept it with my eyes open. My second true death, of nine. The Toll was taken, and it was not a quantity. The schedule named its fee, and the fee was a Remembered Day, itemized in the Court's short hand. The chart-table. The lamplit evening at the half-sewn wall-chart, me small and certain in the middle of her work, her voice above, amused, talking to the needle: *That winter I tried eight strays*. It went across the desk whole, the way a coin goes: entirely, and to someone else. I keep the words; they are in the chest-ledger, and notes are not the thing. The warmth of that table belongs to the Hollow Court now.

He took it professionally, and almost gently, and neither helped. And the stamp with its paw-print came down on a page that did not say REFUSED, and the not-saying sat in the corridor's cold light like a stone.

Then came the measuring.

He drew my thread out along the brass rule set into the desk's edge, the way a draper runs a bolt, and read its length against the ledger. The first time, I had been too newly dead to notice him do it. He read it. He stopped.

He ran it back through his fingers, slowly, spectacles down, to the first of the small grey knots, the mends I have carried since the refusals began, and he examined it for a long time, and then the next, and the next, and I sat in the cat-sized chair, which was mine now the way the mantel was mine, by treaty and silence, and watched death's own clerk confront a document he could not file.

"There is work on this thread that is not ours," he said, at last. "I have noted it before. I have written CLERICAL ERROR, once, and I do not write fiction, as a rule." He looked at me over the spectacles. "Close work. Old-fashioned. Whoever ties these does not care to have them noticed — and they are *mends*, sir. Someone has been re-tying you. Your arithmetic will not balance because it is being balanced from outside, between my audits, by a hand that pays nothing in and takes nothing out and appears in no schedule of this Court." He laid the thread down with the exaggerated evenness of a man mastering an emotion unbecoming to his office. "Your file is the thickest irregularity below this city, and it is attracting *attention*, and I find—" he stopped, and turned the lamp up a degree, which I had learned by then to read as the outer limit of his tenderness,

“—I find I no longer altogether mind. Go carefully. That is not in the form.”

He was not quite done. He turned the ledger back to the season’s first page, and laid one translucent finger on an entry there, and left it a moment without comment. “One thing more, sir. Your first death. The parlor. It kept an appointment — and this Court did not post it. The line for the posting hand is blank.” He looked at the blank the way he had looked at the knots. “I have kept this desk a long time. I have never once seen that line blank.”

He walked me out himself, that visit. Down the corridor of shelves. And at a cross-aisle I had passed on every visit and never once turned down, something in the dark *breathed*.

One long bronze note, below hearing, felt in the floor: the sound a great bell makes in its sleep, years after the last time it was rung, when a footfall crosses its vault. I stopped. The Clerk stopped. Down the cross-aisle, behind a grille, lay a bell the size of a parlor, green-shouldered, dust-shrouded, its docket hanging from its crown on grey ribbon like a toe-tag.

“Ah,” said the Clerk. “Yes. The Ninth.”

He said it the way you name a colleague’s old scandal, and I received at last the answer to the first wrong thing I ever noticed, eight bells from the tower and no ninth any more, and the answer was: *pawned*.

Pawned to the Hollow Court a century ago, by the city itself, in council, under seal, collateral against a plague-season’s worth of unpaid Tolls, and never redeemed. Since the night they hauled it down, said the Clerk, in the tone of a man quoting a finding he had signed and not liked, the city’s nights have run one hour short: the ninth hour of the dark was rung by the ninth bell, and an hour that is never rung is never *kept*, and so it pools down here with the rest of the unclaimed. Nobody in Hollowmere has dreamed a dream to the end in a hundred years. The bell sleeps in an evidence vault with the whole unspent hour of the city banked in its bronze, accruing.

“It did not only ring the hours,” the Clerk added, in the tone of a footnote. “The hours kept the appointments.”

The working of forty years ago had rung nine bells; I had heard them in the Remembered Day, and the ninth had been rung *out of this vault*: signed out, the docket showed, for one night, on the

Circuit's surety, for the great sewing; and returned. The last time it spoke. Her seam was rung shut on a pawned bell's borrowed voice.

I asked to see the surety. I want that entered exactly: I asked about a bell. I was standing in front of a grille in a cold corridor being a clerk about a bell, and the Clerk turned the docket on its grey ribbon so I could read it, and the surety ran onto a second sheet, and the second sheet was the accounts of the great sewing, because the Court files what happened next to what it happened for.

The lamps, entered by pattern. The measures, entered by bell. The payments, entered by kind: *memory; warmth; luck; years*, each with its quantity, because the Court audits everything, even salvation.

And then the anchor's line, four inches down a page I had no business reading, in the hand of a clerk dead a generation, waiting where it had been waiting for forty years for somebody to come and be destroyed by it. I read it four times. I will copy it here once, entire:

Anchor: the form asks one (1) life, settled — an anchor wants a life that is finished paying; an unsettled life will not hold the bottom of a seam. Operator tenders none such. Accepted in lieu, per the old exchange, eight (8) lives unsettled, drawn from a bound familiar, at the operator's declaration, viz.: "He offers. Write down that he offers." Rate confirmed: eight unfinished, for one finished. Docket left open as to the balance.

Eight.

My legs stopped agreeing with me and I sat down on the stone with my second death still cold in me and read it again, and the fourth time slowly, for the arithmetic, because arithmetic is what I do instead of feeling things on schedule.

The arithmetic holds. An anchor wants a life with nothing left to spend and she had none to tender; her own was half gone already and holding a city up by the shoulders. So the old exchange was struck. Eight unfinished for one finished, out of the only account standing at the water's edge that held them: a small grey creature that stood to her the way a familiar stands, while it was spent, and did not run.

I was not learning who. Who had been at the head of a page in my own ledger for four nights with no line through it. What the shelf gave me was the thing the name had been missing ever since I wrote

it: *why*, in figures.

And under it, the declaration. Not *consented*. Not *was tendered*. *He offers*, twice, because she stopped the working on black water with her needle in her hand and made the clerk write it down a second time. She was making the file say he chose it. She was defending him, on the record, from a court that had not asked her anything.

A hundred years of clerks have read that line since. Not one of them ever asked the familiar.

Docket left open as to the balance. Even the Court thought somebody was still owed.

I did not say his name in that corridor. I could have. The Clerk stood a foot from my shoulder with his lamp and his spectacles and a form for everything, and the Court of the Hollow acts on what is entered: the name would have been a file before I reached the stairs, and the whole thing would have been out of my paws and into the hands of people who are very good at this. I told myself that was the reason. It was one of the reasons.

“What makes a death true?” I asked the Clerk, there in the corridor. “The form says a true death is always seen coming. Seen how?”

“Posted,” said the Clerk. “An appointment is an hour with a name in it. The desk keeps the calendar; the bells keep the desk. A death that arrives at a rung hour, announced, is a death this Court can file as *kept* — and a kept death spends whole.” He looked at the great green shoulder of the thing in the dark. “A death at an hour that is never rung is a walk-in, sir. We have discussed walk-ins.”

“Your stamp,” I said. It had been sitting in me since my first night at that desk, and the vault seemed to be in a giving mood. “It is a paw print.”

“It is.”

“Why?”

He took it out of his coat and turned it over, and I realized that I had never once seen him look at it. “The desk keeps a first witness. Every bench does; ours has simply never got round to replacing hers.” He said *hers* the way he says all his footnotes. “When the desk was new there was a question of law: whether a thing arriving here could be said to have seen its own appointment coming, that being the whole of the test. So testimony was taken from the only creatures on

either side of the city who reliably do. They go and sit somewhere clean, sir, and they wait, and they are almost never wrong about the hour, and they do not argue about it afterwards. The Court took its definition of a kept death from what the witness described, and then took the witness's mark for its seal, as courts will, and has not remarked on the matter since."

"I had assumed it was fondness," I said.

"Certainly not," said the Clerk, and put the stamp back in his coat. "It is precedent."

I looked at the bell a long time. Stair by stair as we climbed, a set of separate facts began to sit together: a seam that wants an anchor; an anchor that wants a finished life, tendered at a kept hour; an hour that has not been keepable for a hundred years; and a bell with the whole of that hour banked in its bronze.

"The docket remains unresolved," said the Clerk, and dusted nothing off the grille's brass. "The Court does not forgive collateral, and the city has never once petitioned for redemption. It would take—" and he permitted himself the thing that in the Clerk stands where other men keep smiling, a small dry ceremonial pause, "—a paperwork error. There is always a paperwork error. Locating it, however, is a profession."

He looked at me. I looked at the bell.

The stairs up are longer than the fall down. They always are. I climbed them that night with the case entire on my back: three suspects still pinned to the board, a fourth in the log, and at home on the mantel, in a closed book, a name at the head of a clean page with no line through it. A mender who comes at the neap and re-ties a dead witch's cat between audits. The missing, the wax, the roosts, all draining down one slope toward a patient hope under black glass.

The Mere is fed on the missing and the quiet, and it is winning, softly, one unpicked seam at a time. Against a thing like that, claws are a rumor. *Paperwork* is an appointment. I had learned that in the spring off a defective hinge in a lease, and filed it where I file weapons; this was the night I took it down off the shelf.

Tansy was asleep on the hearthrug when I came in, in the exact center of it, compassed by one chewed bootlace; she had waited up, the room said, and lost.

Under the door, in Brindle's counting-hand, was the answer to a

question I had paid her to put about: where the senior grey passed his Mereside nights. *Nowhere that paper reaches.* I could read that correctly now: at the empty rails, in the one place no ledger prices, keeping a vigil nobody commissioned. The Exchange cannot book grief. I filed the confirmation under his testimony and let the old tom keep his roof.

I stood a while at the board on the chimney breast, and then I took a pin, and under the whole assembly of the case, the stub, the counterfoil, the shroud-thread, the grey wool running toward Gravamen, I pinned the one new exhibit I had carried up the long stairs, a sentence, mine:

The city is owed an hour, and I know where it is banked.

And beside it I pinned the fish-market tide-table, because a plan with no date on it is a wish.

The anchor is the one part of a seam that can be touched at all, undone or made good, taken or defended, and hers lies out past the last stone, under water that never ebbs. Except at the neap. At the neap the flats go bare from the sea-wall to the deep pool, and anything small and dry-footed can walk out and put its hands on the bottom of the world. That is why the mender comes at the neap. That is why forty years of stolen half-seconds were all taken at the neap and never once in the weeks between.

The tables are posted a season ahead. I had read the next figure off Pell's shutter at dawn before I ever went down the sea-stair, and I sat up on the mantel among the exhibits and did the sum again, wanting a different answer, in the manner of every debtor who has ever added a column twice.

Fourteen nights.

Fourteen nights of flood tide, and then the flats would lie bare again, and the hand that had lifted one of my hems whole off a midwife's door would have its window at the anchor. Lady's Day fell inside the fourteen, with five nights still to run past it: her estate weighed in one room, and then the water. Everything left in this file was done inside that number.

Then that is where we are going, and there are fourteen nights to get there.

Part III

The Ninth Bell

Chapter 10

The Slow Clock and the Escrow Key

The Horological Society's master clock runs four minutes slow. The Horologists know why. They are not fixing it.

Nobody sent for me. Too much of this case had arrived under my door, and the season had taught me to distrust arrivals. This one I dug.

The four minutes had been in the file since Gravamen: Sootbeard's log had the tower's slowness dated and growing, and the Gentleman's hall clock ticked the same four minutes behind the world, and a district that sets every watch in it by one instrument does not notice the instrument lying.

And a cat who intended to spring a bell from an evidence vault by paperwork needed schooling in exactly one art: how time is owed, held, and moved on paper. So I went up the tower in the dead watch, to catch the difference being made.

I caught it. Three Horologists at the crown-wheel in the smallest hour, shaving the night: four minutes here, a matter of seconds there, skimmed off the district's clocks, gathered, wound onto a mainspring of appalling beauty.

They froze around their work when I came out of the wheel-train's shadow, three guildsmen caught at a theft they had committed on their own guild's honour, and the oldest of them looked at me a long, ticking time, and then said, to his brothers: "It is the party of the irregular filings. Bar the door. Either he ruins us, or he was sent."

I was not sent. But I stayed, and I sat where they could all see my claws stay folded, and I heard them.

The Society's tower is one instrument: a building whose bones tick like a chest full of hearts. Its master clock governs the district: every counting-house regulator, every undertaker's hall clock, every watchman's turnip sets itself by the tower. Eleven years, and not one clock in the district to argue with.

For their founder.

He is dying: the old master who built the tower's heart, dying for years now with the stubbornness of his own escapements. And the Society holds a contract, his first commission, signed by the city in an age when the city still signed such things. One sunrise, owed to him, dated *on completion of the great work*.

The great work was completed forty years ago. His hands set the crown-wheel the same season my witch walked out onto the black glass. The sunrise was never paid, the paper slept, and he will not survive to spring.

You cannot bring a sunrise forward. You can, if you are a guild of desperate clockmakers, assemble one out of hoarded minutes: eleven years of skimmed time spent all at once, one impossible golden hour over Hollowmere, out of schedule, with the old man's chair carried up to the tower gallery to meet it.

Hoarding time is Toll evasion, and the Court's auditors had noticed eleven years of the district's minutes failing to reconcile, and were en route.

What the Society thought it needed was a miracle. What it had, I told them, was a *paperwork error*. The right kind. They were not thieves hiding a hoard. They were creditors holding a receipt, and the whole difference between the two is whether the taking-back is done in a cellar or in the open, declared, itemized, before witnesses, with the balance struck.

They stared at me. And Tansy, who had sat through the whole council on the table's edge washing her ears with unbearable magisterial calm, looked up from a paw and said it back to the room better than I had said it to them:

"So you weren't stealing time. The city owed you a sunrise, and you have the receipt."

Three master Horologists looked at a kitten the way men look

at a text. I never stated the law half so well at any point in the proceedings, and I did not try again; when the case found its way to the auditors, that is the sentence I built the filing around. I am told I had begun, at some point in the council, to pace the table the way *she* used to pace a hem.

The auditors arrived at dawn: two of them, grey-gloved, correct, with dockets already opened. The Society, coached to the syllable, did not hide the mainspring. They *declared* it. The sunrise contract went onto the bench beside eleven years of skimming-ledgers, with a petition to discharge the city's oldest unpaid debt of light by public performance, all parties witnessing, the Court to meter the spend.

I watched two auditors of the Hollow Court confront a filing that was irregular, enormous and *correct*, and I watched them fall in love. They stayed three days. They found against the Society on two counts of procedure and waived both fees in consideration of *exceptional bookkeeping*.

They also, from the first evening, without being asked once, told me about the seam.

I had not applied. I had not paid a fee or filled in a line. A cat twice through the desk and presently a docketed party has a file, and they had read mine on the barge down. So at dusk, each dusk, one of them would find me on whatever ledge I was working from and give me the day's metering in the flat kindness of their trade, the same voice they use for weather and for verdicts: *the seam at the Mereside anchor, metered at dusk. Holding*.

Ten nights of the fourteen still to run. I thanked them each time, formally, and did not once tell them what I had written in my own ledger about the hand that comes at the neap.

And on the fourth evening, the Horologists spent the hoard.

The city has a golden hour now, in its memory, that appears in no almanac. It came on like a tide of honey: every clock in Gravamen stopping together, politely, as if for a funeral — and then the light. Sunset ran backward. The undertakers came out onto their steps. The fog itself went up the terraces amber, and every sunbeam in the district — I felt them, all at once, the whole map of warm rectangles that a cat carries of any city — *ignited*, an hour of them, in the middle of the evening, for nothing. Word had gone around the night-side in the mysterious total way it goes: rooflines and

window-ledges filled with cats sitting up and down Gravamen like gargoyles' apprentices; Sootbeard on his corner three districts away reported afterward, formally, one (1) unscheduled sunrise, *received*. Merrow's lamplighters stood their ladders and let the lamps sleep through it. The old master sat his chair on the tower gallery with his guild around him and the Court's two auditors standing witness at the parapet, gloves folded, metering the golden air with instruments of brass and, I will testify, not looking at the instruments overmuch.

He died eleven days later, out of schedule and in no one's debt, and the Court processed him, I have this from the Clerk, on a docket marked *paid in full, with sunrise*, and no one below the city found anything irregular in it at all.

The golden hour goes in this file for three reasons. Because the precedent is now law: *the Court will honor a debt of light against a debt of time, and will help compute it*. Because the auditors, who became first colleagues and then something like friends, taught me over three days how collateral dockets are structured and *mis-structured*.

And because in the middle of the golden hour I looked away from the light, the only creature on that roofline looking away, and I watched the Mere.

The black glass did not take the gold. The whole city ambered, and the lake lay in the middle of it like a hole cut in the page — and around its rim, in the amber fog, shapes stood at intervals, unhurried, dry, *watching the light spend*, and I understood that we had just shown the patient thing under the water exactly how much this city still had left in its accounts worth taking.

An hour bought and spent for love, over a city, in the open. And sunk in the vaults below, behind a grille on grey ribbon: a hundred *years* of hours, banked in bronze.

A creditor had stood at the rim and watched a debtor spend in the open. I made a note of what it had been shown, and went down off the roofline before the light did.

* * *

The Locksmiths' Fellowship holds secrets in escrow, and Box 9-Crown was due to open that midnight.

The day-side thinks a locksmith sells locks. The Fellowship's true stock is *kept* secrets: locked boxes deposited with conditions, held in a hall with the best iron in the city and a charter older than the iron. And the charter's terrible clause is this: a box whose condition has come due, and whose named claimant does not appear, is *unclaimed*, and an unclaimed secret is read aloud. On the steps. At midnight. In full.

The Fellowship does not peek, does not edit, does not mercy. Depositors trust the Locksmiths because they have stood at the foot of those steps, at some midnight of their lives, and heard somebody else's business read out.

Box 9-Crown was deposited forty years ago. Condition: *the death of the depositor, plus one season*. The depositor: E. Vane, of Thimblefield.

The season had turned that week.

I learned of it from the Fellowship's crier posting the midnight docket at dusk. By full dark the steps of the Locksmiths' hall held the strangest congregation of my season.

Half the night-side wanted that box read: the Circuit's younger seats, hungry for anything of hers; Mistress Shear, near the front, wearing her correctness like frost; every broker of rumor in three districts; and, fog-smelling, gloved, at the edge of the lamplight, the Quiet Gentleman, attending in person, which the oldest heads on the steps said had not happened at a reading in living memory.

The other half wanted it burned: Cardew, planted on the top step with her stick like a boundary-stone, on the simple grounds that whatever a dead witch locked away for forty years was locked away from *somebody*, and the somebody was likelier than not standing in this crowd. And at the rim of it all, out where the lamplight failed, the fog off the canals stood in its shapes and did not disperse, and I marked their spacing, and their patience, and counted the Mere among the interested parties.

Nine-Crown. She numbered it in the year of the seam, and she numbered it *nine*.

The Fellowship's law allows one interruption of a reading, and one only: a claimant. The box named its claimant in the deposit-deed, per the crier's docket, as *my heir, in law*, not by name, in the standard form. And Elspeth Vane died, the whole city knew, without kin,

without apprentice, intestate as weather. There was no heir in law. There was going to be a reading.

There was a cat on the steps.

I went up them at a quarter to midnight, past Shear's frost and Cardew's stick, and I sat down on the reading-stone itself in front of the Keeper of the Fellowship, a vast, slow, iron-colored woman with the manner of a door, and before the assembled night-side of Hollowmere I made my claim: heir in law to Elspeth Vane, of Needle Lane, called the Needle; her familiar of fifteen years; bearer of her unfinished magic, her collar, and her strand; mender of her wards; sewer of her shroud-seam, witnessed by the tide and Mother Cardew; presently investigating her murder.

The steps went up like the roosts in the seed audit. The Keeper looked down at me for a long iron moment. Then she pronounced what I had gambled the whole night on: that the claim was a real question, fit for a real court; that no reading may proceed while a real question stands; and that the Fellowship, whose charter predates the city's courts and defers to exactly one older jurisdiction, would refer the question of whether a cat can inherit to the only bench with standing over the estates of the dead.

The Hollow Court. A hearing. The box stayed — sealed, guarded, condition suspended — pending the ruling.

Two things happened in the crowd in the moment the gavel-word came down, and I was watching for both. Mistress Shear closed her eyes: relief or fury, I could not read which, and the not-reading kept her pinned to my board another fortnight.

And the Quiet Gentleman raised one gloved hand, at the edge of the lamplight, in the gesture of a man acknowledging a well-played trick at cards, then wrote something in a small book, and the writing of it reached me later that night, folded, fog-smelling, under my own door, in the only correspondence he has ever sent me. It said:

You have discovered the trade's one secret: possession is nothing; standing is everything. The hearing will be worth attending. I hold paper on several of the parties. — G.

And below that, in a hand suddenly smaller, as close to human as I ever saw him come:

She deposited it the week after the water. I brokered the box-fee. She paid it in tears — one vial, escrow-grade. I have never sold it.

Some accounts one keeps.

* * *

Home, late, the fog walking me the last three streets like a bailiff. And on the sill of her window, waiting for me, a vole.

Fresh. Whole. Laid straight along the sill-stone, not dropped, *placed*, wedged at the corner where the shutter meets the frame, exactly the way I had wedged the herring for the blind postmaster of the roosts. The kill was clean, and old-fashioned, and close work. Some senior professional of the night-side, then, keeping accounts of his own.

I ate it on the sill in the fog, and I read it the plain way, the warm way: the city had begun, in its unbudgeted fashion, to keep its cat. Brindle carries my credit; Merrow chalks my mark; Sootbeard logs my crossings; and now somebody, wanting no receipt, had sent supper. I did not ask whose hand. Of all the exhibits in this file, it is the one I was glad to leave unattributed.

Tansy asleep in the exact center of the hearthrug; the board over the mantel crowded now, threads crossing threads, the whole city pinned and strung. And I sat up on the mantel among my exhibits and put the chapter in order, as she taught me, before sleep.

The Court will honor strange debts, strangely computed, if the paper is true: *proved, in gold, over Gravamen*.

The Court now owes me a hearing on the one question whose answer unlocks everything at once: the box and its forty-year secret; the estate; the standing to petition, as her heir, against dockets a stranger cannot touch. A bell's docket, say.

And in a vault under the city, behind grey ribbon: her confession. I was as sure of it as I have been sure of anything since the kettle. Her own account of the water, the working, and the eight the vault docket counted out in a clerk's hand. Deposited the week after the seam, sealed against the day of her death plus one season, addressed to an heir she would not name and kept count toward for forty years.

She knew the bill would come due. She banked the truth against it, and paid the fee in tears, and spent the rest of her life assembling, stray by stray, nine attempts, one signature, somebody to read it.

Nine is the number I owe. I know where I first heard that sentence: the chart-table, the lamplight, her voice above the needle, amused, *that winter I tried eight strays*, and me small and certain in the middle of her half-sewn work. That night, before sleep, I reached for the Day itself, the way I had reached for it all season, to sit in the warm of it a minute, under the lamp, beside the voice.

It is not there. The Toll took it at the flats, and I had felt it go, and that night on the mantel I finally went to look at what the going means. It means the fact is still mine: eight strays, nine owed; her voice said so; my own file says so. And the room the fact was kept in is gone. No lamp. No table. No voice over the needle. My own handwriting, telling me there was a voice.

I sat with the difference a long time, with the whole case strung and pinned within reach and the one place I wanted to go in it nowhere at all.

The case was all still there. The warm was not.

The hearing was set for Lady's Day. Of course it was: the Circuit's inquiry was already docketed there, and courts consolidate. And Lady's Day, the almanac noted, fell that year at the dark of the moon.

Chapter 11

The Testimony and the Last Parcel

The night-post of Hollowmere delivered that week, thirty years late, and did not consider itself late.

The postman came up Needle Lane at the hour between the last lamp and the first gull, in a coat of a cut not seen since before the bell was pawned, with a parcel lashed in oiled string and a manner that suggested the intervening thirty years were a rumor he had declined to countersign. The parcel was addressed to *Elspeth Vane, Needle Lane, Thimblefield* — in her own hand. Mailed by her, thirty years ago, to her future self. Postage due.

He would not leave it. He would not discuss it. He required, he said, consulting a delivery-book, *a signature* — the addressee's, or, the addressee being deceased (he pronounced it like a foreign currency), that of her successor in law. And there being, at the present hour, no adjudicated successor in law, he would return, *at the same hour, following the determination of the question*, and he walked back down the lane into the fog with the parcel under his arm and thirty more years of patience visibly available to him.

So now two locked things in this city were waiting on one question, and the question had its date. Lady's Day, at the dark of the moon: the day this city makes its undecided things decide. I spent the intervening nights doing what any respectable litigant does, which is assembling witnesses and being unable to sleep.

* * *

The Hollow Court does not, as a rule, sit on the affairs of the living. The question of whether a cat can inherit turned out to be, on the Clerk's own reading of his own charter, neither an affair of the living nor of the dead, but of an *estate*. Estates are the Court's native soil. So the corridor of shelves grew a courtroom the way the desk had grown a cat-sized chair: quietly, overnight, without anyone admitting to the carpentry.

I will give the hearing as the file requires: parties, testimony, exhibits, ruling. I was not calm.

In the matter of the estate of E. Vane (intestate): on the question of succession.

The Clerk presided. There is, it emerges, a higher bench below him, which owes him four centuries of deferred leave and defers to him in all matters he cares to keep. He had cared to keep this one. His enthusiasm was total and totally suppressed, expressed exclusively through the turning-up of the lamp and the presence, on the bench, of *two* inkwells.

For the claim: myself. Heir-presumptive; cat.

Against: the Circuit's advocate, a dry young seat from Gravamen with a conscience visibly too good for her brief, instructed to secure the estate's workings "for the public safety." And, joined to her side by motion, with her own advocate and her frost worn like court dress: Mistress Shear, rival claimant, petitioning that the estate's technical effects pass to "the qualified," meaning her.

The Gentleman attended. He sat at the back with the fog folded around his ankles and held, I do not doubt, paper on every party present, including the bench, excluding me. The Court of Whiskers filed an amicus brief. It was a dead moth of unusual quality, presented by a deputation of three seniors, and the Clerk entered it into evidence without a flicker, as *amicus curiae*, *one (1), lepidopteral*, and I watched the Circuit's advocate decide not to object and grow, in my estimation, considerably.

The public gallery was open, and one man in it had bought his seat with a season of fright. Mr. Wick came in late, alone, without the grey-gloved men, and sat at the end of a bench with his hat in his hands and stayed to the finding. He had chosen the date himself

in the spring and loaded it under my witch's door like a trap, and it sprang that morning exactly as he had built it to: in a court he did not know existed, over an estate he had never wanted, in favour of the one claimant he had spent good money to have removed from the lane. It left him nothing to do with his hat. He did not speak once. He left before the stamp came down, and the Court, which files everything, filed his attendance and let him go.

The testimony for my claim, in the order it was given:

Mother Cardew, on the shroud-seam: that at the tide-turn, before the assembled guilds, the deceased's own burial stitch was completed *in the deceased's own hand* by the claimant; that what closed that shroud was not an imitation of Elspeth Vane's hand but its *continuation*; and that she had tied her own debt into the claimant's thread on the quay, in public, "because one does not tie debts into property. One ties them into *persons*."

And then Mother Cardew did a thing that was not in her brief. The Circuit's advocate half rose, thought better of it, and let an old woman finish.

She had brought two files with her under the shawl. Old ones, the paper gone the colour of weak tea. She laid them on the exhibit-cloth and put one hand flat on each, and gave the bench their names.

"Adela Marchmain, of the Tatterstage. Stitcher. Kept her seam under the greasepaint nineteen years. Found in her dressing room, the fourth of Hollowmas, forty years ago."

"Nan Sarn, of Hemlock Row. Sailmaker and stitcher. Widow. Found in her own kitchen three springs after, and her terrier sat two winters on that step, and the Row fed it there because it would not come in and nobody had the heart to make it."

"I signed both closings," she said. "I was twenty-two. A senior told me the finding was fatigue, and I wrote fatigue, because I had not yet learned that a senior can be tired too. There were four hands in this city that could hold a seam. Inside three years there were two. Nobody asked why — not the Circuit, not the guilds, not the Court, and myself first and worst of all." She squared the files. "I do not ask the bench to reopen them today. That is Circuit business and I will do it myself. I ask the bench to record that they are not shut."

The Clerk recorded it. He wrote it out longhand, slowly, in the second inkwell, which is the nearest that desk comes to ceremony.

Marrow, with the shift-book under her arm, on the hall's ward: mended by the claimant, unasked, in front of the guild; holding to this night. She chalked the hall's tally-mark on the Court's own floor, and the Clerk had the mark entered into evidence where it lay, which means the Hollow Court now bears, somewhere in its corridor, one stroke of a lamplighter's chalk that may not lawfully be washed.

Brindle, on trade: that the Exchange had dealt with the claimant across a season as a principal, not as a curiosity; that he pays, collects, redeems, and holds credit; and that "the Exchange has fenced for four hundred years, m'lud, and we have never once extended an account to *property*."

And then one item nobody had asked her for, given at the end of her evidence with her chin up.

"There is a thing I owe the claimant and I will put it in your record, m'lud. On a wet night in the spring he showed me a seal off a cart-slot in Needle Lane. I looked at it half a second longer than I looked at anything else that night, and he saw me do it, and he was too new to know what he had seen. It was favour-paper. The Gentleman's house makes it and nobody else can. I knew it at a glance and I said nothing, because the Exchange does not price that stock aloud — not for a client, not for a friend, not for a wet cat I had taken a liking to. That is the rule and I kept it and I would keep it again." She looked at the ceiling of the corridor, briefly, in the manner of a woman conducting a private negotiation. "It cost him the whole summer. Put that in as well."

And then the Circuit's advocate, doing her instructed duty, called her joined party to establish the counter-claim, *the qualified hand*, and Mistress Shear took the stand, and the hearing became, for one hour, the other thing. The thing I had been building toward since a draped chair in the Circuit's long room.

Because I had standing to cross-examine. And I had spent three days with two auditors learning what a docket can be made to ask.

I did not ask her about the murder. Ask a frightened witch about a murder and you get a wall; her advocate was primed for the wall; the wall was rehearsed. I asked her instead, mildly, from the claimant's little table, about *qualification*. She had petitioned on the strength of her hand. Very well: here, entered as exhibit, was a hand's length of warding in the Vane stitch, mirror-handed: the sample, her sample,

surrendered under subpoena from the locked box in her workroom, the box she swore was never unlocked. Would the qualified candidate, before the bench, demonstrate the stitch she proposed to inherit?

She looked at the sample a long moment. Frost, at close range, is thinner than it looks from the gallery.

She tried. I will give her that much forever: she took the needle, before the Hollow Court and the Circuit's advocate and three senior cats and the fog-ankled Gentleman, and she tried the stitch, and her good journeyman hands produced good journeyman work, forward-handed, correct, and *nothing like it* — and she knew it before the thread was drawn, and something in her that ambition had been holding upright for twenty years sat down at last, in front of everyone.

She did not speak. That is the whole of it, and it was the loudest thing said at the hearing. She looked at the drawn thread a long moment, and laid the needle down square on the exhibit-cloth, the way you lay down something you have decided not to carry any further, and went back to her place and sat, upright, correct, hands folded — and when the bench asked whether the petitioner wished to address her demonstration, her advocate rose, looked once at her face, and withdrew the claim entire. She looked at me then, the only time she ever did. There was nothing in the look I could file. There did not need to be. The Court, which knows testimony when it hears it, let the silence stand unabridged.

The Clerk waited a decent interval, then took up the exhibit-sample himself, ran it through his fingers the way he runs thread, and put on the record, drily, the finding that mattered to my other case, the one no bench had convened:

"The Court notes for its own files that the work in this exhibit is of a craft this bench has encountered *elsewhere*, in matters irregular; that the documents before this bench date her acquisition of it to a period well within her adult practice; and that the craft itself, on the evidence of this Court's oldest colleagues—" a granite salute from the gallery; Sootbeard had insisted on attending; the floor had been reinforced by order, "—has been in continuous exercise in this city for not less than forty years. The witness would have been an apprentice of nine at its first attestation. The bench observes, for whatever bench may someday need the observation, that *she did not make this*. She merely wanted it. Wanting is not yet a filing category."

Cleared, in open court, on the record, by the same arithmetic that convicted her of the wanting.

I had not needed it. I had stopped having suspects at the neap; the board over the mantel had been down to one name for a fortnight. What I did not have, from the parlor to that morning, was a single sheet of paper a court could hold. I had my own paws and a dead woman's handwriting and a certainty I could not put in an envelope. Shear's clearing was worth something all the same: a case with a hole in it is a case somebody else can fill, and the bench had just filled that one on its own initiative and for free.

Which left the one place in Hollowmere where proof of my sort exists on paper. He was at the back. I had spent a season being handed things by this city: tips, summonses, folders left open at the angle of expectation. I was done being a recipient. So I asked. Formally, from the claimant's table, as residuary legatee of the estate whose technique had been hawked through the quiet channels: *the claimant moves that the house of G— produce its paper on the circular styled "the Needle's hand, demonstrated and taught."*

The corridor went very quiet. You do not subpoena the Quiet Gentleman; there is no bailiff in any world for it; the motion was a door held open, no more. He rose, and considered the door, and named the toll of walking through it, in the voice a signature makes: "The house's stock is sold, not seized, little rival. The price is one knot. Of my choosing. At a time of my choosing."

An unspecified debt to a being whose whole nature is collection: the exact paper the old ones on the ropewalk had warned me never to touch. I looked once at the gallery rail, where three seniors sat very still, watching their own law about to be spent; and I thought of Tansy's purr, and of what proof is worth on a board with one name left on it; and I paid. "Done," I said, on the record, and the Clerk entered the knot into the minutes with a face that declined to have an opinion, and somewhere in the fog at the Gentleman's ankles a page turned.

He produced three things, and I will give them one at a time.

The first was the brokerage-trail of the circular, entire: the fog-paper, the knot-signed commission, the account settled in wound grey thread. Every document establishing that the hand behind it was a client the house itself had never seen. The house does not

spend lives; the house *banks* them; it had been settled with in the one coin it does not deal in, by a client who had nothing else and would not come to the counter.

I knew whose hand it was before the first sheet was flat on the table. The sheets were for the thing I had gone a whole season without: a fact about him that existed outside my own head, in ink, in another party's keeping, dated, filed, and produceable. He had known from the first fog-smelling card on an empty shelf that I would need to prove it rather than believe it, and he had waited for the market where that proof would fetch its best price. He got his price. I have never once thought it was too high.

The second was smaller, and it closed a question this file had carried since the wet spring night Brindle sold me a docket-scrap: a carrier's counterfoil. One cart, Needle Lane to the Wickhouse, the cargo entered in a clerk's indifferent hand as *street-thread, harvested, spooled*. The lane's own stitching, the cut tethers of every window and door on her street, riding heavy toward the water, and coming home light.

And the third was not paper. It was one sentence of testimony, given standing, unsworn, because his word is the only oath he recognizes: "The house walks behind its blind commissions. Blind for the client is not blind for the house." The gentleman the Grey Boss could never book, going nowhere in particular the whole way down the lane on the murder night, had been the house itself, attending its paper. He had walked at strolling pace behind the cart that carried her cut wards, and had asked, of course, nothing.

Through the whole of it the deputation kept the gallery rail, the senior grey at its head, struck from my board a month since by the testimony of his own worn paws. When the third exhibit fell he looked down at me with the grave courtesy of the wrongly hunted, and I bore the look.

And then there was one thing more before the ruling, and it took the floor out from under me.

The Clerk squared his papers to close, and did not close them. He asked it in the voice reserved for the parts of a form that have never once mattered in four hundred years.

"A matter of form. The claim rests on the bond of a familiar. The Court must satisfy itself as to the class." He dipped his pen. "Does

any other familiar of the decedent survive?"

I was an officer of the estate. I had spent a season standing on that duty, and an hour of that morning telling this bench what a duty is, and there was no version of the question I could have answered with a silence.

"One," I said.

Nothing in the corridor of shelves moved. Nobody in that room but me knew what was about to go on the record, and I knew it entire: I was going to give the Hollow Court the name of the only creature in Hollowmere who had ever pulled me out of the way of anything.

"Name?"

"Bodkin. Grey tom, one eye, half an ear. He was hers before me. He is living."

I did not accuse him. I gave the Court a name, a description and a fact, and I did not give it a charge, and the distance between those two things is a distinction only a coward needs measured. He was owed. That was true, and I said it. He had killed her. That was true, and I did not. Telling the truth and betraying my teacher turned out to be one act, performed once, in open court, at a little table, by a cat under a duty he had spent the whole season insisting on. I have not found the ledger that squares it. I do not expect to.

The Clerk wrote the name down. And then — I watched it happen from four feet away — he stopped writing, and looked at what he had written, and did not look up.

He had run four neap mends through his fingers and put a description of that hand in his own record, and gone on describing it all season without a name to hang it on. He had one now. He had a bench, and a charter, and a Court that has never in four centuries failed to follow a thread it was handed. He was two strokes of a pen from a finding that would have taken this case out of my paws and put it where cases belong.

He put the pen down in the tray.

"The bond is not pleaded," he said, to the room, in the flattest voice he owns. "No party has presented it. This Court cannot go where it has not been taken, and an unrepresented claim sleeps." He looked at me then, once, over the two inkwells. "The claimant will understand that a sleeping claim is not a dead one."

“The claimant understands.”

“Yes,” said the Clerk, and turned his page. “I rather thought the claimant might.”

And then the ruling. The Clerk read it himself, from a page he had written out fair twice:

In the matter of the estate of E. Vane: it is the finding of this Court that a familiar in surviving receipt of his witch's unfinished working is not the estate's property but its residuary legatee; that the bond of a familiar, being a thread tied by the decedent herself and severed by no instrument this Court recognizes, constitutes designation in her own hand; and that the claimant — Ashcat, of Needle Lane, called the Needle's heir — is so adjudged, with all rights, workings, debts, and standings of the estate, to hold and to answer for. The Court further notes that it has now, at last, filed something under 'nine' without irregularity, and found the experience restful. Next matter.

The stamp came down. Paw print. Nobody remarked on it. The gallery rail purred: three seniors, formally, in unison. And Mother Cardew looked at the ceiling of the corridor of shelves and said, to a woman forty years and one season dead, “There. *Now* scold me,” and had to sit down.

* * *

Box 9-Crown was opened to me that same night, in the Fellowship's iron reading-room, alone, as the deed provided: *my heir, in law, and none other present.*

I meant, for a long time, not to transcribe her confession. But I am her executor, and an executor's duty is to the estate's debts, and the largest debt this estate owes is the truth of what it did. A truth kept in an iron box under a city has already been kept that way for forty years, and look what the keeping bought. So the reader will have her, in her own hand, at its youngest and worst, blotted, she who never blotted, as much of her as the case is owed. The rest stays between us, and there is a rest, and you may not have it.

Set down the week after the water, by E. Vane, stitcher, against herself, while the hand still shakes. When the

shaking stops I will begin to forgive myself. This paper is to prevent that.

The form asked one finished life for the anchor. It is the old rule and it is a fair one: an anchor wants a life that is finished paying, and none such stood on the water. Mine is mortgaged to the seam while I live. There was no other needle. The city was one tide from the bill it has owed since the first quay went in, and I stood on the black glass with the form asking, and nothing to tender.

He heard the form ask. He had been at my skirts nine years, where he was always. He said: take mine. I said the form does not take what is nine-tenths a future. He said — and he said it to the clerk of the working, not to me, so that it would stand in the record where I could not unsay it: “He offers. Write down that he offers.”

Eight, at the old exchange. Eight, one at a time, down my own needle, and he stood to me while I drew them, the way he stood to me at every hem and blessing of nine years, and he did not once cry out, and the wet on that water was on my face and none of it on his. When it was done he had one left. He looked at me a while. I have set down everything else plainly and I will set this down plainly too: there was no anger in the look, and I have wished every night since that there had been. Then he walked into the fog on the one life I left him, and I did not follow. Write why. Because what I owed could not be paid by finding him, and what he needed could not be survived by me.

I cannot give them back. Thread that has become stitch is not thread any more; it will not wind; it is load now, and it holds the bottom of a lake. And I cannot wind him new ones. Winding wants an unspent spool, and his is stitch to the heart.

So I will make nine new ones, and give those. Not to him. He would not take them from this hand, and he would be right. To the kind: one life over par, paid forward, stray by stray, until the count is nine. It will not settle the

account. Nothing settles the account. It will keep the hand that owes it honest, which is all a ledger has ever been for.

There was one thing more in the box, flat under the confession at the iron bottom: a receipt, forty years old, for one (1) candle, beeswax, escrow-grade, sold out of the Gentleman's house the week after the water. She would not have the rich man's smell in her house; I built the first chapter of this file on that. But the same week she banked her confession she bought one fine candle, and kept it forty years — held, like everything else in that box, against the settlement she never stopped expecting to make. The good light you keep against a guest you owe.

Fifteen years of evenings with her needle in my shadow while I slept on her work and took it for petting. The heir reports that he is not her cat so much as her *restitution*.

And the confession's last line, which is the only will she ever left:

If he comes to collect — and he is owed; whatever he has become, write it at the head of every page, HE IS OWED — then let my heir pay what I could not. I do not know if that is mercy or justice. Whichever is dearer. She always knew the difference, and I never did.

She wrote *she*. Forty years before me. I have decided, executor's discretion, that she was allowed to hope her ninth would be a she, and that I am allowed to have read it anyway.

* * *

I walked home from the iron room over the roofs, the long way.

She spent him. Eight lives, at her own needle, out of a creature who stood to her while it was done, stood the way I have stood to her over lesser work a thousand evenings, certain past thought that the needle would never turn. Then she came off the water alone, and let him walk into the fog with the one life she had left him, and did not follow. Forty years she wrote *he is owed* at the head of every page. Writing a debt at the head of every page is not paying it.

And my whole life was lived inside her amends. The fire, the window, the kettle at dusk: fifteen years on the warm side of an

account, while the creature the account was owed to sat out on the sea-wall and watched the lamp burn. She knew he was there. Knowing was her trade. She put the kettle on anyway, every evening, and never once told me what I was standing in.

State her account, then, since stating accounts is the trade she left me, and I have stated one for every other name in this file. Elspeth Vane, called the Needle: guilty of accepting eight lives that were offered but were not hers to accept; guilty of entering the offer in the record so that neither of them could take it back; guilty of forty years of writing *he is owed* at the head of pages instead of standing on a sea-wall saying it to the creature it was owed to; guilty of building her restitution out of strays and warmth and kettles and never once out of the one thing the account named, which was herself, at his side, with the truth.

She needed to be forgiven without having to ask. He needed to be asked.

And against all of it: one city, standing; forty years of a held seam; every coat on this quay that still has someone in it. I state it flat, the way I stated Wick's, because she taught me that a reading done in anger is done twice. The file keeps what she did. Both columns.

I came down to Needle Lane and could not go in. I sat on the step of a dead woman's house until the fog came up, and then I was at the doorpost with my claws, and it was not sharpening.

In the chest-ledger, that night, I wrote nothing. I tried. I could not put her name at the head of a page, because under her name the next line was waiting, and I could not write them together — the woman at the window and the woman on the water. The small honest hand does not have a sentence that holds both. The page is blank. It is still blank.

The kettle sat cold on its stone inside, and nobody was expecting me anywhere, and that night, for the first time since the parlor, I was glad of it.

* * *

The postman returned at the hour between the last lamp and the first gull, consulted his book, accepted my signature: a paw print,

pressed beside her name. The Court had certified the mark that afternoon, on its own motion, in the second inkwell. He collected thirty years' postage due, which Brindle advanced against the estate, and left me the parcel.

Inside: a spool of ordinary thread.

Her first. I knew it before the wrapping was off. The case knew it; Box 9-Crown was 9; the parcel was mailed thirty years back but the spool was older, forty at least, wound by hands still learning, the way beginners keep their first anything: too carefully. Ordinary grey linen thread, slightly waxed, the kind you hem a curtain with. No working in it at all. That was the point of it, and the point of everything she ever kept.

And beneath the spool, a note, folded small, sealed with a pressed geranium petal gone to brown paper. On the outside, her hand: the late hand now, the hand I knew. So she had opened her own parcel to her future self at some point, and added to it, and sent it on again.

Set the row straight: the spool wound in her first year at the needle, the year of the seam; posted to herself a decade after; opened, added to, resealed, somewhere in the counting years; delivered now.

For after. You will know when after is.

It is a measure of what this season has done to me that I did not open it. The note said *after*, and after had not come. I put it in the deepest pocket, the one over the heart-shadow, and I took up the spool, because the spool's turn *had* come.

A witch's estate comes with her work still in it, and the work has requirements. A dead witch's wards want maintaining. Her heir must stitch, not mend, as I had mended, by imitation and grief, but *stitch*: begin, work, and tie off, on his own hand, from his own spool. And I held one torn thing that was hers and mine and wanted no witness: the pockets of my shadow. Two of them torn. I had felt each one go, at the parlor, at the flats, like a seam in a coat you are wearing when it parts.

So on the night after the hearing I got down onto the workroom floor, which is not the easy thing it used to be, and sat in the moon's full lamp with my shadow thrown clean on her boards and the first spool beside me, and I stitched.

Cardew had offered supervision. I had declined, and she had looked at me the way she looks at weather and gone home. This was

between me and the shadow. I threaded the bone needle the way the shroud had taught me. I found the torn mouth of the first pocket — you can touch your own shadow, if it is moonlight and the shadow has been sewn in before; it takes the pale strength and it feels, I will report exactly once, like touching the underside of your own name — and I began, and my paws, unwatched, unhurried, with no ward to match and no pattern to follow, ran the stitches *mirror-wise*. Right to left. Every stitch. Not error; *grain*. The thread lay down that way like fur lies down, and fought the other way, and I stopped, halfway along the torn pocket, in the cold moonlight, and looked at my own work.

Her stitch. Reversed. Perfect. *Faster than any needle honestly goes* — because a familiar's paws do not learn the stitch from the needle's side. They learn it from the lap. Fifteen years on the near side of the work, watching from in front, every evening, the needle coming *toward* me — of course it is mirrored. It could be nothing else.

Nobody taught Bodkin the stitch.

That had been the last hole in my case and I had carried it a fortnight, since the night I wrote his name in the chest-ledger and did not strike it out. Two hands in this city ran the Vane stitch and there had only ever been one teacher, and Elspeth taught nobody. So I had filed a theft. A watcher at a window over years; a professional's eye; a pattern lifted the way patterns are lifted, by looking.

Sitting on her boards with the needle in my teeth and my own paws going backward without being asked, I understood there had been nothing to steal.

The stitch is not knowledge. It cannot be given, because it is not held anywhere a hand could reach in and take it. It is the shape left in a body by years of lying against somebody else's work. It comes out mirrored because the work came toward you. It comes out that fast because it was never learned at all, only *grown*, an evening at a time, on the warm side of one lamp.

Which meant that before me, in that room, on the near side of that same lamp, something had lain against those same hands long enough to come away carrying this.

I had known his name for a fortnight. I had not known this. He is not a murderer who copied her. He is what I am. The same craft, the same lap, the same parlour, the same evenings, forty years ahead

of me on one road — her first learner, where I am her ninth, and every single thing I can do, I can do because I sat where he sat.

I put the needle down on her boards and stopped, halfway along my own shadow, for a long time, and did not write anything anywhere.

Because a thing follows from it that I would have paid a life not to have worked out. If the stitch is only the shape a life leaves in a body, then he did not become the Unpicked by learning something monstrous. He became it by being exactly what I am, and then being spent, and then being owed for forty years by the one hand that could have said so. There is no craft between us. There is no difference of kind. There is only the account, and which side of it we were standing on the evening it came due.

I am looking at my own elder brother. I am looking, if this file is honest, at a thing I could still turn into.

You fight like a housecat. — I was one. — Were. A paw on my scruff, sure as her hands, hauling me from the watch. *Watch the paws, not the claws:* the lesson you give a young cat you cannot afford to see die, from the one creature in the city who knew precisely what my deaths cost.

And the knots. Nobody fought my fights. The wraiths took me whole and true; the flats drowned me with no hand on the scales; every price I contracted, I paid. The knots were not armor. They were *aftercare*. Four of them, by the Clerk's audit, tied at the neaps, between filings: a mender re-tying the fray my own spending left in my thread, the way you mend a working coat that will not stop being worn. He let me buy every lesson at full price. He could not watch the wear go unmended.

I knew your witch to look at. Everyone did.

And the teaching. All of it. The paws, the reading of a street, the trick of the drainpipe, the hour to move and the hour to be furniture: I had taken every scrap of it for a professional's charity to a stray with promise. It was nothing of the kind. It was an old cat finding, at the wrong end of forty years, another creature shaped by the same fifteen evenings in the same room. He was finishing his own apprentice out of the only stock left in the world that could take the finish.

True. Every word he ever said to me was true. A shape in a parlor doorway wore a room of her threads, and looked down at a small

ruined cat on the threshold, and *decided he was not an interruption*. Decided, with the only tenderness left in it, that whatever else was to be unpicked in that house, the ninth stray would not be.

The name had stood at the head of that page since the neap, under the sentence she ordered written there.

He is owed. — Bodkin.

That night, in the moonlight, with my shadow whole again and her first thread tied off inside it, I added the only line I had left to add. It is not evidence. It goes in the file anyway.

He learned it where I learned it.

Then I finished the pocket. Both pockets. Mirror-handed, in her first thread, to the end of the seam and the tying-off, because the estate passes *to hold and to answer for*, and I was, from that night, entirely certain which of the two I intended to do. My paws ached to the shoulder before I was half done, and I finished anyway. The only other creature who had ever run that stitch was out at the black water's edge, at the anchor of the world's most expensive seam, unpicking.

Chapter 12

The Ninth Bell

The last Remembered Day came to me that same night, unhunted, in her chair.

I had never slept in the chair. The chair was not mine to fill; that was a rule, and I kept it through everything. But I came up from the workroom with my shadow newly whole and a new line written under his name, and the house was doing a thing it had not done since the kettle: it was *waiting*. The chair stood in the moon's lamp with her shape still in the cushions, and I understood that the rule had expired.

I got up into it. I put my chin where her hand used to fall.

And it was morning. *That* morning.

It is only her last ordinary day, kept in the cushions of a chair, and what I had left of her paid it out to me whole, every hour of it, down to the hour it stopped.

Grey early light. The kettle on for her own tea, the first kettle, the innocent one. She moves slowly; I had not seen it in the living days and I saw it now, the whole dream saw it: she is *spent*. Weeks of it. Wards failing all over her district faster than they should: the alarm-threads she keeps on forty years of workings tugging at her one after another, here a hem gone at the fish market, there a binding loose at the tannery, each one an evening's mending, and she does not have many evenings in her.

And she knows. I watched her know. She stands at the workroom wall with her tea going cold, reading her own cut city, and she says, to the wall, in the flat voice she kept for arithmetic that would not

come out otherwise:

“Ward by ward. You are emptying me first, my grey one. That is craftsmanlike.”

She does not weep, and she does not send for the Circuit, and now I know why on both counts: the confession in the iron box. *He is owed*. You do not call the constables on your own creditor. She had spent forty years failing to invent a settlement. She put her books in order.

I watched her do it. It is terrible housekeeping, because none of it is for her. The workroom tidied — for whoever must read the room after. Her second-best thimble set square on the workbox — for the trade it would someday buy.

The red kerchief, washed at the basin, wrung, and folded on the sewing table — not put away; *folded, on the table, where a cat coming over the sill could not miss it*. She had washed it that morning. She folded her collar for me before noon, on the day she died at dusk, because she did not intend to be wearing it when the collecting came, and she did not intend it to go to the tide with her either.

Last of all, the sunbeam. Late morning, the good one, the March-through-October beam that crosses the work-table at eleven, and I am asleep in the middle of her chart-papers in it, because I was; I remember the day now from both sides, hers and mine, and from my side it was nothing, it was any day, it was a nap. From her side: she sets down her pen, and looks at me a long time, doing what I now recognize as the other ledger, the margin one. Then she crosses the room and *picks me up* — lifts me off her work the way you lift someone who might wake, one hand under, one hand over, the single liberty I permitted in this world and permitted to her alone — and she carries me, the whole slow length of the workroom, to the hearthrug, and puts me down in the poorer, warmer light, and stands over me with her emptied hands, and says:

“There. Mind the house, Ash. I am going to see about the lamps.”

That is all. Her hand on the latch, her back to me, the evening coming up the lane to meet her.

But the dream did not end at the door.

She came back from the hall at dusk with the lamps going up behind her, and she did not sit down. She went round the parlor and closed the shutters. Both leaves, and the bar across. Fifteen years I

had come home over that sill and it had never once been shut against an evening; she stood at that window every night of my life.

Then she took the good beeswax candle out of its drawer, bought the week after the water and kept forty years unburned, and stood it unlit where a guest coming in would have it in the eye. Then she filled the kettle and set it on and got down two cups.

She did not want it seen. Nobody on that lane was going to look up, count an hour of candlelight in a dark parlor, and wonder who was sitting in it with her.

Then she sat down in the chair I was sitting in, to wait.

And when I came to that window at the end of it I read the shut leaves the way anybody would have read them. *Out*, I thought. Gone to see about the lamps.

I woke in her chair at the greyest hour with my face wet in the way of cats, which is invisibly.

And I knew that *after* had come.

The note came out of the deepest pocket smelling of geranium and forty years. Her late hand, small, unblotted, entirely herself:

If you are reading this, then you have done everything in the correct order, which means you are mine, which means I am past scolding you and it has all become your business after all. Very well. Three items, and mind the sequence, you know how I am about sequence.

The bell wants ringing. The Court has held the city's hour a hundred years and the Court, of all of them, keeps honest books — make the books say so. Nothing anchors without a measure, and I had the ninth bell the first time. You will need it.

Spend nothing you cannot re-sew. I mean this. Your lives are not a purse, whatever the arrangement downstairs has taught you. They are the only thing I ever made without owing.

And when you meet my first — for you will; sequence, Ash; you were always the ninth of nine — tell him what he is owed. I could not walk into the fog to say it, and I will not say it through you. You have read my books. You know the words.

The kettle is not your fault. Whatever happens, whatever you saw: the kettle is not your fault. I know you took it off the fire. I know it took three tries.

— E.

I sat in her chair while the grey came up the windows, and then I did what she said, in sequence.

Almost. One item came before her sequence, and it was not on any list of hers.

The night after I sewed my own shadow, I hunted him.

I do not mean I investigated. The investigating had been over for a fortnight. I mean that I sat on the mantel at dusk with the whole board strung above me, and the red feeling came up out of the bottom of me, the parlor's red, older than names, and this time I did not spend it on the nearest wall. I sat on it. I groomed, with terrible thoroughness. And then I went out over the roofs of my city to open my teacher's throat, and it took me the whole of the night, because I am fifteen years old and there was not one roof on that route I did not have to sit down and look at before I took it.

He was not hard to find. He has never been hard to find; that was one of the things I had declined to count. He was on the sea-wall, at the stone where he always sat, looking at the water — and he was asleep. Old cat, one eye, half an ear, forty years of weather in the set of his shoulders, asleep at his post above the black glass, with a grief under him older than my whole life. I came down the wall out of the wind, the way he taught me. I stood over him. I was close enough to count the greys of his coat, and the distance was nothing, and the angle was mine, and no power in Hollowmere was going to arrive in time to stop me.

I want it written that it was not mercy that stopped me. Mercy is a settlement, and I had not stated the account yet; mercy was not mine to spend. What stopped me, standing over the sleeping murderer of Elspeth Vane with the red feeling asking one spring of my back legs, was her hand. Not on my scruff — in my head, in the books, in fifteen years of the windowsill voice: *the difference between brave and stupid is four seconds of looking, Ash. The difference between justice and spite is the same four seconds.*

I looked. Four seconds. Longer. And what I saw was an old cat who had posted my first death to the gentlest desk below the world, asleep above the water where his eight lives were sewn, and a bill on him so far past anything my claws could collect that taking it out of him there would have been *bad bookkeeping*. A debt that size is not settled by making more death. It is settled the way she settled

everything: stated entire, aloud, and paid in the correct coin.

I took the red feeling home unspent. It has never entirely gone; I do not expect it to. But I came down off the sea-wall that night with my claws clean and her sequence unbroken at the head of the list. It was harder than the flats, and I have died on the flats.

Then I went and made the books say so.

* * *

The redemption of the Ninth Bell of Hollowmere took four days, one cat, two auditors, a clerk, and no miracles at all.

Four days, against a tide-table. The anchor of a seam can only be *worked* when the flats lie bare, and the flats bare only at the neap. Forty years of unpicking had kept that calendar, and the next neap stood five nights out when I filed my petition. The auditors metered the seam at every dusk and posted the finding to me without being asked: *holding; holding; holding at the anchor only*. The Court does not hurry. The Court merely does not stop. We won the race by one evening.

I petitioned as the Needle's heir. The bell had been signed out once in a century: one night, forty years ago, on the Circuit's surety, *for the great sewing*. And a surety, my grey-gloved colleagues confirmed, gleaming, confers standing on the surety's successors in the matter of the collateral. I had inherited, along with a house and a strand and a shadow full of pockets, the right to be heard on the docket of a pawned bell.

And the docket, once a profession finally located its error, was glorious. The auditors metered the vault itself, the first such audit since the pawn was struck, and the finding ran thus: the bell had been taken as *dead* collateral, a thing of bronze, valued at its metal against a plague-season's unpaid Tolls. But the bell was never dead stock. The bell held the ninth hour, every night's unrung hour pooling into it for a hundred years, unclaimed, unspent, *accruing*. And the Court's own charter, the Clerk read aloud with two inkwells going, requires accrual on held assets to be credited against the securing debt. A century of held hours, at the Court's own posted rate for time, against one plague-season of Tolls.

The debt had been paid off, by the bell itself, sometime in the reign before last. Everything since was overage. The city of Hollowmere, the finding concluded, did not owe the Hollow Court. The Hollow Court owed the city *an hour a night for a hundred years*, and the instrument of repayment was hanging in its own evidence vault, and the precedent for repaying a debt of time in light, *proved, in gold, over Gravamen*, was already on the books, because we had put it there.

And a finding is not a payment, and the Court did not want to make one.

The higher bench came up for it. I am told that has happened four times since the pawn was struck; two of those were fires. It came up with an argument that was not a quibble, and I will state it fairly, because a case you cannot state fairly is a case you have not won. A century of the Hollow Court's own holdings was to be disgorged in one night, at the Court's own posted rate, on the petition of a cat, to a city that had not asked for it. Hours are lent, and warmed, and kept against lean centuries, and every hour in that bell was already doing something. Pay this and the next claimant comes with a barrow. *The instrument is unique*, the objection ran, *but the ruling will not be*.

And it did not have to win. It only had to take four days.

My auditors could not answer it. No auditor in this world or under it prices a house against itself, and they said so, and gleamed at me apologetically for an hour.

The Clerk read the objection through twice with the lamp turned up. Then he asked the higher bench a single question, which I believe he had been holding four centuries without ever having a reason to ask it: whether the charter, on accrual, distinguished between an asset the Court found convenient and an asset it did not.

The bench asked for the clause. The Clerk had already found the clause. He read it out. It does not distinguish. It does not so much as pause.

There was a silence I would not have sat through for a fish.

"Then the Court is inconvenienced," the higher bench said, "and the Court is bound, and I would rather be the second than the first. Note my objection. Note that it was overruled on our own charter, which is the only honest way to lose. And note, Clerk, that I expect

the barrow.”

“I shall receive the barrow personally,” said the Clerk, “and I expect it will be the best evening of my death.”

Then he wrote out the finding fair, twice, and stamped it, with feeling, and rose from his desk, and took his lamp, and personally led the way down the cross-aisle to the grille on its grey ribbon.

“I have processed irregularity all my death,” he said, unlocking it. “Permit me, once, to originate some.”

They rang it that night.

Not hoisted: there was no time and no tower. The seam was down to its last threads at the anchor; the fog stood in the streets at noon; the Drowned walked the Mereside terraces in numbers the day-side could no longer unsee. The Court rang it *where it hung*, in the vault under everything, at the stroke where the ninth hour of the night had fallen silent a century ago — the Clerk’s own hand on the rope, two auditors metering, one cat present as petitioner of record —

and the Ninth Bell of Hollowmere spoke for the first time in a hundred years, down under the city, up through the stones, out through every cellar and hearthstone and bone of the town: *nine*.

I was already running for the water when the first stroke caught me. Out past the sea-wall, at the far low line of the ebb, the black flats lay shining under the fog like a spilled mirror. Out on them, small at the anchor of the world, something person-shaped stood wearing the last of my witch’s greatest seam, unpicking by the light it had paid half a century of half-seconds to reach.

It was the neap. Of course it was the neap.

* * *

Tansy was at the sea-wall stair, planted across my path, orange and entirely certain. “I am coming. I am fierce. I can bite fog.” “Mind the house, Tansy,” I said, and she turned and ran for Needle Lane as if the house were a thing that could get away.

I went out over the flats alone, on the ninth bell’s ninth stroke, and the fog opened me a lane the whole way, which I understood was not courtesy. The Mere wanted witnesses. I paid the crossing even so: the cold came up through the mirror at every second stone,

reading me, pricing me, and out in the middle of it the last of what she had put in me went, and I felt it go, and there was no more of her after that. I came off the flats slowly, on my own feet, with nothing of hers left and nothing else to spend.

The Unpicked stood at the anchor-stitch as it had stood in her parlor: unhurried, absorbed, wearing its woven habit of stolen threads, her wards, her walls, forty years of her work wound about an absence. Its hands, which I could see now as I could not in the parlor, moved on the great seam *mirror-wise*, right to left, lifting her stitches whole, in her order, run backward, each one releasing into the black water below with a sound like a word unsaid.

So that was the lamps, the night she died. He had lit the lane in mirror-order because the order is the stitch, and a round run backward is an unpicking: her ward was off that lane before he ever reached the gate. The anchor was most of the way out. Under the flats, under the glass, all the way down, the patient one lay against the underside of the world with its whole weight, no longer hoping. *Certain.*

I did not fight it. I came onto the last stretch of mirror-flat, and I sat down on the wet shining black in front of the person-shaped absence in its coat of my inheritance, in easy reach of the hands that had murdered my witch and defeated me at my own hearth, and I said what her books had taught me to say.

"The account was never closed on her side either. Not for one evening of forty years. The window was never only for me."

The hands stopped.

The flats were very quiet. The fog stood in its ring. Down under the glass, something vast recalculated.

"She wrote it," I said. "Forty years ago, the week after the water, in a box with your number on it. *He is owed — write it at the head of every page.* I have read every page. It is at the head of every page. And I am her heir, in law, adjudicated, and I have come to answer for it. Not to the lake." I looked up at where a face was not. "To you. Bodkin."

And the Unpicked came apart.

Not as a defeat. As an *undressing*. The woven habit unwound itself from the top down, thread releasing thread, her wards sighing off it into slack coils on the shining black — the garment he had

worn to do the work of a creditor, taken off, at last, because he had been called by name to a settlement, and you attend a settlement as yourself — and when it was done, standing on the flats in the ring of fog, on the last thread-bare stitches of the anchor, was a grey tom. Old. Big-boned under a coat that had seen forty years of weather. One eye. Half of one ear. The stillness of a creature that has spent a long time being exactly as visible as it chooses.

“You fight like a housecat,” he said. The voice was the alley voice, unchanged, and it broke something in me that the parlor had not managed.

“I was one.”

“Were,” he agreed. And then, for the first time in our acquaintance, he said something that was not load-bearing: “You were the only thing in that house I could not unpick. Fifteen years I watched her wind you. Nine lives, kit. Nine, on her own needle, out of her own evenings. I sat on the sea-wall and *watched the lamp burn* while she sewed you a fortune, and I told the water: you see. You see what she has. She could always make more. She only ever could not make *mine* back.”

“She could not make yours back,” I said. “That is in the box too, in her own hand, blotted. *Thread that has become stitch is not thread any more*. You have been unpicking her stitches all season and not one of them has come off the seam as a life. They come off as *slack*.” I put my paw on the coils of released warding lying dead on the black mirror between us. “Look at it. This is what the lake has been paying you in promises. Spent is spent, Bodkin. Open the seam to the bottom and your eight lives do not come out. It lied to you the way you have been not-lying to me: precisely, and to purpose.”

“To purpose,” he agreed. “Everything to purpose. All of it mine, and none of it small. Put it all on the bill.”

I put it on the bill. And then I did what a settlement requires: before anything is paid, the account is stated entire, aloud, by the party holding the pen.

“Elspeth Vane, stitcher of Hollowmere, unpicked in her own parlor at dusk. Before her, the two stitchers this city agreed to forget: the lady of the Tatterstage, who kept her seam under the greasepaint, and Widow Sarn of Hemlock Row, who sewed sails, and whose terrier waited two winters on her step. They were the only hands

left in Hollowmere that could have re-anchored the seam once it opened, and you removed them decades ahead of the need, the way a professional removes the locks before the robbery.” He did not correct me. “The lamplighters’ hall, emptied on the true word that there was work elsewhere, from the one voice that knew where elsewhere was. The roosts, drawn down over years, coat by coat, until missing looked like weather. Fenn, who walked into the fog while his lamp was still burning. The frame, hung on a hungry living neck so the Circuit would spend its season watching the living. The wisps on the lamplighters’ round, taught the route and the taste of it.

“Every tether on Needle Lane. Not frayed. Not worn through. *Cut* — clean, in order, by a hand with no right to cut. Anything in this world can fray a thread. Cutting one is a standing and not a skill, and the Weft keeps the entry of who held it, and against every one of those tethers the entry is blank. That is why her bond to me is still tied, Bodkin. You could take her wards off her own street and you could not take her hand off my neck, because the one wanted scissors and the other wanted a right, and you never had the second of those in your life.

“The cart. Driven by a day-sider whose debt you held and called — the same debtor who hauled the seed to the rooftops; one man, spent twice in one week, who scratched his own name off the consignee line at the yard before he took the reins. The Grey Boss never knew him because there was nothing to know.

“And the candle.

“She set it out for you that evening, unlit. The good beeswax, bought the week after the water and kept forty years: the light you keep against a guest you owe. I do not have to tell you what that is. You told *me* what that is, on the first night I ever spoke to you, in an alley, in the rain, when I asked what the rules were on the roofs and you said there was one. *Nobody collects off a lit candle*. Take a house’s light, or its salt, or its fire — take any of the three and you take nothing else under that roof that night. Older than the desk, you said. Older than the water. You gave me that the way you gave me your name: once, take it or leave it, and never again.

“She set out the good light for the guest she owed. You lit it yourself. You worked your hour by her hospitality, and when the work was done you pinched it out — close, old-fashioned, tidy —

because the dark was owed to the work, and the flame was owed better than burning down unattended in an emptied room. It is the first exhibit I ever pinned, and it is the only one in this file with both your hands on it: the guest's, and the collector's. And it is the one line on this bill that you cannot make me argue, because I did not bring the rule to these flats. You did. Forty years old and every hour of it paid for and one evening, by one light, in one parlour, you were a thief.

"And under the whole of it, wound small and buried deep, forty years of stolen half-seconds off the stock of every soul in the city. That is the account."

He took the whole of it standing, and he did not flinch, and at one line he stopped me.

"The hall." Quite level. "Strike it or amend it. Every soul in that hall walked out of it on his own feet. The word I gave them was true. There was work at the Gravamen yards that week and there is work there now, and men I sent are drawing wages on it tonight. I have not told a lie to a living creature in forty years and I will not be billed for one at the end."

"It is true," I said, "and it stands."

"Then you are billing me for the truth."

"I am billing you for what you did with it." I did not raise my voice; her books are clear that you do not raise your voice at a total. "You were the only creature in Hollowmere who knew where the work was, and which road ran to it, and what was standing in the fog beside that road at the hour you sent them down it. You gave forty men one true fact and kept the other one. You have spent forty years telling yourself there is a wall between those, and you have never once walked up to it and put your paw on it, because it is not there."

The one eye stayed on me. Something behind it did the arithmetic, and did not care for the answer, and did it again.

"Marrow chalks a mark on that door for every round walked while a man is out," I said. "She has been chalking your line all season. Go and read the door and then tell me what to strike."

A long moment on the black glass, with the fog standing in its ring.

"Amend it," he said at last. "Not *emptied*. *Sent*. I sent them."

"Sent," I said, and amended it, and he did not contest another

line. And I crossed a charge off my own page besides, one Merrow had laid on me at her hall door: the teacher of the wisps' route, found.

The candle was the line at which the one eye closed.

"There is a line missing," I said. "The parlor. That first night was my death too, and the Court did not post the appointment. The line for the posting hand stands blank."

"It stands blank because the hand was mine." The one eye did not move off me. "I posted it myself, kit, the gentlest slot on the whole ledger. You came through that door at me, and you were going to, whatever any soul did or said. All there was left to choose was the desk you woke at, and I chose it."

"I took the long way home."

"And the eleven minutes bought you nothing. The work was done between the boiling and the scream. Do the sum you have been refusing."

I did the sum: no route was fast enough. There was never a version of that evening with a living witch at the end of it. He had just handed me the worthlessness the way you hand a colleague an acquittal.

"Three more items," I said, "and then the bill is stated. Why arm me? You saved my life in an alley before I mattered. You taught me the paws. You gave me the counting room. You mended what my spending frayed. A forty-year professional does not spend a season sharpening the instrument of his own collection."

"Does he not," said Bodkin. The one eye went out over the water. "Forty years, kit, I was owed, and there was no desk in this world or under it where the account could be stated. She would not come to the sea-wall. I would not go to the window. The lake does not state accounts; it only buys them. And then the ninth stray came over the wall of the counting-house yard wearing her whole estate, and I understood what I had been waiting for. Not a victim. Not an avenger. An *executor*. A settlement wants a party with standing, and I built myself one: you find good stock, and you keep it alive, and you let it learn. I armed you because a collection without a stated account is only a theft, and I have never once in forty years been a thief. Whatever else you write of me, write that I paid for my own hearing."

It is the only untrue thing I ever heard him say, and he had sat through the candle a quarter of an hour before he said it. A creature does not keep one sentence in his mouth for forty years because it is accurate. He keeps it because it is the last wall in the house, and he goes on saying it after the wall is down. I did not correct him. It was on the bill already.

"Then why you at all?" I said. "That is the thing I have never been able to file. It folded Fenn away standing, with his lamp still lit beside him, a mile from the water. It walks the terraces dry-footed. A power that can do those things does not need an old cat on a sea-wall. What does it want with a *hand*?"

"Because it cannot lift a stitch." He said it the way you state a trade fact to an apprentice. "It can take, kit. Take is the only verb it owns. A stitch is not taken. A stitch is *lifted*: in its own order, backward, one at a time, by something that already knows which one comes next. Forty years that lake could have drowned every soul in this city on any tide it liked, and not one of them could have got her seam open. It did not want a servant. Servants it can have for nothing. It wanted a needle, and there were only ever two in the world, and it could not have hers."

"Then the last item. Why this year? Forty years of patience, and she dies this spring. What changed?"

"She did." It came out flat. "Forty spools of the deep silver, kit. A resurvey. Every steady needle the Circuit could lend, 'for a work of renewal, before winter.' She was going to re-found the seam: make it *hers* past dying, a working that would outlast her hands and mine. While the seam could still be opened, what I was owed had somewhere to live. That spring she priced my waiting at nothing, and never once thought of it that way, because she was minding a city, and I was a page in a forty-year-old book she wrote *owed* in every morning and never posted." The one eye came back to me. "You asked the water once what changed. Nothing changed. It finished. Everything owed finishes, kit. The whole trade of this city is deciding what it finishes *as*."

And the lake's forty years of quiet, which I had filed all season as patience, had never been patience at all. While the seam held there was nothing its money could buy; the spring the anchor began to thin was the first morning its purse meant anything, and it opened

the purse, and it has not shut it since.

"And the missing?" It came out of him fast, and I heard it for what it was: the last plank of a bridge he had been standing on for years. "The coats. The roosts. The hall I sent. I fed it *down-payments*, kit; its terms, not mine. But they are held, not spent. They went down whole. I know held from spent. I have been both. It gives them back when the seam opens. That is the contract."

"The contract," I said, "is void for fraud on the consideration. The lake cannot pay you the eight; the eight are the seam. Your refund was always going to be the city, Bodkin. Everyone's. That is all it had to sell, against the one thing it had spent forty years making sure you could never have. And you have known it all season, because you have carried the proof in your own teeth. You have never once looked at it, because grief is the one auditor that refuses its own evidence." I stood up on the black glass. "She knew. It is the last thing in the box. She could not give you your lives back, and she could not survive giving you the rest of hers, and so she did what she did with every debt she could not pay at the source. She paid it forward. Nine lives, made new, given to your kind, *whichever is dearer, mercy or justice*, and then she sat in her chair at the end of an emptied day and heard your paws on the sill, and—"

"*Don't*," said Bodkin.

"—and put the kettle on," I said. "For two."

The fog ring stood. The bell's ninth stroke was long gone but the bronze of it was still in the stones, in the water, in the pads of my feet. And the oldest professional in Hollowmere, the murderer of Elspeth Vane, sat down on the mirror-flats in front of me and said it in the alley voice, very evenly, as a man reports a position:

"She said, 'You'll take tea, then.' Forty years, and that is what she said. And I stood in her parlor with the night's work in my hands and I could not tell if it was surrender or welcome, and I have done the one thing since that I have never done in this city." The eye closed. "I did not look. Four seconds, kit. Her own rule. I did not spend four seconds looking, because if it was welcome, I could not have collected, and I had made the water a promise that could not survive her pouring the tea."

"It was both," I said. "It was her hand. You knew her hand. It was always both."

"It was always both," said Bodkin, and the last plank went out from under him, and he was only old, and grey, and one life deep, sitting on the black glass at the anchor of everything, mourning the woman he had murdered, forty years too late and one evening too early, with her heir and her kerchief three feet away and the drowned certainty of the Mere coming up under all of us.

Because it came, then. Of course it came. It had heard the settlement it could not survive.

* * *

The water did not rise; the *flats* rose, the whole mirror flexing upward like the lid of an eye. The ring of fog fell in on us from every side at once, and the Drowned came out of it arriving, all of them, a city's century of them, dry-footed on the buckling glass. Under the failing anchor the patient one put its whole weight on the last threads, no longer patient, and the seam began, stitch by stitch down its forty-year length, to *sing*: the sound her wards made dying in the parlor, scaled to a lake.

And this time the arriving was for me. I had come across with nothing left and the Mere knew it to the farthing: the nearest of the Drowned finished arriving with its hands already closed on my scruff and my haunch, and the cold of the grip was not weather but *lien*, the seizure of an asset by a creditor who has decided the account is due. I fought it. I spent the red down to the walls of me and marked its wet grey wrists and it held me the way the tide holds a stone. A second pair of hands arrived at my shoulders, and I understood that I was about to become a down-payment, and I kept talking anyway, because the estate answers, held or standing.

"It needs an anchor," I said, pinned flat on the buckling glass. "Now. A new one. Take mine: seven, banked, and a mirror-hand to sew them. It held on eight, it will hold on seven, I will argue the difference with the lake personally—"

"Spent is spent," said Bodkin.

He said it quietly, and he was standing when he said it, and everything unhurried had gone out of him except the last thing, the craftsman's thing, the thing that had pulled me out of the watch's

path and taught me the paws and mended my thread at four neaps, between audits, unthanked.

“The form’s own rule, kit. You read it in the vault — I know you read it; you are her ninth; you read everything. *An anchor wants a life that is finished paying.* The form asked for one such, forty years ago, on this water, and there was none to give, and it took eight of mine at the old exchange instead — eight unfinished for one finished; you copied the line out yourself. Yours are worse stock than mine were: new-made, and owed forward — she made them without owing, and you will not owe them to this.” He looked at the water. “Mine has been finished for forty years. I kept it back out of spite, and spite is paid off. Tonight the form gets what it asked for the first time.” And the one eye came around to me, pinned under a century of the drowned, and it had in it, at the end, the whole voice of the alley, dry, fond, appalling. “I have an appointment. First one in my life. Listen.”

Under the flats, through the stones, out of the deep vault of the city, the Ninth Bell of Hollowmere began the hour again, the ninth hour arriving on time for the first time in a hundred years, and I understood what the Court had known when it stamped my petition. The bell does not only ring hours. It rings *appointments*. A scheduled death, announced: the one kind of arithmetic that has never once failed to balance at that desk.

“Tell the Clerk,” said Bodkin, taking the needle-end of the anchor-thread up in his teeth the way she taught us both from opposite sides of one lamp, “that the walk-in apologizes for the filing.”

And the ninth stroke came down, and on it, mirror-handed, in her exact stitch run the true way round, the first familiar of Elspeth Vane sewed himself into the bottom of the world.

I will not describe the working, and not because I cannot. It was the reverse of everything the dream had kept from me at its corner: not eight drawn out of a standing shape one at a time, but one going down the needle willingly, into the seam, whole. And the seam took it, and closed, and the singing stopped, and the whole length of her forty-year working pulled taut and true from the Wickhouse shore to the far fog with a sound like a kettle coming off the fire.

The flats settled. The hands that held me opened, *released*, the way a bailiff releases goods when the ruling goes the other way, and

the Drowned, all across the mirror, stopped arriving. They stood a moment, upright, and began, one by one, unhurried to the last, to *leave*: back down into a lake that was, for the first time in a century, only water on top.

The Court's papers went through that same night; the auditors had them drawn before the bell finished striking. The contract of the down-payments: void, for fraud on the consideration. The holdings: ordered disgorged. The account of the Mere: closed to new credit for as long as the Hollow Court keeps books. The Clerk read the judgment aloud to the water from the sea-wall at the following neap, alone, by lamp, as the form requires, and the black glass lay flat and took it, the way the very old take a sentence they intend to outlive. It is down there still. It keeps accounts. Somewhere under the new-anchored seam, I do not doubt, it has already opened one on me.

And on the black glass at the anchor of everything sat one cat, with one strand of new grey stitching under his paw where an old grey tom had been.

The fog let go of the flats. The ninth hour of the night came down over Hollowmere like a lamp being turned up. And out along the sea-wall, along the Mereside terraces, up the wet steps between the houses, in their coats and their feathers and their forty kinds of silence, the missing of the city walked home.

I could hear it from the anchor. Doors going back on their hinges the whole length of the terraces, one after another, faster than anybody could have opened them on purpose. A woman out in the road in her nightdress with her hands already up. Somebody three streets over singing very badly and not stopping. And a dog that had not been let out of a house in a year getting out of it, and the noise that dog made, which I am not going to try to write down, and which I have not stopped hearing since.

Not all of them. One line belongs here, inside the joy. What the Mere *held*, the ruling pried out of it entire. What the Mere had *spent*, no ruling reaches: spent is spent; it is the law the whole night stood on, and the law does not stop being true because it is finally working for you. In the last weeks — the weeks after a cat on these flats told it no — the lake had pressed the failing seam with everything it had, and the pressing was paid for out of its freshest holdings, burned

as they were taken. Fenn was taken in those weeks. Fenn was fuel. Fenn does not walk home, that night or ever, and his lamp went on burning where he left it, and I sat on the black glass while a city came back to itself and entered the line in the ledger of my chest where it has stood ever since, at the head of my own page, under his name: *taken while I contested; spent while I filed. Put it on my bill.*

Epilogue: Nine

The city took a season to walk all the way home, and I kept the accounts, because keeping accounts is most of what we do, between meals.

The Lamplighters came back over three weeks, in ones and twos, up out of the Mereside fog in their coats, and their coats came to meet them. I watched it happen twice, and the hall that had lit lamps at its own door every night of the long silence was, both times, exactly as bright as it had promised to be. Merrow chalked no marks for the returns. The tally on the hall door was rounds completed *until they walk back in*, and they walked back in, and she washed the door herself, one bucket, no speech.

All but one of them walked back in. The new count on the washed door does not start at nothing. It starts at one, and it will end at one, and every soul in that hall knows whose one it is.

Fenn's coat hangs on its peg over his boots, and Fenn's lamp, the one that burned where he left it, stands lit at the head of his old round every night, walked out and lit and walked home again by whichever of the guild has the dusk shift, because a lamplighter's lamp does not go dark while the guild stands, and Fenn does not come home to light it.

Merrow found me on the wall opposite the hall the evening they lit his lamp the first time. She stood under me with her chalk-hands in her coat and said it straight up at the wall, in the end-of-shift voice, because she is the only creature in this city who has never once softened an account for me: "He was taken in the contested weeks, cat. The hall has done that arithmetic, same as you." And then, before I could make the entry mine alone: "The hall also walked the rounds while the seam was argued, and would again, and he would

have walked them hardest. You kept the seam. He paid on it. Both lines are true, and the hall lights his lamp on both." She went in. I sat on the wall a long time. It is the fairest bill anyone has ever served me, and I pay it every dusk, because his round runs past her window, and I keep her window, and the two of us — the lamp and I — are lit at the same hour.

The child of the sunday jacket walked home in the third week, out of the fog at the sea-wall, to the one who had waited there at every dusk. And one older coat stays on its peg besides: a fisherman's oilskin at the Wickhouse, older than living memory; the Mere's escrow reached back only so far. Nobody claims it. Nobody moves it.

The roosts of the Mereside filled. The old blind postmaster of the dead rail lived to feel the boards drum again under a hundred returning feet, and held his counter through one glorious deafening re-founding parliament, and died on his rail a month after, up to his ears in gossip, on one foot, which among the Post is dying rich. The pigeon-net carried his name the whole length of the city twice. I heard it both times and both times it was said with the feathers up.

The Mere is water. The seam is a seam still, wanting its maintenance, and maintenance is now among the duties of the estate I hold and answer for. But the fog keeps hours now. The Drowned have not been seen since the foreclosure. Day-side children have begun daring each other to swim off the sea-wall again, which the Court of Whiskers considers a deplorable development and I consider the whole point of everything.

And the city has its ninth hour back. Every night, over the roofs, the full count, one to nine, dropped into the dark like coins into a well, the ninth stroke deep and certain. And for one hour after it, an hour no living Hollowmere had ever kept before this year, the town lies open under the moon in a wash of unspent light. Nobody works the ninth hour; it will not hold a contract. People sleep differently. You can see it in their faces at the fish market: the dreams run to the end now.

The case closed the way cases close below: on paper. I attended. The Clerk read the finding into the record — the murder of Elspeth Vane, called the Needle; the murderer identified, deceased, *by appointment*; the file of the deceased murderer examined and found, after forty years of irregularity, to reconcile exactly — one life allotted at

the last, one spent, ledger closed — and he stamped it, paw print, with feeling, and then he did a thing that is not in any form. He took the thick folder marked IRREGULAR, my folder, the season's whole appalling arithmetic of refusals and mendings and walk-ins, and he retired it *unresolved* — carried it himself down the corridor of shelves to the deep stacks where the finished centuries sleep, and shelved it, and stood a moment with his hand on the ribbon.

"I do not write fiction, as a rule," he said. "But I have come to believe the rule admits of a footnote."

The cat-sized chair is still at the desk. I have no appointments posted, and a standing arrangement to take tea at the turning of each season, at which the Clerk reports, with professional disapproval and personal relish, on the continuing failure of my file to generate work. Somewhere in the deep stacks there is a second folder, a thin one, opened new this spring, and I have seen the cover, because he wanted me to see it. It says: *VANE, A. — heir. Active.*

Mistress Shear left the Circuit's candidacy and apprenticed herself, at her own petition, to Mother Cardew, who accepted her by saying that wanting it was the first qualification, and that as for the rest of it, well. The ninth seat stays empty, the Needle's seat; the Circuit has stopped speaking of filling it and speaks now of *mind*ing it.

And Cardew has taken down the two old stitcher-files.

I went to the first Circuit after the water to see it done. It is a plain room over a chandler's with a long table, bad chairs, and forty women who have all been up somebody's stairs half the night. The agenda that morning ran to nine items. Cardew did not take the agenda. She stood, which she does not do any more, and set the two files in front of her, and read out the names.

"Adela Marchmain, of the Tatterstage. Stitcher. Died the fourth of Hollowmas, forty years ago, in a fog she did not buy."

She turned the second file face up.

"Nan Sarn, of Hemlock Row. Sailmaker, stitcher, widow. Died three springs after, in her own kitchen, and her terrier sat two winters on the step, and Hemlock Row fed it where it sat."

Then she said the rest of it standing, to a room of her own juniors, with her hands flat on paper she had signed at twenty-two: that both closings were hers, and both were wrong; that the Circuit had agreed to be tired for forty years because tired was cheaper than frightened;

and that from that morning the Circuit would hear those two names first item, before the agenda, at every meeting, for as long as she has a voice to say them with.

"The agenda will keep," she said, sitting down at last. "They did not."

She has done it at every meeting since. It takes ninety seconds. Nobody has yet proposed a better use of them, and I have noticed that the juniors have stopped bringing their tea in until it is over.

Brindle fenced the gull feather from my board, at my instruction, for one button of ordinary brass, and we both recorded the transaction as *sentimental, non-precedential*. The thimble sits on her counting-board still, redeemed and un-redeemed, on permanent exhibition under the only sign in the Exchange: NOT FOR SALE. She is right about everything; it is her one flaw.

The Quiet Gentleman has not called his knot. He will. Some evening years from now, at the worst possible hour, fog-smelling paper will come under a door I am behind, and the house's price will be named, and I will pay it, because I was taught by professionals: an account is a relationship, and his is the oldest relationship this city has, and even he keeps some accounts for no reason money knows. On the anniversary of the water, every year, one vial of escrow-grade tears goes down to the tide with no name on the docket. He pays it himself, and the tide takes it, and he has never once been asked to.

Tansy can stitch.

I did not teach her; I issued no such appointment. She watched. From in front, from my lap-side, evening after evening while I maintain the estate's wards, with her chin on my foreleg and her whole absurd orange conviction fixed on the needle coming toward her. And one night in the spring I found the hem of the parlor curtain mended, badly, gloriously, in my own stitch, *run the true way round*. Mirror of a mirror. Her hand is her own entirely. She has announced that she is my apprentice; the Court of Whiskers has minuted it; I have given up litigating my own household.

The Fish-Giver feeds the strays at dawn. Eleven years, now twelve, and the widow Hake feeds his out of her rebuilt stall beside him, fiercely, interest on a loan nobody billed. He still calls me puss. Long may he.

Two entries stay open. The chest-ledger still has no sentence that

holds the woman at the window and the woman on the water; the page is still blank, and the estate has ruled it stays open — some seams are finished open. And the Remembered Day the Toll took stays taken. I keep her window every evening, and the one memory that would explain the keeping is not a place I can go and sit. The fact is mine, in my own handwriting. The warmth of it is at the Hollow Court.

And the house on Needle Lane is warm.

That is the entry I have been walking the whole ledger toward, so let me close the book properly, the way she would, with the accounts in order and the sequence minded. The threads are back on the workroom walls — not hers; hers went where they went, and the walls carry mine now, and Tansy's one glorious bad hem, and room for forty years more. The board over the mantel is empty. I unpinned it exhibit by exhibit on the night the file was retired, in reverse order of acquisition, the way you unpick a seam you are proud of, and the last thing off it was the first thing on: a candle stub, stamped with a bee, which I carried down to the tide myself.

The kettle sits on the hearthstone. It is used — Tansy takes milk warm; the Understudy was right about everything except whom the management deserved; guests come, on the ninth hour mostly, rats and birds and lamplighters and once, magnificently scandalizing the lane, a gargoyle as far as the window — and every time it boils, it boils for someone, and it has not screamed once since the night it screamed, because there is always somebody in this house to take it off the fire in time. One paw. One try, these days. Everybody knows.

I sit at her window in the evenings, on the sill, under the lamps going up one by one. Fifteen years I was the one coming home to it, and I never once saw what she was looking at, all those evenings, coming to the glass at the sound of a drainpipe. Now I keep the window and I know. The lane fills at dusk. The Lamplighters walk their order past the gate, and the third lamp goes up, then the first, then the one by the pump, a signature signed correctly on the dark. The dog at Number Twelve barks at all of it, on schedule, with his whole heart, and the roosts over the lane conduct their parliament, and somewhere under everything a desk-lamp burns over a thin active folder, and out over the chimneys the ninth bell drops its deep stroke down through the moonlight — thread that has not been used

yet, the whole sky of it, that can still become any stitch at all.

She always came to the window. I always thought it was for me.

It was for all of it. The entire salvage: every lamp, every bell, every fed stray and mended hem and small ridiculous rescued evening of this unpicked and re-sewn city — that is what stood at the glass every dusk of my life, wearing a red kerchief, counting what it held together. I know, because it is what stands here now, wearing the same one.

I am a cat somebody was expecting, once, every evening, for fifteen years.

Now I am the one expecting. The lamps are going up. The kettle is on.

Come home.

— *Ashcat, of Needle Lane*
called the Needle's heir
nine lives allotted, two spent, seven held
in trust